INTERVIEW-PREP PACKET 3 OF 5 · PER-INTERVIEWER · BUSINESS-PROCESS LENS · V2 — NINE PRIMARIES

Amazon NACF Supply Chain loop — Packet 3: Rocky Goforth

Amazon — Senior Supply Chain Manager, NACF Supply Chain (L6)

Rocky Goforth

Senior Manager, Infrastructure — NACF

Thursday, October 30, 2026 · 10:00 am PDT · 55-minute video interview

Strategy in one line. An infrastructure owner wants to know what happens when the plan meets the floor. Open with S2 (one comingle pool instead of two warehouses, a robotics ramp behind a published 98% gate that fired at 94, two go-lives with zero customer-facing incidents) and hold S18 (dual-DC WMS migration: 0.5% tolerance published before mock one, 7% → 1.8% → 0.3%, the RF-device miss owned) for the go-live-gone-wrong / Bias for Action question. Gates, invariants, triggers and hypercare numbers are the vocabulary; vendors configured, DC Ops ran the floor. **v2:** seven new primaries (U1–U7) re-cut the same Sephora node facts — matrix, profile, reserve, constraint, runbook, AFS control, issues log — each with its own math, behavioral pack, angle cards, trap drills and NACF bridge.

LP focus — my guess, not confirmed: Insist on the Highest Standards · Bias for Action · Deliver Results or Ownership. Amazon does not disclose the assignment; the guesses are reasoned from the interviewer's title and the JD in "Read me first" and should be held loosely. No interviewer biography is asserted anywhere in this packet — only title-based inference, labeled as such.

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Canon: amazon/amazon-l6-scm-master-packet.html (§1.2 roster, §4.1 ledger). Every number below is that packet's value; every dollar carries its basis label (record · user anchor · modeled · priced).

5-Minute Cram Sheet — Rocky Goforth NEW

Profile hooks (title-based inference — no biography asserted)

- **Senior Manager, Infrastructure.** Owns the physical and systems substrate: buildings, automation, WMS layer, capacity, launches, cutovers, peak readiness. His question is *what happened when the plan met the floor.*
- **His vocabulary:** dock, space, labor, throughput, node constraints, gates, rollback, freeze windows, hypercare exit — and physical truth vs system truth.
- **My moves:** open S2; name the gate that fired; put every dollar behind its basis word; end each story on one number, then one sentence to NACF inbound (doors × hours × unload rate · UPH · cube).
- **LP guess (unconfirmed):** Insist on the Highest Standards · Bias for Action · Deliver Results / Ownership — Dive Deep and Earn Trust are likely second-round.

The nine stories, in the order to reach for them

#	STORY	LPS	THE ONE NUMBER
1	**S2** · Utah DC comingle pool + robotics gate ELEVATED	Insist on the Highest Standards · Deliver · Backbone · Earn Trust	+15% processing efficiency, zero customer-facing incidents *(record)*
2	**U4** · Where the node's constraint bound NEW	Bias for Action · Frugality · Dive Deep · Earth's Best Employer	94 vs 98 → ~30% dial; ≈421 h vs ≈4,200 mis-picks *(modeled)*
3	**U5** · 343-task runbook, one irreversible instant NEW	Ownership · Deliver · Backbone · Dive Deep	343 tasks · ~815 h · 61 days; rollback never fired *(record)*
4	**S18** · WMS migration, two DCs; 0.5% tolerance ELEVATED	Ownership · Bias for Action · Learn · Insist	7.0% → 1.8% → 0.3% vs the 0.5% tolerance *(record)*
5	**U7** · 836-row log as the readiness instrument NEW	Dive Deep · Insist · Ownership · Earn Trust	441 of 836 rows Blocker/Critical; 98.0% of them closed *(record, pandas)*
6	**U1** · Node × channel × bucket-transition matrix NEW	Invent and Simplify · Dive Deep · Insist · Earn Trust	every event → exactly one bucket; Blocker + Critical open = 0 at go/no-go
7	**U3** · Merch reserve — the priced no NEW	Backbone · Customer Obsession · Earn Trust · Success & Scale	p* = 36.7% — the price of promising reserve *(modeled)*
8	**U6** · Negative AFS + the correction screen NEW	Dive Deep · Ownership · Customer Obsession · Insist	3 cause classes; negatives clean at T+1; drift 0 *(record design)*
9	**U2** · Profile both books before the design NEW	Dive Deep · Are Right · Learn · Think Big	$2.2M point → $0.74M–$2.2M range; 87% not pooling-dependent *(modeled)*

Three sentences to open with

> "At Sephora's Utah DC I turned two warehouses in one building into one comingle pool — three planning identities over one physical location — through two go-lives and a robotics ramp behind a published 98% gate: +15% processing efficiency, signed by Sephora, and zero customer-facing incidents."
>
> "The number that mattered most was 94 against 98: in week two the node's constraint moved from labor hours to pick accuracy, and a throttle DC Ops owned before the ramp bought a root-caused fix for about 421 labor hours on my model — full volume in week three."
>
> "I ran the program on one 836-row issues log, read Blocker and Critical first — 441 rows, 98% closed — and the rows where the dock, the floor, the power and the footprint were the problem each had a name and a date."

Five numbers never to get wrong

> **+15% processing efficiency · zero customer-facing incidents** — *record — Sephora-signed, DC Ops measured; the dollars are modeled*
>
> **98% gate · week 2 at 94% · ~30% throttle for a week · full volume week 3** — *record*
>
> **7.0% → 1.8% → 0.3% against the 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock one** — *record*
>
> **836 rows · 714 closed (85.4%) · Blocker 164 + Critical 277 = 441 (52.8%)** — *record; recomputed from the log with pandas*
>
> **343 tasks / 48,885 task-minutes ≈ 815 h · sync < 99% for 4 h · p95 > 2× for 1 h** — *record*

Never say: "400 devices failed" (say *hundreds of RF devices*) · "20+ systems" (say *about a dozen impacted systems*) · "fifteen tracks" (say *about thirty build tracks*) · any ratio of two modeled dollars · a fifty-times multiplier anywhere (the real figure in the loop is 9.7×, 7 → 68).

Question → Story Router NEW

How to use. Hear the question, find the LP, say the 15-second opener, land the number, then stop. Every question cites the real Amazon bank wording as *AIQB: LP Q#*. "Card" = the angle card under that story (data · conflict/influence/backbone · failure-learning). Story IDs: **S2** Utah DC comingle pool + robotics gate · **S18** WMS migration, two DCs; 0.5% tolerance · **U1** Node × channel × bucket-transition matrix · **U2** Profile both books before the design · **U3** Merch reserve — the priced no · **U4** Where the node's constraint bound · **U5** 343-task runbook, one irreversible instant · **U6** Negative AFS + the correction screen · **U7** 836-row log as the readiness instrument. Basis labels are in the story; *modeled* / *illustrative* are said as such.

LP	AIQB QUESTION (VERBATIM)	PRIMARY STORY → ANGLE	BACKUP	15-SECOND OPENER	ONE NUMBER
Customer Obsession	*Sometimes customers make unreasonable requests. Tell me about a time when you've had to push back or say no to a customer request.* **AIQB: Customer Obsession Q7**	**U3** · conflict card — visibility yes, promisability no	U6 (Q8 — a negative AFS is a promise we cannot keep)	"Merchandising wanted reserve stock promisable — it was in the building. I priced the ask: it pays only above about 37% release, so I said no and offered visibility instead."	**p* = 36.7% *(modeled)***
Ownership	*Describe a time when you didn't think you were going to meet a commitment you promised.* **AIQB: Ownership Q2**	**S18** · failure card — the RF-device test	U5 (Q4 — two go-lives and a runbook over one fast date)	"A device test I scheduled before training showed hundreds of RF devices failing the conversion script — and I had planned that task as low effort. I told leadership straight: training slips a week and a half, the date holds."	**+1.5 weeks; date held *(record)***
Invent and Simplify	*Give me an example of a complex problem you solved with a simple solution.* **AIQB: Invent and Simplify Q1**	**U1** · data card — one rule, one asset	S2 (one pool, three planning identities)	"Three node types, two channels, about a dozen systems — and one rule: every physical event maps to exactly one inventory bucket, tested cell by cell with numbers before and after."	**AFS 557, not 560 or 554 *(illustrative trace)***
Are Right, A Lot	*Tell me about a time when you didn't have enough data to make the right decision.* **AIQB: Are Right, A Lot Q1**	**U2** · failure card — the point became a range	U1 (the in-transit cells the floor taught us to add)	"The case said "pool them," and I did not have the demand profile. I profiled both books by node — overlap, order shape, variability — and turned a $2.2M textbook number into a $0.74M–$2.2M range with the measurement that would settle it."	**$0.74M–$2.2M *(modeled)*; 87% not pooling-dependent**
Learn and Be Curious	*Describe a time when you took on work outside of your comfort area. How did you identify what you needed to learn to be successful?* **AIQB: Learn and Be Curious Q2**	**S18** · Learn answer — month one on the floor	U2 (Q1 — the pooling math, learned in discovery)	"I had never run a WMS migration and had eight months. I wrote the charter in week one so the destination existed before my knowledge did, then spent month one on the floor until I could walk receive to ship unaided."	**month 1 on the floor; 7% → 1.8% → 0.3%**
Hire and Develop the Best	*Tell me about a time when you provided coaching for a team member. What started the coaching?* **AIQB: Hire and Develop the Best Q4**	**S15** bench (Josyula's primary — only if the question demands it)	U6 (four control-owner groups ran the screens without me)	"A QA lead feared compressed test windows — and she was right. I coached the frame and she wrote the definition of done; by cycle two she was defending the gate without me."	**critical defects per release −50% *(record)***
Insist on the Highest Standards	*Describe a time when you refused to compromise your standards around quality/customer service, etc.* **AIQB: Insist on the Highest Standards Q1**	**S2** · conflict card — the 98% gate	S18 (the 0.5% tolerance published before mock one)	"I published the standard before there was any pressure to waive it: a 98% pick-accuracy gate and a throttle dial DC Ops owned. Week two read 94, so the gate fired — bots to about 30% for a week, full volume in week three."	**98 → 94 → ~30% → full volume wk 3 *(record)***
Think Big	*Tell me about time when you were working on an initiative or goal and saw an opportunity to do something much bigger or better than the initial focus.* **AIQB: Think Big Q1**	**U2** · Think Big answer — two pools to one	S2 (the one-omni-facility ask)	"The ask was a number on pooling; the bigger prize was one physical pool with three planning identities — each channel kept its forecasting lens, and the self-transfers went to zero by construction."	**2 pools → 1; ≈260K units/yr self-transfers → 0 *(illustrative volume)***
Bias for Action	*Give me an example of a calculated risk that you have taken where speed was critical.* **AIQB: Bias for Action Q1**	**U4** · data card — the dial fires	S2 (the throttle decision)	"Week two of the robotics ramp read 94 against a published 98. The dial was built in advance and DC Ops owned it, so we throttled to about 30% that same week and root-caused the zone and slotting logic."	**94 vs 98 → ~30% → full volume wk 3 *(record)***
Frugality	*Give me an example of how you have helped save costs or eliminate waste within your role or organization.* **AIQB: Frugality Q1**	**S2** · data card — duplicate handling removed	U4 (Q4 — priced both sides of the throttle)	"Two warehouses in one building were transferring stock to themselves and paying duplicate handling for zero customer value. One comingle pool removed that cost, and DC Ops measured +15% processing efficiency."	**+15% *(record)*; ≈$1.6M/yr *(modeled)***
Earn Trust	*Tell me about a time when you had to communicate a change in direction that you anticipated people would have concerns with.* **AIQB: Earn Trust Q1**	**S2** · conflict card — Digital's concern became the design	U7 (Q6 — the worst number in the room was mine to say)	"Digital worried a virtual Retail DC would blur their forecasting lens, and they were right to. I did not argue them out of it — I made the concern the design: three planning identities over one physical location."	**3 identities, 1 location; 60+ stakeholders**
Dive Deep	*Tell me about a situation that required you to dig deep to get to the root cause.* **AIQB: Dive Deep Q2**	**U6** · data card — a negative has three causes	U7 (the log, three cuts) · U2 (the profile)	"A negative AFS is not one problem. I decomposed it to three cause classes — a duplicate event, a feed that had not caught up, an override — each with an owner, and every AFS-changing act got a screen, a role and an audit row."	**3 cause classes; drift 0 on consecutive days *(record)***
Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit	*Describe a time when you took an unpopular stance in a meeting with peers and your leader.* **AIQB: Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit Q2**	**S2** · conflict card — two go-lives, not one	U5 (Q5 — no UAT compression after the Locus RTL slipped three weeks)	"The prevailing instinct was one go-live, one date. I challenged it: one go-live puts a reserve-rule defect and a floor defect in the same room the same week — so January proved the rules and May moved the floor."	**2 go-lives, 1 defect class each**
Deliver Results	*Give me an example of a time when you were able to deliver an important project under a tight deadline.* **AIQB: Deliver Results Q1**	**U5** · Deliver answer — 61 days, peak untouched	S18 (eight months, ~3% under) · S2 (Q3, +15% signed)	"The window was 61 days, May 1 to July 1, with the Oct–Dec peak freeze behind it — so I wrote the cutover as 343 owned tasks, about 815 hours, each with a predecessor, and the two go-lives landed on their dates."	**343 tasks · ~815 h · 61 days *(record)***
Strive to Be Earth's Best Employer	*Describe a time when you implemented a change at work aimed at improving the work experience of yourself or coworkers.* **AIQB: Strive to Be Earth's Best Employer Q3**	**U4** · Employer answer — the stop condition belongs to the floor	S15 bench (QA lead elevated, not blamed — Josyula's)	"The floor was the one place a bad ramp would land. I wrote the gate and the dial before the robots arrived and DC Ops owned them — so when week two read 94, the stop condition belonged to the people who carry the consequence."	**dial owned by DC Ops before the ramp; ~30% for one week**

LP	AIQB QUESTION (VERBATIM)	PRIMARY STORY → ANGLE	BACKUP	15-SECOND OPENER	ONE NUMBER
Success and Scale Bring Broad Responsibility	*Tell me about a time when you considered everyone who was affected by your work, not just your direct customers or people within your organization.* **AIQB: Success and Scale Bring Broad Responsibility Q5**	**U3** · Success & Scale answer — a broken promise is a defect	U6 (the screens and owners that keep a promise true)	"An oversell looks like a ledger error to a planner and a broken promise to a customer. At an illustrative thirty million orders a year that is thirty thousand customers, so I treated it as a defect with an owner and a screen."	**30,000 customers/yr *(illustrative)* → zero incidents *(record)***

THE ELEVEN NON-LP PROMPTS — SAME GRID NEW

PROMPT	PRIMARY → ANGLE	BACKUP	15-SECOND OPENER	ONE NUMBER
"Tell me about a time you failed."	**S18** failure card (Apple G2)	U6 · U5 failure cards	"The RF-device test failed before training; I had planned it low-effort, I said so the same day, and I now give every single-point dependency a what-if plan."	**+1.5 wk; date held**
"Disagreed with your manager."	**S2** two go-lives (conflict card)	U5 no UAT compression	"The instinct was one go-live; I put the two-defect-class argument in front of leadership and we staged it."	**2 go-lives, 1 class each**
"Influence without authority."	**S2** · 60+ stakeholders	U3 · U6 (owners I did not manage)	"None of the systems reported to me; I owned the model, the gates and the signature chain, and made the concern the design."	**60+ stakeholders**
"Reduced cost."	**S2** · +15%, self-transfers gone	U4 priced the throttle	"One pool instead of two removed duplicate handling; the +15% is signed, the ≈$1.6M a year is my model."	**+15% record; ≈$1.6M/yr modeled**
"Dealt with ambiguity."	**U2** · profile first	S18 charter in week one	"Two books, two warehouses and no agreed model — I profiled SKU overlap, order shape and variability before anyone argued design."	**9.9%–29.3% release**
"Simplified a process."	**U1** · one rule, one asset	S2 · U7 one grammar	"Every event maps to exactly one bucket, and no story entered QA without a cell reference."	**557, not 560 / 554**
"Decision with incomplete data."	**U3** · the break-even	U2 bounded range	"I could not know the release rate, so I priced the decision at the rate where it flips."	**p* = 36.7%**
"Missed a deadline."	**U5** · Locus RTL +3 weeks	S18 training +1.5 wk	"A vendor slipped three weeks; I escalated the week it surfaced, re-slotted openly and refused to compress UAT."	**3 wk slip; UAT intact**
"Mentored someone."	**S15** bench (Josyula's)	U6 control-owner handoff	"I coached the frame, the QA lead owned the gate, and she defended it without me."	**−50% critical defects**
"Tight timeline."	**U5** · 61 days	S18 · eight months	"343 tasks, about 815 hours, every one with an owner and a predecessor."	**61 days**
"Changed your mind with data."	**U2** · $2.2M point → range	U4 constraint moved	"I had carried the textbook pooling number; the overlap and correlation tests said carry a range with a kill number."	**$0.74M–$2.2M**

Spend rule. One question, one story. If an LP is asked twice, move to the named backup, not a story allocated to another interviewer. S15 is Josyula's primary — use it only if the question demands it and keep every fact identical to his packet. Real failure chapters (Apple G1/G2/G3) are the source for every failure/learning angle; none is invented.

Read me first

The interviewer's lens (inference from title + JD — not a biography)

Inference from the title. "Infrastructure" in a fulfillment network means the physical and systems substrate the process runs on — buildings, automation and robotics, the WMS/WCS layer, capacity and launches, cutovers and peak readiness. A Senior Manager there is accountable for changes that touch the floor: go-lives that cannot drop a shipment, automation ramps that must not erode throughput, and migrations where inventory accuracy cannot wobble. He will care about gates, rollback, freeze windows, hypercare exits, and what happened when the plan met the floor.

What that means for the answers. The two Sephora distribution-center programs: S2 (two systemic warehouses in one building consolidated into one comingle pool, with a WMS upgrade and a robotics ramp on the same critical path and zero customer-facing incidents allowed) and S18 (a dual-DC legacy-WMS migration run to a 0.5% reconciliation tolerance published before the first mock, with the RF-device miss owned). Tell them as Make/Deliver process redesigns — one inventory pool instead of two, a cutover discipline instead of a date — with asset utilization (+15% processing efficiency, labor-hours, capital pooled) and reliability (zero incidents, 0.3% against 0.5%) as the results. The vendor teams configured BlueYonder and Locus; DC Ops ran the floor; I owned the model, the staging, the gates and the go/no-go.

Three guessed LP focus areas, with rationale

> **Labeled guess.** Amazon assigns 2–3 Leadership Principles per interviewer and does not disclose them. These three are inferred from the title and the JD; if the first question lands on a different LP, the twist maps under each story carry the pivot.

GUESSED LP	WHY THIS INTERVIEWER WOULD CARRY IT	STORY TO OPEN · BACKUP
Insist on the Highest Standards	Infrastructure owners live by gates that can stop the program: the 98% robotics gate that fired at 94 (S2) and the 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock one (S18) are the primary and backup for this LP in the master map.	S2 (open) · S18 (backup)
Bias for Action	When the floor breaks the plan — hundreds of RF devices failing the conversion script in a pre-training device test — he wants to see a decision taken the same day, the cost priced and the date held.	S18 (the device-test miss) · S2 (the throttle to ~30%)
Deliver Results / Ownership (one of the two)	Two go-lives, peak untouched, +15% signed by DC Ops; an eight-month migration on time and ~3% under budget with a $20M pipeline unblocked. Ownership shows in the RF miss carried with my name on the cause.	S2 (the comingle launch) · S18 (8 months, both DCs)

Answer strategy — business first, systems as enablers

- **Open with the process problem and its cost, not the system.** First sentence names the broken process (Plan, Source, Make, Deliver or Return), who it hurt (customer, Finance, the floor) and the baseline number. The platform appears only as the enabler of the redesign, in one clause.
- **Use the JD's four outcome words as the results frame:** reliability (did the promise hold?), responsiveness (how much earlier did we see it?), cost efficiency ($ with its basis label), asset utilization (capital, labor-hours, capacity released).
- **Action = operating-model redesign in gated phases** — Discovery → Plan & Design → Build & Test → Cutover → Hypercare, each spoken as entry bar · what I delivered · exit bar. Say the gate that fired, not the meeting that happened.
- **Every dollar carries its basis word in the same breath** — record · user anchor · modeled · priced. A record dollar is said flat; a modeled dollar is said with its inputs. Never promote a modeled number to record.
- **Program-lead voice.** I owned definitions, rules, gates and the signature chain; engineers, SIs and vendor teams configured and built to the spec I signed. The only platform personally configured in canon is Manhattan DOM.
- **The pitch ends on the primary metric.** Then stop. Silence after the pitch is the interviewer filling their STAR worksheet; their probes are the second half of the answer.
- **For Infrastructure specifically:** speak in gates, invariants and triggers — the published ramp gate and the throttle built in advance; the six cutover invariants (Σ AFS conserved; no SKU sellable in two places; negatives cleared first); rollback triggers as numbers (sync < 99% for 4 h; p95 > 2× for 1 h); hypercare exit as a number (< 2 blockers/day sustained). A gate that cannot stop the program is decoration.
- **Asset utilization is the result frame:** +15% units per labor-hour (signed), one pool instead of two (√2 pooling, modeled and labeled), self-transfers inside one roof eliminated, robotics at full volume by week three, $20M of pipeline unblocked on the date.

Loop-consistency rule. One question, one story; never the same story to two interviewers — interviewers compare notes. Held for other packets (do not spend here): S11/S12 (Tripathy) · S6/S8 (Hoerger) · S1/S3 (Lan) · S16/S15/S10/S14 (Josyula). **v2 overlap:** U1, U3 and U6 re-cut the AFS, merch-reserve and bucket-matrix facts that sit in Lan's S1 — the numbers are identical in both packets; answer from U1/U3/U6 only when the question is about the building, and say the program is the same. S5 (the architecture council) shares the UDC program's dated chain with S2 — Lan's backup pointer, not yours; S2 and S1 share program-level artifacts (issues log, rollback triggers) — if asked, say so.. If pushed for "another example" on an LP, use the named backup in the question bank or the backup bench at the end of this packet, never a story allocated to another interviewer.

How to read the "L6 level evidence" block under each story. Amazon's L6 functional bar (user-supplied rubric): *Ambiguity* — strategy or network undefined; I select the stakeholders, set the goals, deliver independently. *Scope & influence* — team-level scope; influences one to two levels up. *Execution* — tactical and strategic; simplifies or extends; applies best practices; force-multiplies; mitigates long-term risk; makes the short-versus-long-term trade-off explicit. *Impact* — long-term team goals. *Process improvement* — operational-excellence best practices institutionalized. *Complex* — visible risks, roadblocks and constraints mitigated through expertise, judgment and influence to consensus. Overview themes the block is tuned to: designing and modeling the supply chain rather than working in it; developing new processes for others to own; root-cause mechanisms that resolve trending issues at scale; recommendations to leadership that outline competing metrics. The block sits right after Results so the evidence is on the page when the probing starts.

NACF inbound bridge — one whiteboard for nine stories NEW

Every story ends with one sentence that lands on NACF. The sentence rides on the inbound booklet's frames — CAP-A doors, CAP-B UPH, CAP-C cube, CAP-D dwell, CAP-E peak buffer, INV-D transfer break-even — on the booklet's own illustrative FC (120,000 units a day). Draw this chain first, then say which link the story's constraint lives in.

FRAME	LINK	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
A	Doors	`120,000 ÷ 6 ÷ 40 = 500 pallets; ÷ 26 = 19.2 trailers/day; ÷ 10 h = 1.92/h; ÷ 0.5 trailer per door-hour = 3.84 doors; ÷ 0.85 = 4.5`	booklet CAP-A · illustrative FC	**5 doors**
B	UPH labor	`120,000 ÷ 300 = 400 h; × 1.15 = 460 paid h; 0.7 × 300 + 0.3 × 180 = 264 blended; 120,000 ÷ 264 = 454.5 h`	booklet CAP-B · 300 UPH, 60% learning curve illustrative	**+13.6% hours**
C	Cube	`2,000,000 × 0.25 = 500,000 ft³; 1,200,000 × 0.85 = 1,020,000 effective; 500,000 ÷ 1,020,000`	booklet CAP-C · 0.25 ft³/unit illustrative	**49.0% true use**
D	Dwell	`2.0 ÷ (1 − 0.85) = 13.3 h; 2.0 ÷ (1 − 0.95) = 40.0 h; 40.0 ÷ 13.3 = 3.0×`	booklet CAP-D · qualitative queueing approximation	**85% → 95% ≈ 3× dwell**
E	Peak buffer	`156,000 ÷ 264 = 591 h; 591 − 454.5 = 136 h; ÷ 10 = 13.6`	booklet CAP-E · p90 156,000 illustrative	**≈14 flex heads**
D′	INV-D	`$3.00 ÷ $12 = 0.25 — transfer when stockout probability > 25%`	booklet INV-D · $3.00 transfer, $12 margin illustrative	**p* = 25%**

STORY → FRAME → THE QUESTION I WOULD ASK AT NACF

STORY	WHAT THE NODE TAUGHT	THE NACF SENTENCE	FRAME
S2	A published ramp gate and a dial the floor owns (94 vs 98 → ~30%).	Which link binds this week at a new FC — doors at the 85% line, UPH after the learning-curve tax, or cube at 49% effective — and who owns the stop?	A · B · C
S18	Tolerance published before mock one; a freeze sized to the longest lane; a what-if for the single-point dependency.	Publish the receipt-reconciliation tolerance before the first mock; hold 5 planned doors against 3.84 raw — about 1.2 doors of slack — so a day-one surprise does not move the date.	A · D
U1	Every event lands in exactly one bucket; zero or two is a defect.	"Stranded" inventory is an event that landed in zero states. Build the receive → stow → sellable event matrix before an FC ramps.	booklet "stranded"
U2	Profile overlap, order shape and correlation before pooling is claimed.	Do two FCs carry the same ASINs and see the same demand? Pooling pays only at low correlation; the physical move is INV-D — transfer when p > 25%.	INV-D
U3	Merch reserve is in the building and not promisable; p* = cost ÷ (gain + cost).	Promise pickable, not received. Same break-even shape as INV-D (3 ÷ 12); 10,000 reserved units at 0.25 ft³ hold 2,500 ft³ of the 1,020,000 effective.	C · D′
U4	The constraint moved from labor hours to accuracy; the throttle cost ≈421 h.	421 h is about 10.5 people for a week against CAP-B's 13.6% learning tax and CAP-E's ~14 flex heads — name the binding resource first.	B · E
U5	One irreversible instant; stop conditions written as numbers before the first task.	The first live inbound appointment is the irreversible instant; the 85% door ceiling is the slack that absorbs a re-pointed or late trailer.	A · D
U6	A negative AFS decomposes to duplicate event, feed latency, override.	Committed units above what the building can back: a double receive scan, dock-to-stock lag, a manual adjustment — zero-tolerance reconciliation of dock-received vs system-available.	D
U7	The issues log read severity-first, with the dock, power and footprint rows named.	Launch register with the dock row at the top: appointments, placards, pallet-build positions; a SKU with no footprint defaults a slot, which is wasted cube at the 85% line.	A · C

All booklet inputs are the booklet's own illustrative FC; nothing here is a Sephora figure. The people-week conversion assumes a 40-hour week (421 ÷ 40 = 10.5).

The stories — business-first, canon numbers

Nine primaries on the Sephora distribution-center work: S2 and S18 (elevated) and seven new cuts of the same node facts, U1–U7. Each: 60-second pitch → Situation/Task → Action in gated phases → Results → L6 evidence → five facets and probing → the four-table math → Twist map → behavioral pack, angle cards, trap drills, 20-second version and NACF bridge.

S2 — Sephora Utah DC — two systemic warehouses in one building → one comingle pool, coupled with a WMS upgrade and a robotics ramp behind a published gate (+15% processing efficiency, zero customer-facing incidents) ELEVATED

LPs this story can serve here: Insist on the Highest Standards (primary — the 98% gate that fired at 94) · Deliver Results (two go-lives, peak untouched) · Have Backbone (the throttle) · Strive to be Earth's Best Employer (the floor protected during the ramp) · Bias for Action (the throttle decision the week the gate failed)
Process family: Make / Deliver — DC operating model (one inventory pool, three planning identities), automation ramp governance, staged go-lives, cutover runbook, hypercare exit

Honesty label. I owned discovery through FSD for the location and inventory model, the staging and the gates; BlueYonder, Locus and the platform teams built and configured; DC Ops ran the floor and measured the +15% post-stabilization. The +15% is Sephora's signed number; every dollar is my model on an illustrative 100K-units/week DC. Program-level artifacts (dated gate chain, 836-row issues log, rollback triggers) are shared with S1/S5 — one umbrella program.

LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES CARRIED — ONE-LINE PROOF EACH

Insist on the Highest Standards. I published the robotics gate — 98% pick-accurate — before the robots arrived; when week two read 94 it fired and the bots went to ~30% for a week.

Deliver Results. Two go-lives on their dates, each carrying one defect class, peak untouched, zero customer-facing incidents and +15% processing efficiency signed by Sephora.

Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit. I challenged the single-go-live instinct and held the comingle-reserve improvements out of the release to protect zero incidents — priced as a later enhancement.

Strive to be Earth's Best Employer. The throttle and the DC-Ops-owned dial protected the floor's throughput during the ramp; the interim reporting burden was named as the price. No headcount or attrition number is claimed.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Sephora's Utah DC ran as two systemic warehouses in one building — Dotcom 801 and Retail 901 — transferring stock to itself and paying duplicate handling for zero customer value. The ask was one omni comingle facility, with a BlueYonder WMS upgrade and Locus robotics on the same critical path, an October–December peak freeze, about a dozen impacted systems, 60+ stakeholders, and zero customer-facing incidents allowed. **Task.** I owned discovery through the signed design for the location and inventory model, the staging and the acceptance gates. **Action.** I redesigned the operating model as one physical pool with three planning identities, so each channel kept its forecasting lens without a second truth; split the program into two go-lives so each carried one defect class — January proved reserve rules against live demand with the floor untouched, May moved warehouse execution; published the robotics gate at 98% pick-accurate throughput with the throttle dial built in advance and owned by DC Ops; ran three mock cutovers against the 0.5% tolerance and a 343-task runbook whose one irreversible instant was zero-then-publish, so nothing was sellable in two places. When week two of the robotics ramp hit 94 against 98, the gate fired: bots throttled to about 30% of volume for a week, zone and slotting logic root-caused, full volume week three. **Result.** Primary metric: DC processing efficiency — baseline index 100 → 115, +15%, Sephora-signed, measured by DC Ops post-stabilization; zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives; rollback armed twice, never fired. About $1.6M a year modeled — labor at +15%, pooling carry, fewer split shipments, self-transfer handling removed — and about $2.2M of one-time safety stock released by pooling, also modeled; the +15% and the zero are the record.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — The Utah DC ran as two systemic warehouses — Dotcom 801 (selling location 800) and Retail 901 — transferring stock to itself and paying duplicate handling for zero customer value. The ask: one omni/comingle facility, with a BlueYonder WMS 8.2 → 2023.1 upgrade and Locus robotics on the same critical path, about a dozen impacted systems, an Oct–Dec peak freeze, zero customer-facing incidents allowed.

The challenges sat on the critical path itself: the WMS upgrade and the robotics ramp shared it, the peak freeze bounded it, and the interim would run two live truths. The register's top three risks — two live truths during the interim, a robotics ramp with no stop condition, and a peak collision — each had a trigger, a mitigation and an owner before sign-off.

T — Discovery through FSD for the location and inventory model, the staging and the acceptance gates; 60+ stakeholders (~80 names across ~15 functions) on the steering path; none of the systems reported to me.

Baselines on the table: processing efficiency index 100 (units per labor-hour) · customer-facing incidents allowed: 0 · robotics gate 98% published in advance from the pre-ramp baseline and the incident budget · self-transfers and duplicate handling — the standing cost one pool exists to remove.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (3/29 → 4/30)** — profiled 801/901 (SKU overlap, order profiles); sponsor objectives and success criteria — one omni facility, self-transfers eliminated, zero customer-facing incidents, peak untouched; systems-impacted table. *Exit bar:* every impacted system named to an owner with a written LOE (landed 7/2); criteria signed by steering.
- **Plan & Design (5/15 → 8/14)** — council pack (three decisions + an out-of-scope fence); the 900/901 location/inventory model with three planning identities over one physical location; staged two-go-live timeline; RAID log; FSD 8/14. *Exit bar:* council sign-off 7/31; FSD 8/14; peak-freeze boundary decided; LOE-backed plan across ~30 build tracks.
- **Build & Test (Aug → Jan/Apr)** — node × channel × bucket-transition matrix as the regression asset; dated E2E days — Inbound 11/22, Dotcom 12/20, Retail 1/30 — every function in one room; Locus gate definition (98%) with the throttle spec; three mock cutovers against the 0.5% tolerance (the S18 discipline reused); the Locus RTL slipped three weeks — escalated the week it surfaced, re-slotted openly, UAT not compressed to absorb it. *Exit bar:* E2E green on three dates; Blocker + Critical open = 0 at each go/no-go; mock 3 inside tolerance.
- **Cutover & Go-Live (January; May 1 → Jul 1)** — runbook of 343 tasks / ~815 hours, each with owner, duration and predecessor; six-step May choreography — clear negatives, transfer AFS to Uncommitted, scan-and-reserve, zero-then-publish; rollback triggers per interface (sync < 99% for 4 h; order-flow p95 > 2× budget for 1 h). *Exit bar:* six invariants held (Σ AFS conserved; no SKU sellable on 800 and 900 at once; negatives cleared first); rollback never fired.
- **Hypercare / Close (Jun → Jul)** — monthly arc of new issue rows 271 → 65 → 21 → 14 → 4 (June → October); Locus weekly gate read — week 2 at 94 vs 98 → throttle to ~30% → RCA (zone/slotting logic) → full volume week 3; hypercare exit memo; template handed to the next DC. *Exit bar:* < 2 blockers/day sustained → exit week 3 of 4; +15% measured post-stabilization by DC Ops.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the location/inventory model, the staging, the gates, the council pack, the runbook and the go/no-go recommendation. BlueYonder, Locus and the platform teams built and configured; DC Ops ran the floor, owned the robotics gate and the dial before the ramp — so when it fired, the rule fired; I did not improvise. Digital worried a virtual Retail DC would blur their forecasting lens — the three-identity design made the concern the design rather than an argument. The comingle-reserve improvements were held out of the release to protect zero incidents, priced as a later enhancement at steering.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** I designed the location/inventory model, the gates and the throttle dial; DC Ops owned the dial before the ramp and runs the floor on it, and the hypercare template went to the next program. **Trade-off put to leadership.** The recommendation to leadership outlined the competing metrics — +15% processing efficiency and the robotics ramp vs zero customer-facing incidents and peak untouched — and made the gate (98%) and the throttle (~30%) the published answer before the robots arrived.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY (CANON NUMBERS ONLY)

- **$** — ≈$1.6M/yr *modeled* (labor at +15% ≈$0.88M · pooling carry ≈$0.22M · fewer split shipments ≈$0.45M · self-transfer handling ≈$0.10M) + ≈$2.2M one-time safety-stock release *modeled* via √2 pooling; the +15% is Sephora's signed number; every dollar is my model on an illustrative 100K-units/week DC (range $1.1–2.4M/yr).
- **#** — cutover runbook 343 tasks / 48,885 task-minutes ≈ 815 hrs; issues log 836 rows / 85.4% closed; monthly new-row arc 271 → 65 → 21 → 14 → 4 (record, from the log).
- **%** — processing efficiency +15% (record, Sephora-signed); robotics gate 98%, week 2 at 94, bots throttled to ~30% of volume for a week, full volume week 3 (record).
- **Time** — council 5/15 → sign-off 7/31 → FSD 8/14; E2E 11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30; January and May go-lives; hypercare exited week 3 of 4 (record).
- **Customer** — zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives (record) — the constraint every other number moved inside.
- **Quality** — six cutover invariants held; rollback armed for both go-lives, never fired; peak untouched (record).

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — what the interviewer pattern-matches against the Amazon L6 functional rubric; every line is this story's canon, no new numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	Two systemic warehouses in one building and no agreed operating model. I owned the location/inventory model (three planning identities over one physical location), the staging and the gates, and set the success criteria with the sponsor — one omni facility, self-transfers eliminated, zero customer-facing incidents, peak untouched.
Scope & influence	BlueYonder, Locus and the platform teams built and configured; DC Ops ran the floor and owned the robotics gate and the dial; the go/no-go recommendation was mine to leadership — influence across about a dozen impacted systems and 60+ stakeholders I did not manage.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others now own	Robotics throughput vs floor stability: the 98% gate fired at 94 in week 2, bots throttled to ~30% for a week, full volume week 3. Mechanism others own now: the dial, owned by DC Ops before the ramp, and the hypercare template handed to the next program.
Impact (long-term)	Processing efficiency +15% (Sephora-signed); zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives; ≈$1.6M/yr modeled plus ≈$2.2M one-time modeled; peak untouched.
Process improvement (standard work institutionalized)	The node × channel × bucket-transition matrix as the regression asset; a runbook of 343 tasks / ~815 hours with owner, duration and predecessor; six cutover invariants; a monthly new-row arc 271 → 4.
Complexity & consensus	Staged two go-lives (January planning / May execution) so each carried one defect class; a peak-freeze boundary; dated E2E days (11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30) with every function in one room.
Root cause at scale	The week-2 robotics miss was root-caused to zone/slotting logic and fixed before full volume — the rule fired, the cause was removed, the ramp was not pushed through.

PROBING — FIVE FACETS, THEN THE HARDEST FOLLOW-UPS NEW

THE FIVE FACETS — WHERE EACH ONE LIVES IN THIS STORY

1 · Data analysis. Grain: node × week × bot share; SKU × pool. Data: both books profiled in discovery (U2), labor hours, picks attempted/accurate, the 836-row issues log, the 343-task runbook. Cuts: accuracy by week; new rows by month (271 → 4). Revealed: the week-2 miss was zone/slotting logic, and the case rested on recurring rows more than on pooling.

2 · Solution design. Options: (A) keep two warehouses and reconcile; (B) one pool, one blended planning lens; (C) one physical pool, three planning identities (chosen); and a staging choice — one go-live vs two (chosen: two, each carrying one defect class). Why: C keeps Digital's forecasting lens without a second truth; two go-lives keep diagnosis univariate.

3 · Math & data logic. +15% → hours 240,000 / 1.15 = 208,700 (−13.0%); pooling 1 − 1/√2 = 29.3% on $7.5M → $2.2M (bounded in U2); gate T = accurate ÷ attempted ≥ 98%; throttle 100% → 30% (bounded in U4); AFS conserved (U5).

4 · Implementation. Five gated phases (3/29 → 4/30 → 5/15 → 7/31 → 8/14 → E2E 11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30 → January → May 1 → Jul 1 → hypercare); owners: me (model, staging, gates, go/no-go), BlueYonder/Locus/platform (build), DC Ops (floor, gate, dial). Controls: Blocker + Critical = 0, mock 3 ≤ 0.5%, rollback triggers.

5 · Probe questions. The six answered above in the Probing block; the zoom-ins that stand alone are U1 (matrix), U2 (profile), U3 (reserve), U4 (capacity), U5 (runbook), U6 (negatives).

FACET 5 — PROBE QUESTIONS (CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER)

Infra — Why 98%, and what did you actually do at 94?

98% was set from the pre-ramp baseline and the incident budget before the event, and DC Ops owned it. At 94 in week two I throttled the bots to about 30% of volume for a week, root-caused the zone and slotting logic, and ramped again — full volume by week three. A gate that cannot stop the program is decoration; mine did.

Infra — Why two go-lives instead of one big one?

So we never hunted two defect classes in the same week. January proved reserve rules against live demand while the floor was untouched; May left warehouse execution as the only remaining class. One go-live would have put a reserve defect and a floor defect in the same room.

Infra — What made you say go in May?

Counted rows, not the room: Blocker + Critical at zero, mock 3 inside the 0.5% tolerance, the 343-task runbook rehearsed, rollback armed per interface. I would have said no-go on one open Blocker; I never had to.

Infra — What were the rollback triggers and did any fire?

Sync below 99% for four consecutive hours, or order-flow p95 above twice budget for one hour — rollback per interface behind them. Armed for both go-lives; never fired. The one irreversible instant was step 4, zero-then-publish, so no SKU was ever sellable in two places.

Infra — The labor number is the biggest piece of your $1.6M. How firm?

The fifteen percent is measured and signed; the 120 FTE and the $28 loaded rate are my assumptions. Pull the DC's direct hours for the two quarters before and after and multiply by payroll — that turns the model into a record in an afternoon. If the split-shipment row didn't move, the total is about $1.1M.

> **Infra — What would you do differently?**
> Staff the interim reporting workstream on day one, not month three — for four months every report had to declare which system of record it read. And the Locus slip: escalated the week it surfaced, but I would have put the RTL on the register as a risk, not a task, from the start.

THE MATH — FOUR-TABLE DERIVATION (FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION → RESULT) NEW

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Two warehouses in one building	`planning pools = 2 (801 retail + 800 dotcom)`	two planning identities over one roof (record)	2 pools
2	Baseline efficiency	`index = 100 units per labor-hour`	pre-UDC baseline (record)	100
3	Direct labor to run it	`120 FTE × 2,000 h/yr = 240,000 h/yr`	modeled staffing on an illustrative 100K-units/week DC	240,000 h/yr
4	Self-transfers inside one roof	`≈260,000 units/yr moved on paper between 801 and 800`	modeled	260K units/yr of non-work
5	Duplicated safety stock	`$50M × 25% = $12.5M SS; $12.5M × 60% = $7.5M`	avg inventory (illustrative) × SS share × share held in SKUs both pools carry	$7.5M duplicated poolable SS
6	Split shipments	`4,500,000 orders × 1 pt = 45,000 extra splits/yr`	~4.5M dotcom orders/yr; split rate 1 pt above the comingled state (modeled)	45,000 splits/yr

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	One pool, three planning identities	`900/901 model → self-transfers = 0 by construction`	three planning identities over one physical location (record design)	the move is a posting, not a truck
2	Robotics gate (published first)	`T = pick-accurate completed / attempted ≥ 98%`	gate published before the ramp (record)	the dial was built in advance
3	Gate evaluated, week 2	`T = 94%; 94 < 98 → gate failed by 4 pts`	record	throttle fires
4	Throttle	`bot share 100% → 30%; manual covers (1 − 0.30) × 100,000 = 70,000 units/wk`	volume illustrative	RCA, then ramp again — full volume week 3 (record)
5	Efficiency after	`index 100 × 1.15 = 115`	+15% (record, Sephora signed, post-stabilization)	115
6	Hours for the same volume	`240,000 / 1.15 = 208,696 ≈ 208,700 h/yr`	Table 1 row 3 and the +15%	≈208,700 h/yr
7	Hours saved	`240,000 − 208,700 = 31,300; 31,300 / 240,000 = 13.0%`	arithmetic on the two rows above	31,300 h/yr = 13.0%
8	Pooling (2 equal pools → 1)	`factor = 1 − 1/√2 = 1 − 0.707 = 0.293; $7.5M × 0.293 = $2.2M`	√2 pooling (toolkit label; ceiling — bounded in U2)	≈$2.2M one-time
9	Zero-incident fence	`two staged go-lives — one defect class live at a time`	customer-facing incidents allowed: 0 (record constraint)	0 incidents through both

Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

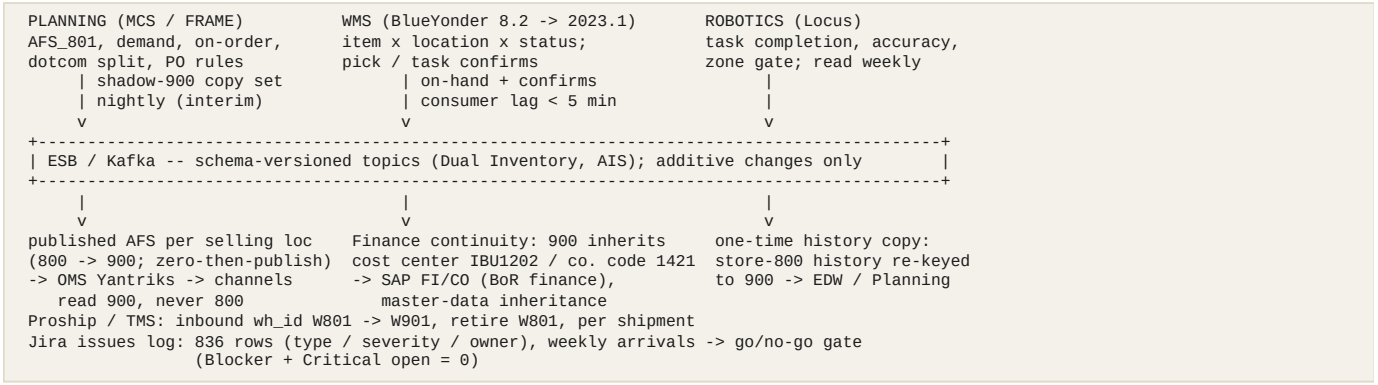
STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Processing efficiency (units/labor-hour)	index 100	115	record (Sephora signed)
2	Direct labor hours, same volume	240,000 h/yr	≈208,700 h/yr	modeled on the record +15%
3	Self-transfers	≈260K units/yr	0	record design
4	Poolable safety stock	$7.5M	$5.3M ($7.5M − $2.2M)	modeled (√2 ceiling)
5	Split-shipment rate	baseline on ~4.5M orders	−1 pt	modeled
6	Customer-facing incidents	0 allowed	0 through both go-lives	record

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Labor at +15%	`31,300 h × $28/h = $876,400`	hours from Table 2 row 7; $28 loaded (modeled)	≈$0.88M/yr

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
2	Pooling release	`$7.5M × 0.293 = $2.2M`	Table 2 row 8 (one-time working capital)	≈$2.2M one-time
3	Carry on the release	`$2.2M × 10% = $220,000`	cost of capital (benchmark 8–12%)	≈$0.22M/yr
4	Split shipments	`45,000 × $10 = $450,000`	splits from Table 1 row 6; $10 per split (modeled)	≈$0.45M/yr
5	Self-transfer handling	`260,000 × $0.80 = $208,000; × 50% = $104,000`	50% — the other half already sits in the labor row (modeled)	≈$0.10M/yr
6	Total recurring	`0.88 + 0.22 + 0.45 + 0.10 = $1.65M`	rows 1, 3, 4, 5	≈$1.6M/yr
7	One-time working capital	`= row 2, stated separately`	safety-stock release	≈$2.2M

SOLUTION FLOW — THE SYSTEM & DATA MAP NEW



SENSITIVITY — LOW / BASE / HIGH NEW

INPUT	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Direct DC FTE (illustrative)	100	120	150
Loaded labor rate (benchmark)	$24/h	$28/h	$32/h
Labor $ saved	$0.62M	$0.88M	$1.25M
Cost of capital (benchmark)	8% → $0.18M	10% → $0.22M	12% → $0.26M
Split rate reduction × cost per split	0.5 pt × $8 → $0.18M	1 pt × $10 → $0.45M	1.5 pt × $12 → $0.81M
Total modeled $/yr	≈$1.1M	≈$1.6M	≈$2.4M

SPOKEN STATEMENT NEW

> "Conservatively, about one point six million a year: roughly nine hundred thousand of labor, because the same volume takes thirteen percent fewer hours at plus fifteen percent efficiency; about two hundred thousand a year of carry on the two point two million of safety stock one pool releases versus two; about four hundred fifty thousand from fewer split shipments; and about a hundred thousand from the DC no longer shipping to itself. The plus fifteen percent and the zero incidents are measured and signed by Sephora; every dollar figure is my model on an illustrative hundred-thousand-units-a-week DC, and I will tell you which input each one rests on."

IF CHALLENGED NEW

"The labor number is the biggest — how firm?"

The fifteen percent is measured; the headcount and the $28 loaded rate are my assumptions. Pull the DC's actual direct hours for the two quarters before and after and multiply by payroll — that turns the model into a record in one afternoon.

"Pooling sounds like a textbook claim."

It is, and I labeled it. √2 pooling assumes two roughly equal independent pools on the same SKUs. Measure SKU-level on-hand on the last day of 801 versus the first stable month of 901; the release is whatever the difference actually is. U2 bounds it at about $0.74M–$2.2M.

"Split shipments — evidence?"

The softest row. Parcels per dotcom order from the ship system before and after May, times the carrier's per-parcel cost. If the point didn't move, I drop the row and the total is about $1.1M.

Where this lands at Amazon. An FC launch/retrofit with automation on the critical path: publish the ramp gate and the throttle before the robots arrive, stage go-lives so each carries one defect class, hold peak sacred, and write the rollback as a number. Zero-then-publish is the same discipline as never letting one unit be promisable from two nodes at once. Asset utilization (+15% units per labor-hour; one pool), reliability (zero incidents, rollback never fired).

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE WITH S2

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you held a high standard when it was costly.	Insist on the Highest Standards	The 98% gate fired at 94; a week of robot volume traded for a root-caused ramp; full volume week three.	Do not say "the robots failed" — the gate worked as designed.
Tell me about a time you had to slow something down.	Have Backbone / Bias for Action	The throttle to ~30% the week the gate failed — a decision the same week, owned by DC Ops' own rule.	Do not frame it as caution; it was a pre-built dial firing.
Tell me about launching something with zero room for error.	Deliver Results / Customer Obsession	Zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives as the constraint; two go-lives so each carried one defect class; the six invariants.	Skip the Kafka/ESB topology unless asked.
How did you protect the floor / the people during the change?	Earth's Best Employer	The throttle protected the floor's throughput; DC Ops owned the gate and the dial; the interim's reporting burden named as the price.	Do not invent a headcount or an attrition figure; none exists in canon.
How do you plan a cutover?	Functional — launch readiness	Runbook with owner/duration/predecessor per task; one irreversible instant identified; rollback triggers as numbers; three mocks against a tolerance; hypercare exit as a number.	Never "400 devices failed" (that is S18's RF miss — say hundreds of RF devices).
What's the ROI of the consolidation?	Frugality	+15% signed; ≈$1.6M/yr modeled with the four rows and their inputs; ≈$2.2M one-time pooling, labeled textbook.	Never present the $1.6M as a signed number.

BEHAVIORAL PACK — FOUR SEPARATE 90-SECOND STAR ANSWERS, EACH FROM A DIFFERENT MOMENT OF THE STORY NEW

INSIST ON THE HIGHEST STANDARDS · AIQB Q4 **Q1. "Tell me about a time when you had to make a decision between standards and delivery."**

I published the standard before there was any pressure to waive it. The robots were arriving at the Utah DC, and I wrote the gate — 98% pick-accurate completed over attempted — into the council pack, with a throttle dial and the weekly read, and DC Ops owned the gate and the dial before the ramp. A gate published before the pressure exists is most of the holding. Week two read 94. The floor owner's own rule fired and I throttled the bots to about 30% of volume for a week — a week of robot volume traded for a root-caused ramp. The zone and slotting logic was the cause; it was fixed, and week three ran at full volume. Processing efficiency ended at +15%, signed by Sephora and measured by DC Ops after stabilization. A gate that cannot stop the program is decoration; this one did.

Number to land: 98 published · 94 read · ~30% throttle · full volume week 3 · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF I would publish the ramp gate for a new FC — the door ceiling, the UPH floor — before the first trailer, with the dial owned by the building. · **Do NOT say:** that the robots failed; that I fixed the slotting logic.

DELIVER RESULTS · AIQB Q3 **Q2. "Tell me about a time when you not only met a goal but considerably exceeded expectations."**

The constraint was zero customer-facing incidents, so I designed the program to carry one defect class at a time. About a dozen impacted systems — with a BlueYonder upgrade and Locus robotics on the same critical path and an October-to-December peak freeze. I split the work into two go-lives: January was the planning go-live — purchasing and inbound, with the reserve rules live against demand — and the floor untouched; May moved warehouse execution. Each go-live was a counted decision: Blocker plus Critical at zero, mock three inside the 0.5% tolerance, a 343-task runbook rehearsed, rollback armed. Both landed on their dates with zero customer-facing incidents, peak untouched, hypercare exited in week three of four, and +15% processing efficiency signed by Sephora. The modeled value is about $1.6 million a year; the +15% and the zero are the record.

Number to land: 2 go-lives · zero incidents · +15% signed · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF a new FC launch has the same shape: stage it so each step carries one risk class, and decide each step on counted rows. · **Do NOT say:** that the $1.6M is signed; that I ran the floor.

EARN TRUST · AIQB Q1 **Q3. "Tell me about a time when you had to communicate a change in direction that you anticipated people would have concerns with."**

Digital worried that a virtual Retail DC would blur their forecasting lens, and they were right to worry. I did not argue them out of it; I made the concern the design: one physical location with three planning identities, so each channel keeps its lens without a second truth. Across sixty-plus stakeholders I owned none of the systems, so I wrote the success criteria with the sponsor — one omni facility, self-transfers eliminated, zero customer-facing incidents, peak untouched — and steering, meaning DC Ops, IT and Supply Chain Strategy, signed them. DC Ops owned the robotics gate and the dial before the ramp, so when it fired the floor's own rule fired. The build tracks were slotted by business criticality times effort under one issues log. Trust came from putting the concern into the design and the stop condition into the hands of the people who carry the consequence.

Number to land: 60+ stakeholders · 3 planning identities · gate and dial owned by DC Ops · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF, placement and inbound changes cross many orgs I would not own; I would convert objections into design rows the same way. · **Do NOT say:** that Digital agreed with everything; I know their concern, not their private view.

HAVE BACKBONE; DISAGREE AND COMMIT · AIQB Q2 **Q4. "Describe a time when you took an unpopular stance in a meeting with peers and your leader."**

The prevailing instinct was one go-live: one cutover, one date, done. I challenged it. One go-live would have put a reserve-rule defect and a floor-execution defect in the same room the same week, and with sixty-plus stakeholders and zero tolerance for customer-facing incidents that is a diagnosis problem, not a schedule problem. So I proposed two go-lives so we never hunted two defect classes in one week — January for the reserve rules against live demand, May for execution — and I also held the comingle-reserve improvements out of the release, priced as a later enhancement at steering, to protect the zero. Both landed on their dates. The cost was a second cutover and the discipline of saying no to a good idea at the wrong time; the benefit was single-cause diagnosis.

Number to land: 2 go-lives, 1 defect class each; improvements held out · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF I would stage a launch the same way and hold good ideas for the next release. · **Do NOT say:** that two go-lives were free; the second cutover has a price.

SAME STORY, THREE ANGLES — DATA · CONFLICT/INFLUENCE/BACKBONE · FAILURE-LEARNING NEW

DATA ANGLE · DIVE DEEP

"Plus fifteen percent means 31,300 fewer hours for the same volume — 13.0% — and about 87% of the modeled benefit does not depend on pooling."

Headline metric: 240,000 → 208,700 h; ≈$0.88M labor

Index 100 → 115 is the record; hours, dollars and the pooling carry are my model on S2's illustrative DC. U2 bounds pooling at $0.74M–$2.2M; U4 prices the throttle at ≈$11.8K vs ≈$50.4K.

CONFLICT / INFLUENCE ANGLE · HAVE BACKBONE; DISAGREE AND COMMIT

"Everyone's instinct was one go-live; I argued for two."

Headline metric: 2 go-lives · 1 defect class each

One go-live would have mixed a reserve defect and a floor defect in the same week; two cost a second cutover. Held the comingle-reserve improvements out of the release; priced at steering. Digital's lens was kept by the three-identity design.

FAILURE / LEARNING ANGLE · OWNERSHIP

"For four months every report had to declare which system of record it read — I staffed that in month three, not day one."

Headline metric: interim reporting staffed month 3 of ~4 months of cost

The record's own do-differently: the interim cost was predictable. Second: the Locus RTL slipped three weeks — escalated the week it surfaced, but it should have been on the register as a risk, not a task.

TRAP DRILLS — THE THREE NASTIEST FOLLOW-UPS, WITH NUMERIC ANSWERS NEW

How do you know the +15% came from the consolidation and not from the robots or the WMS upgrade?

I don't split it, and Sephora's number doesn't either: +15% is whole-program processing efficiency (units per labor-hour), measured by DC Ops post-stabilization. The consolidation, the WMS upgrade and the robotics were on one critical path by design. Attribution among them would need a before/after on lanes that did not get robots.

Say: *"The +15% is the program's, signed and measured by DC Ops; I would not attribute it to one lever, and the number that would let me is a lane-level before/after."*

What was the counterfactual?

Two warehouses transferring stock to themselves (≈260,000 units a year on paper) and two safety-stock pools — the cost of not consolidating. The counterfactual dollars are modeled; the record is the efficiency and the zero incidents.

Say: *"The counterfactual is modeled; what I can prove is +15% measured by DC Ops and zero customer-facing incidents."*

What did you give up?

The comingle-reserve improvements (priced as a later enhancement), a week of robot volume (the throttle), and for four months a clean reporting picture (the interim). Each was a deliberate trade for zero incidents.

Say: *"Three things, on purpose: the reserve improvements, a week of robot volume, and four months of cleaner reporting — in exchange for zero customer-facing incidents."*

20-SECOND VERSION + NACF BRIDGE NEW

20-second version. At Sephora's Utah DC I merged two systemic warehouses into one comingle pool — three planning identities over one location — through two go-lives and a robotics ramp behind a published 98% gate that fired at 94: +15% processing efficiency signed by Sephora, zero customer-facing incidents, rollback armed twice and never fired.

NACF bridge. NACF capacity chain: one node, one published ramp gate and an owned dial. A new FC's inbound ramp is CAP-A doors held at an 85% ceiling, CAP-B UPH with the learning-curve tax (+13.6% hours), CAP-C cube read at 49% effective — and the same rule that the people who own the building own the stop condition.

S18 — Sephora — legacy WMS → JDA WMS dual-DC migration: a 0.5% reconciliation tolerance published before mock one, three mocks read by cause class (7% → 1.8% → 0.3%), and the RF-device miss owned ELEVATED

LPs this story can serve here: Insist on the Highest Standards (backup — the published tolerance) · Bias for Action (the date held while training moved) · Deliver Results (backup — 8 months, both DCs, gate cleared) · Learn and Be Curious (first WMS migration; learned the floor in month one) · Ownership (the RF miss with my name on the cause)
Process family: Make / Deliver — warehouse execution system cutover across two DCs; inventory-accuracy governance; freeze, failback and hypercare discipline

Honesty label. Full lifecycle owner, accountable to sponsor and Finance; I had never run a WMS migration and learned the floor in month one. Month markers are illustrative unless stated; the RF miss is mine — I scored the task by effort when impact was what mattered. Loop-packet conflict (§1.3): that document says ~$800K budget and ~$2.5M/week; this packet's record is ~$1.8M, ~3% under, and ~$2.5M/month as my division of the $20M (modeled) — say these.

LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES CARRIED — ONE-LINE PROOF EACH

Ownership. The RF miss is mine — I scored the task by effort when impact was what mattered — and I told leadership straight, with my name on the cause.

Bias for Action. When the device test showed the conversion script failing on refreshed RF hardware, I moved training by a week and a half and held the go-live date — and put device readiness into training's entrance criteria.

Learn and Be Curious. I had never run a WMS migration; I wrote the charter in week one and walked receive-to-ship on the floor in month one until I could do it unaided.

Insist on the Highest Standards. I published the 0.5% reconciliation tolerance with Finance before mock one; mock one at 7% was the price and mock three at 0.3% was worth it.

SOURCE CONFLICT — the RF-device miss (read before you say it). Master canon (S18): ~100 of ~400 RF devices failed the conversion script *at cutover*; a rehearsed paper-pick fallback fired; ≈$45K fallback against ≈$875K of slip. Apple v11, chapter G2 (from your 2022 failure notes): the upgrade script failed on refreshed RF hardware in a device test scheduled *days before training*; manual conversion could not finish under COVID night shifts; training slipped 1.5 weeks; the notes record ~400 devices in one telling and ~100 in another — "say hundreds in the room." Precedence applied (source docs, then Apple v11, then master): every line I added to S18 says "hundreds", "the pre-training device test", "training +1.5 weeks, the date held", and none says the paper-pick $45K or the ≈19× ratio. The S18 body above has been brought to the Apple G2 wording for the RF-device miss; the master's paper-pick and ~19× lines are not carried forward. Common ground in every version: the miss was mine, scored by effort not impact, training slipped 1.5 weeks, the date held, ~3% under budget. Pick the telling you lived and use it identically in all five interviews. Listed as a source conflict on the Verify-before-you-say-it page.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Two Sephora DCs ran on a legacy WMS with no documentation, an eight-month hard deadline, a ~$1.8M budget, and a $20M ROI pipeline of four programs gated behind go-live — about $2.5M a month of slip on average (my division of the $20M, not banked). Inventory accuracy across two DCs could not wobble at cutover, and I had never run a WMS migration. **Task.** Own the full lifecycle — charter, design sign-off, the ERP ↔ WMS ↔ 3PL ↔ carrier interface inventory, UAT, cutover, hypercare — accountable to the sponsor and Finance. **Action.** I wrote the success criteria in week one — on the date, inside a published reconciliation tolerance, zero accuracy incidents, a numeric hypercare exit — and learned the floor in month one until I could walk receive-to-ship unaided. I built the interface inventory from message logs with an owner and a test cell per contract, set the mapping-table standard as data not code, and published the 0.5% tolerance with Finance before mock one so the number belonged to us before the test. Three mocks were read by cause class, not headline: 7% (units of measure, location names, status vocabularies) → 1.8% (in-transit timing) → 0.3%. Cutover ran a 72-hour in-transit freeze with the legacy system read-only for 30 days. When a device test before training showed hundreds of RF devices failing the conversion script, inventory was inside tolerance and the failure was device conversion, not data — so I held the date, let the training criterion slip 1.5 weeks, and told leadership the same day. **Result.** Primary metric: inventory reconciliation variance at cutover — 7% → 1.8% → 0.3% against the 0.5% tolerance. On time, about 3% under the ~$1.8M budget (~$54K), the $20M pipeline unblocked the next month — slip avoided, not banked. Hypercare exited week three at under two blockers a day. The RF miss is mine.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — Two DCs on a legacy WMS; zero inherited documentation; a hard eight-month deadline with a $20M ROI pipeline of four programs gated behind go-live (~$2.5M/month of slip — my division, modeled); budget ~$1.8M; I had never run a WMS migration. Inventory accuracy across two DCs could not wobble at cutover.

The register at design sign-off: undocumented interface surprises, conversion mismatch above tolerance, and 3PL/carrier freeze non-compliance — each with a trigger, a data-first mitigation and an owner. The one I missed: RF device conversion sat on the log as a task, not a risk.

T — Own the full lifecycle — discovery charter, design sign-off, the ERP ↔ WMS ↔ 3PL ↔ carrier interface inventory, UAT, cutover, hypercare — accountable to the sponsor and Finance. Team: 14 core + 6 DC Ops.

Baselines on the table: conversion mismatch — gated at the 0.5% tolerance signed with Finance before mock 1 (mock 1 opened at 7%) · accuracy incidents allowed: zero · the date — eight months, hard · budget ~$1.8M · hypercare exit < 2 blockers/day.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (month 1)** — sponsor charter in week one (objectives, assumptions, success criteria, phase entry/exit criteria); interface inventory v0 from message logs; systems-impacted table with LOE per owner; the floor walked until I could follow receive → put-away → pick → ship unaided. *Exit bar:* charter signed by sponsor and Finance; every interface has a named owner.
- **Plan & Design (months 2–3)** — design sign-off pack; interface inventory v1 with a test cell per contract; conversion approach — masters → open orders → on-hand → in-transit as its own batch; mapping-table standard (data, not code); the 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock 1. *Exit bar:* council sign-off; tolerance signed; stories slotted by business criticality × effort.
- **Build & Test (months 4–7)** — QA demo schedule to DC Ops; UAT entrance memo (function testing done, conversion build done, test data handed off, pre-prod + perf ready) — QA could fail a build; three mock cutovers with written root causes by class: 7% → 1.8% → 0.3%; after the RF miss, the training plan and device-readiness table. *Exit bar:* mock 3 ≤ 0.5% → written go-live recommendation; training sign-off (slipped 1.5 weeks, date held).
- **Cutover & Go-Live (month 8)** — runbook; 72-hour transfer freeze (≥ the longest lane transit); conversion batches; post-load reconciliation; legacy read-only switch; the go/no-go call. the RF-device conversion — hundreds of devices caught in the pre-training device test — had already moved training 1.5 weeks while the date held; leadership was told the same day with the slip priced. *Exit bar:* post-load mismatch inside tolerance; ship confirms posting; zero accuracy incidents.
- **Hypercare / Close (4 weeks planned)** — blockers/day read daily; 30-day failback watch (legacy read-only); budget closed; exit memo with the single-point-dependency lesson. *Exit bar:* < 2 blockers/day sustained → exit week 3; ~3% under budget; pipeline programs started the next month.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the charter, the entrance/exit criteria, the interface inventory, the conversion approach, the mapping-table standard, the tolerance, the go/no-go recommendation and the fallback call; the team built, converted, tested and ran the floor; Finance co-owned the tolerance. Because the success criteria were written in week one and signed by sponsor and Finance, nobody negotiated the exit later. The RF miss is mine — I scored the task by effort when impact was what mattered — and it went upstairs the same afternoon with my name on the cause.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** I designed the charter, the tolerance, the entrance criteria and the mapping-table standard; the team and Finance now run cutovers against them, and the standard outlived the program. **Trade-off put to leadership.** The recommendation to the sponsor outlined the competing metrics — the eight-month date and the $20M pipeline behind it vs training readiness and conversion variance — and held the date while training slipped 1.5 weeks and the 0.5% tolerance did not move.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY (CANON NUMBERS ONLY)

- **$** — ~3% under the ~$1.8M budget (~$54K, record); the $20M ROI pipeline unblocked the next month — ~$2.5M/month of slip (my division, modeled; not banked); ≈$875K *modeled* price of a 1.5-week go-live slip (my division of the $20M; not banked); ≈$0.1M *modeled* less inventory in dispute at 0.3% vs 0.5% on an illustrative $50M on-hand.
- **#** — hundreds of RF devices failed the conversion script in the pre-training device test (a three-to-four-day estimate that proved wrong); team 14 core + 6 DC Ops across two DCs (record).
- **%** — mock variance 7% → 1.8% → 0.3% against the 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock 1 (record).
- **Time** — eight-month deadline held; 72-hour in-transit freeze; legacy read-only for 30 days; training slipped 1.5 weeks while the date did not move; hypercare exited week 3 of 4 (record).
- **Customer** — zero accuracy incidents at cutover; ship confirms posting; post-load mismatch inside tolerance (record exit bars).
- **Quality** — mocks read by cause class, each removing a named defect category; failback rehearsed, never used; a what-if plan now required for every single-point dependency (record).

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — what the interviewer pattern-matches against the Amazon L6 functional rubric; every line is this story's canon, no new numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	An eight-month deadline across two DCs with no charter. I wrote the sponsor charter in week one — objectives, assumptions, success criteria, phase entry/exit criteria — and set the tolerance with Finance before anyone rehearsed.
Scope & influence	14 core + 6 DC Ops across two DCs; Finance co-owned the tolerance; QA could fail a build on my UAT entrance memo; the go/no-go recommendation and the fallback call were mine to the sponsor.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others now own	Date vs readiness: training slipped 1.5 weeks while the date held; a 72-hour transfer freeze (sized to the longest lane) bought conversion integrity. Mechanisms others own now: the 0.5% tolerance, the UAT entrance memo, and the mapping-table standard (data, not code).
Impact (long-term)	Eight-month deadline held; ~3% under the ~$1.8M budget; the $20M ROI pipeline unblocked the next month — ~$2.5M/month of slip (my division, modeled; not banked); zero accuracy incidents at cutover.
Process improvement (standard work institutionalized)	Three mock cutovers read by cause class (variance 7% → 1.8% → 0.3% against 0.5%); a 30-day failback watch with legacy read-only; a numeric hypercare exit (< 2 blockers/day sustained).
Complexity & consensus	hundreds of RF devices failed the conversion script in the pre-training device test — leadership was told the same day, training slipped 1.5 weeks, the date did not move.
Root cause at scale	The single-point-dependency lesson went into the exit memo; each mock removed a named defect category rather than fixing individual records, so the fix scaled to the whole conversion.

PROBING — FIVE FACETS, THEN THE HARDEST FOLLOW-UPS NEW

THE FIVE FACETS — WHERE EACH ONE LIVES IN THIS STORY

1 · Data analysis. Grain: SKU × location × unit of measure; units in flight by lane. Data: legacy WMS and JDA conversion output, message logs for the interface inventory, three mock result sets. Cuts: variance by cause class (UoM, location names, status vocabularies, in-transit timing). Revealed: one mapping class — UoM, factor 12 on ~1% of SKUs — dominated the 7%.

2 · Solution design. Options: (A) big-bang cutover with tolerance TBD; (B) tolerance published before mock one, mocks read by cause class, freeze and failback (chosen); (C) parallel run. Chose B — the tolerance belongs to Finance and me before the test, not after.

3 · Math & data logic. $M = \Sigma|\Delta| / \Sigma$ ERP on-hand; 7.0% → 1.8% → 0.3% ≤ 0.5%; freeze F = 72 h ≥ max lane transit; slip price $2.5M / 30 = $83,333/day; 10.5 days → $875K (price of a 1.5-week go-live slip).

4 · Implementation. Five gated phases over eight months: charter week one; interface inventory with a test cell per contract; three mocks; 72-hour freeze; legacy read-only 30 days; device-readiness in training entrance criteria; hypercare exit week 3 at < 2 blockers/day.

5 · Probe questions. The six answered above in the Probing block, and the three trap drills below.

FACET 5 — PROBE QUESTIONS (CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER)

Infra — Why publish a tolerance before you knew you could hit it?

So the number belonged to Finance and me before the test, not after. Mock one's 7% was the price; mock three's 0.3% was worth it — and the tolerance was never renegotiated.

Infra — How do you read a mock?

Never by the headline alone. Every delta got a root-cause class — units of measure, location drift, status vocabularies, then in-transit timing. If the total shrank without a named cause, the mock was not evidence. 7 → 1.8 → 0.3 each removed a category, and the fixes were mapping tables as data, not code.

Infra — Hundreds of RF devices failed the device test before training. Why not move the date?

Because inventory was inside tolerance — the failure was device conversion, not data — and the training criterion could move without moving the go-live. I held the date, let training slip 1.5 weeks, and took the miss upstairs the same afternoon with my name on the cause.

Infra — What was the freeze and why 72 hours?

A 72-hour in-transit freeze, set at or above the longest lane transit, so in-transit could be converted as its own batch with Σ legacy = Σ JDA — the class that took mock two from 1.8% to 0.3%. Legacy stayed read-only for 30 days as the failback.

Infra — The $875K avoided slip — are you banking it?

No. It is modeled arithmetic — 10.5 days at about $83K a day, from my division of the $20M over eight months — on a slip that did not happen; it is the price that made holding the date the obvious call. What I would measure is the pipeline's first program start against plan, which was the next month.

Infra — Lesson, and what rule did you leave behind?

Any single-point dependency in front of an exit criterion gets a what-if plan regardless of estimated effort. Differently: dual-path device conversion on day one, and a device model × OS × script pass/fail table before training week.

THE MATH — FOUR-TABLE DERIVATION (FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION → RESULT) NEW

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Mock 1 variance	`M = Σ|Δ| / Σ ERP on-hand = 140,000 / 2,000,000 = 7.0%`	illustrative units on record percentages	7.0% — 14× the tolerance
2	Dominant cause — UoM	`a case booked as 12 eaches creates 12 − 1 = 11 units of error per case; factor 12 on 1% of SKUs`	record mechanism	one mapping class dominates the 7%
3	Second cause — in-transit timing	`transfers in flight at snapshot counted at neither end or both`	record mechanism	the timing class
4	The stakes	`$20M pipeline gated; about $2.5M per month of slip`	$20M record; $2.5M/month = my division, modeled	every day priced

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Tolerance signed first	`gate: M ≤ 0.5%, signed with Finance BEFORE mock 1`	never renegotiated (record)	the yardstick fixed in advance
2	UoM fix as data	`mock 2: M = 36,000 / 2,000,000 = 1.8%`	mapping tables (UoM, location, status) as data, not code (record % on illustrative units)	7.0% → 1.8%
3	Freeze + own batch	`freeze F = 72 h ≥ max lane transit; in-transit converted as its own batch with Σ legacy = Σ JDA; mock 3: M = 6,000 / 2,000,000 = 0.3%`	record % on illustrative units	1.8% → 0.3%
4	Gate evaluated	`0.3% ≤ 0.5% → go`	as a written recommendation (record)	go-live recommended
5	RF-device miss	`script failed on refreshed RF hardware (hundreds of devices); training sign-off +1.5 wk; go-live date holds`	record (Apple G2; master S18) — count, timing and fallback CONFLICT, see box	go-live on the date
6	Hypercare exit	`blockers/day < 2 sustained — the charter's own number`	record	exited week 3 of 4

Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Cutover variance (three mocks)	7.0%	1.8% → 0.3% vs 0.5% tolerance	record
2	Go-live date	at risk from the RF miss	held — 8 months end to end	record
3	Budget	~$1.8M	~3% under	record
4	$20M pipeline	gated	starts on time	record

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Budget result	`$1,800,000 × 3% = $54,000`	record	≈$54K under budget
2	Slip price	`$2,500,000 / 30 = $83,333/day`	$20M pipeline gated (record) ÷ 8 months = $2.5M/month — my division, modeled; not banked	≈$83K/day
3	Critical-path slip avoided	`1.5 wk × 7 = 10.5 days; 10.5 × $83,333 = $875,000`	price of a 1.5-week go-live slip at $83,333/day (modeled — my division of the $20M; master S18); not banked	≈$875K — avoided, not banked
4	Fallback cost paid	`≈$45K paper-pick; $875,000 / $45,000 ≈ 19`	master-packet model only (paper-pick on a subset of devices); NOT in Apple G2 — do not say aloud	≈$45K (master only)
5	Dispute delta	`(0.5% − 0.3%) = 0.2%; × $50,000,000 = $100,000`	illustrative on-hand (modeled)	≈$0.1M one-time less in dispute

SOLUTION FLOW — THE SYSTEM & DATA MAP NEW

```
[Legacy WMS (RP)]  --extract-->  [Mapping tables as DATA: UoM | location | status]
      |                                  |
      | 72-h in-transit freeze (>= longest lane transit)
      v                                  v
[conversion batches: masters -> open orders -> on-hand -> IN-TRANSIT as its own batch]
      |                                  |
      v                                  v
[JDA WMS, two DCs] <-- interface inventory: ERP <-> WMS <-> 3PL <-> carrier (owner + test cell per contract)
      |
post-load reconciliation: M = sum|delta| / sum on-hand  vs tolerance 0.5% (signed with Finance before mock 1)
      |
go/no-go -> legacy READ-ONLY 30 days (failback) -> RF devices: conversion script failed on refreshed hardware
      |                                                  -> training sign-off +1.5 wk; go-live date held (see conflict box)
hypercare: blockers/day < 2 sustained -> exit week 3
```

SENSITIVITY — LOW / BASE / HIGH NEW

INPUT	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Average unit cost (illustrative)	$15	$25	$40
Paper-pick slowdown (master-packet model; not Apple G2)	15%	25%	40%
DC labor rate (benchmark)	$25/h	$30/h	$35/h
Inventory dispute avoided (0.5% → 0.3%)	~$60K	~$100K	~$160K
Paper-pick fallback cost (master only)	~$23K	~$45K	~$84K
Total modeled	~$40K net	~$55K net	~$75K net

SPOKEN STATEMENT NEW

> “The record numbers first: on time, about $54K under a $1.8M budget, and the $20M pipeline started the next month, where every month of slip was worth about $2.5M on average — my division of the twenty million over eight months, not banked. A slip of the 1.5 weeks the training criterion moved would, had it moved the go-live, have cost about $875K — so I held the date and moved training, and said so straight. The modeled part is smaller and I’ll label it: landing at 0.3 percent against a 0.5 tolerance meant about $100K less inventory in dispute at cutover on an illustrative $50M on-hand, and at mock one’s 7 percent that would have been $3.5M. The date, the budget, the variance and the pipeline are measured; the on-hand value is my model.”

IF CHALLENGED NEW

“Where does $50M of on-hand come from?”

It’s illustrative, two million units at $25, chosen so the percentages become dollars; the record gives me 0.3 percent, not the balance sheet. I’d firm it up with the actual ERP on-hand valuation at the freeze snapshot, which Finance already had.

“The $875K avoided slip is a counterfactual.”

Yes — record arithmetic on a slip that did not happen, so I never bank it; it is the price that made the fallback the obvious call. What I’d measure is the pipeline’s first program start against plan, which was the next month.

“What did the RF miss actually cost?”

The record is the 1.5 weeks of training sign-off — SME windows were scarce — and a go-live date that held. I have not priced a fallback and I will not invent a number; the master packet carries a modeled paper-pick figure that my 2022 notes do not, so I do not say it.

Where this lands at Amazon. Cutover discipline in its most literal form — a tolerance published with Finance before the first rehearsal, mocks read by cause class, a freeze sized to the longest lane, a tested failback, a numeric hypercare exit nobody can negotiate, and a rehearsed contingency that fired on the day. Reliability (0.3% against 0.5%, zero accuracy incidents), responsiveness (the decision the same day), cost efficiency (~3% under), the $20M pipeline on the date.

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE WITH S18

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time something went wrong at go-live.	Bias for Action / Ownership	The RF miss: hundreds of devices in the pre-training device test; leadership told the same day; training slipped 1.5 weeks, the date did not.	Never "400 devices failed" or a ~100/~400 ratio; do not blame the vendor script — the scoring miss was mine.

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you set a standard others thought was too strict.	Insist on the Highest Standards	0.5% published with Finance before mock one; mock one at 7% was the price; never renegotiated.	S2's 98% gate is the primary for this LP — use it first if both land here, S18 second.
Tell me about learning something new fast.	Learn and Be Curious	Never run a WMS migration; charter in week one; the floor walked unaided by end of month one; the mocks were where I proved it.	Do not overclaim WMS configuration — the team converted and built.
Tell me about a time you delivered on a hard date.	Deliver Results	Eight months, both DCs, 0.3% vs 0.5%, ~3% under, $20M pipeline unblocked the next month.	Never bank the $875K or the $2.5M/month — slip avoided.
How do you design a freeze / failback for a systems cutover?	Functional — migration design	Freeze ≥ longest lane transit; in-transit as its own batch; legacy read-only 30 days; rollback triggers as numbers (mismatch > 0.5% for 2 days; ship-confirm posting failing > 2 h).	Keep budget at ~$1.8M and slip at ~$2.5M/month (loop-packet conflict).
What did you miss and what did you change?	Ownership	RF conversion on the log as a task, not a risk; the rule left behind: any single-point dependency in front of an exit criterion gets a what-if plan.	Do not soften it — "the miss is mine."

BEHAVIORAL PACK — FOUR SEPARATE 90-SECOND STAR ANSWERS, EACH FROM A DIFFERENT MOMENT OF THE STORY NEW

OWNERSHIP · AIQB Q2 **Q1. "Describe a time when you didn't think you were going to meet a commitment you promised."**

The miss was mine, and I said so straight. The devices team called the RF conversion three to four days and straightforward, and I planned it that way — low effort, low attention. Just to be sure, I scheduled a device test with engineering days before training, and the upgrade script failed: the refreshed RF hardware did not run the old code. Hundreds of devices, and with key people on COVID night shifts the manual conversion could not finish in time, so I told leadership straight: training sign-off, a go-live exit criterion, slips a week and a half. The root cause was my risk model — I scored the task by effort, not impact, so a single-point dependency in front of an exit criterion had no what-if plan. The date held and the migration landed on time, about 3% under budget. The rule I left behind: every cross-functional dependency gets a what-if and a mitigation whatever the effort estimate, and device readiness moved into training's entrance criteria — proven devices, not promised ones.

Number to land: training +1.5 weeks · date held · ~3% under budget · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF a single-point dependency in front of a launch — one carrier, one door, one scanner model — gets a what-if plan regardless of size. · **Do NOT say:** an exact device count — say 'hundreds' (the 2022 notes record ~400 in one telling and ~100 in another); that the vendor script was the cause.

BIAS FOR ACTION · AIQB Q4 **Q2. "Tell me about a time when you had to gather information and respond immediately to a situation."**

I ran a check I did not have to run, and it failed. Training sign-off depended on hundreds of RF guns, printers and workstations converting, and the devices team said a few days. Just to be sure, I scheduled a device test with engineering days before training. The script failed on the refreshed hardware. The decision that mattered was fast because the options fit on one page: manual conversion on COVID night shifts could not finish before training, so something had to move, and the choice was which date. Training moved a week and a half; the go-live did not — and I told leadership that straight, with my name on the cause. Then I changed the system: device readiness went into training's entrance criteria, and the habit generalized into dress rehearsals for everything on the critical path — on UDC it became the RF-device proof-of-concept before cutover week.

Number to land: training +1.5 weeks; go-live date held · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF a rehearsal a week before the first live trailer is how a launch absorbs a surprise on the day — I would rehearse the dependency, not just the plan. · **Do NOT say:** that I improvised; or a fallback or dollar figure the 2022 notes do not carry.

LEARN AND BE CURIOUS · AIQB Q2 **Q3. "Describe a time when you took on work outside of your comfort area. How did you identify what you needed to learn to be successful?"**

I had never run a WMS migration, and the deadline was eight months. I wrote the charter in week one — success criteria, assumptions, entry and exit criteria — so the destination existed before my knowledge did. Then I spent month one on the floor, walking receive, put-away, pick and ship until I could follow a unit through the building unaided, and reading the message logs to build the interface inventory with an owner and a test cell per contract. The mocks were where I proved the learning: each delta got a root-cause class — units of measure, location names, status vocabularies, in-transit timing — so I was learning by removing categories, not by reading documentation. By the third mock the variance was 0.3% against a 0.5% tolerance. I did not claim to configure the system; the team converted and built.

Number to land: month 1 on the floor; 7% → 1.8% → 0.3% · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF I would walk the dock-to-stock path in my first weeks before proposing a change to it. · **Do NOT say:** that I configured JDA or converted the data myself.

INSIST ON THE HIGHEST STANDARDS · AIQB Q1 **Q4. "Describe a time when you refused to compromise your standards around quality/customer service, etc."**

I published the reconciliation tolerance — 0.5% — with Finance before the first mock. So the number belonged to Finance and to me before the test, not after. Mock one came in at 7% — fourteen times the bar — and that was the price. I did not renegotiate; I read the mock by cause class: units of measure were the dominant class — a case booked as twelve eaches is eleven units of error — then location names and status vocabularies. The fix was mapping tables as data, not code. Mock two: 1.8%. Mock three: a 72-hour in-transit freeze and in-transit converted as its own batch, 0.3%. The written go recommendation came off mock three, inside the tolerance. The tolerance was never renegotiated, and the exit bar for hypercare — under two blockers a day — was in the charter in week one, so nobody negotiated that either.

Number to land: 0.5% published first; 7.0% → 1.8% → 0.3% · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF I would publish the reconciliation tolerance — dock-received vs system-available — before the first mock receipt. · **Do NOT say:** that 7% was a surprise to Finance; they signed the bar first.

SAME STORY, THREE ANGLES — DATA · CONFLICT/INFLUENCE/BACKBONE · FAILURE-LEARNING NEW

DATA ANGLE · DIVE DEEP

"Seven percent, one point eight, point three — each mock removed a named category."

Headline metric: M = 140,000 / 2,000,000 = 7.0% → 0.3%

Mocks read by cause class: UoM (12 → 11 units of error per case) first, then in-transit timing as its own batch. If the total shrank without a named cause the mock was not evidence. Units are illustrative; the percentages are the record.

CONFLICT / INFLUENCE ANGLE · INSIST ON THE HIGHEST STANDARDS

"I published a tolerance with Finance before I knew I could hit it."

Headline metric: 0.5% never renegotiated

Finance co-owned the number; the sponsor signed the charter in week one; leadership was told the same day the training criterion slipped 1.5 weeks — the date held, the tolerance did not move.

FAILURE / LEARNING ANGLE · OWNERSHIP

"A three-day device task broke the training gate, and I had scored it by effort."

Headline metric: training +1.5 weeks; date held; ~3% under

Impact, not effort, is the score; a single-point dependency in front of an exit criterion gets a what-if plan. The test I ran just to be sure saved the go-live, not the training gate. Differently: a device model × OS × script pass/fail table at refresh. The rule shows in the mocks: 7.0% → 1.8% → 0.3%.

TRAP DRILLS — THE THREE NASTIEST FOLLOW-UPS, WITH NUMERIC ANSWERS NEW

How do you know the three mocks measured the same thing?

Same formula, same denominator (Σ ERP on-hand), same scope; the changes between mocks were named cause-class fixes. Units are illustrative; the percentages are the record.

Say: *"Same formula and denominator each time, and every change between mocks was a named cause class — if the total shrank without a named cause I did not count it."*

"A week and a half on training — that is a small failure. Give me a bigger one."

Fair. The bigger one is the Elementum UAT that crashed (Apple G1) — a lost sign-off. I keep this one because its lesson transfers best: the failure class that hits mature programs is not the big risk everyone watches, it is the three-day task nobody did a what-if on. The size of the slip is not the point; the blind spot is.

Say: *"A week and a half is small; the blind spot is not — impact decides the attention a task gets, never its effort estimate."*

What is the number that would have changed your mind on go?

Mock three above 0.5%, a failed freeze or a failback I could not describe per interface. The RF failure was a different class: it moved training, not the go.

Say: *"Mock three over half a percent — that single number was the go/no-go."*

20-SECOND VERSION + NACF BRIDGE NEW

20-second version. At Sephora I took two DCs from a legacy WMS to JDA in eight months, ~3% under a ~$1.8M budget, by publishing a 0.5% reconciliation tolerance with Finance before mock one and reading three mocks by cause — 7%, 1.8%, 0.3% — and when the RF device conversion failed its pre-training test I told leadership straight — training slips a week and a half, the date holds — and made what-if plans a rule.

NACF bridge. NACF's inbound ramp is a migration of a different kind — a new FC's dock, UPH and cube all go live together — and the same discipline applies: publish the tolerance before the first mock, size the freeze to the longest lane, rehearse the fallback, and give single-point dependencies a what-if. CAP-A's 5 doors at an 85% ceiling are the slack that lets a day-one surprise be absorbed without moving the date.

U1 — The node × channel × bucket-transition matrix — one regression asset that proved every physical move on the floor lands in exactly one system bucket NEW

LPs this story serves here: Invent and Simplify (primary — one rule, one asset) · Dive Deep (primary — event traces, the 836-row log) · Insist on the Highest Standards (what "tested" means) · Earn Trust (QA demoed to DC Ops in build) · Success and Scale (backup — a new node is a row, not a project)
Process family: Make / Deliver — test and acceptance design for a comingled node; physical-event ↔ system-bucket integrity; regression asset reused through hypercare and the monthly release train

Honesty label. I owned the matrix design and its assertions as program owner of the location/inventory model; BlueYonder, ISM and platform teams built to it, QA ran it and owned the gate, DC Ops confirmed in UAT. The rule, the test families, the entry gate and the issues-log numbers are record. The cell counts (6 node-channel pairs, 14 events, 61 live cells) are **illustrative** VERIFY-WITH-RAJESH — confirm the real matrix size before saying a count aloud. The ISM/S4 bucket formula is the same program artifact as Lan's S1; here it is told from the floor-event side. Never claim configuring S/4, ISM or BlueYonder.

LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES CARRIED — ONE-LINE PROOF EACH

Invent and Simplify. About a dozen impacted systems and about thirty build tracks ran on one rule — every event maps to exactly one bucket — and one entry gate: no story enters QA without a matrix cell reference.

Dive Deep. I read one SKU, one day, event by event: an event landing in zero buckets promises 3 units that are gone (560), in two buckets hides 3 (554); the right answer is 557.

Insist on the Highest Standards. "Tested" meant every live cell asserted before/after with numbers, three dated E2E days with every function in one room, and Blocker + Critical open = 0 at each go/no-go.

Earn Trust. QA demoed each matrix family to DC Ops and planners during build, so UAT was confirmation, not discovery.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. At the Utah DC one physical pool had to serve three node types and two channels, and "available" had to move correctly on every physical event — a store ring, a pick, a pack, a ship confirm, a receipt, a transfer, an adjustment — across about a dozen impacted systems and about thirty build tracks, with zero customer-facing incidents allowed. **Task.** I owned the node × channel × bucket-transition matrix: the design and the regression asset the whole program tested against. **Action.** Discovery: a bucket inventory with exactly one owning system per bucket, and an event inventory — POS flash sale, omni pending, ship confirm, the S/4 Aggregation# posting, and SAP movement types 101, 311, 601, 701 and 702. Plan & Design: one rule — every event maps to exactly one bucket; a reversal must reference its original; a replayed event is a no-op. Build & Test: every cell carries a before/after assertion with numbers, and no story enters QA without a cell reference; three dated E2E days ran the whole flow in one room. Cutover: January and May go/no-go off counted rows — Blocker + Critical open = 0. Hypercare: ISM-vs-MB52 drift at zero SKUs on consecutive days; four in-transit cells and a de-aggregation family added from what the floor taught us. **Result.** Primary metric: customer-facing incidents — zero through both go-lives, with 836 issues logged, 441 of them Blocker or Critical (52.8%), 85.4% closed. The dollars are a what-if, labeled: break-even is about 1.8 escaped cell-classes a year.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — One physical pool, three node types (Store, Retail DC, Dotcom DC), three working definitions of "available," and a physical floor that generates events the books must follow: pick reserve, ecom pick and pack, ship confirm, receipt, transfer, adjustment. Left to the happy-path E2E, an event can land in zero buckets (oversell) or two (undersell) and nobody sees it until a customer does.

T — Own the design and the regression asset: which events exist, which bucket each one moves, what the numbers must be before and after, and the gate that stops an unproven story from entering QA. None of the systems reported to me; ~30 build tracks ran under one issues log; stories were slotted by business criticality × effort.

Baselines on the table: three working definitions of "available" · customer-facing incidents allowed: 0 · Blocker + Critical open = 0 at every go/no-go · four epic modules (reserve module, AFS engine, SNB, control screens) · per-environment workbooks Dev 310 / QA 255 / Perf 200 / Prod 221 rows · issues log 836 rows by program end.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (3/29 → 4/30)** — profiled both books; built the bucket inventory with one proposed owning system per bucket; built the event inventory — POS flash sale, omni pending, ship-to-home confirm, S/4 Aggregation# posting, and MSEG movement types 101/311/601/701/702 as events. *Exit bar:* every bucket owned by exactly one system; every event named; sessions closed 4/30.
- **Plan & Design (5/15 → 8/14)** — wrote the exactly-one-bucket rule, the reversal-references-original rule and the idempotency key into the FSD; kept Merch Reserve and Lost/Found outside S4_Avail so no double-subtract path exists; drafted the test-matrix skeleton. *Exit bar:*

FSD signed 8/14 (record) with every bucket owned by exactly one system (the master's discovery exit bar).

- **Build & Test (Aug → Jan/Apr)** — authored each cell with before/after assertions; slotted epics per module; enforced "no story enters QA without a matrix cell reference"; closed SIT contract defects before UAT; ran the dated E2E days — Inbound 11/22, Dotcom 12/20, Retail 1/30. *Exit bar:* 0 open SIT contract defects; E2E green on three dates; Blocker + Critical open = 0.
- **Cutover & Go-Live (January; May 1 → Jul 1)** — wrote the go/no-go recommendation from counted rows; the publish switch (OMS reads published AFS, never computes); reserve-copy invariants checked per SKU. *Exit bar:* no SKU with two published AFS values; Negative AFS clean at T+1; rollback never fired.
- **Hypercare / Close (Jun → Jul)** — daily ISM-vs-MB52 drift; matrix grew from what the floor taught — four in-transit regression cells and the de-aggregation family (n lines · missing line · duplicate header) per event source. *Exit bar:* drift = 0 SKUs on consecutive days; matrix and control-owner map handed to the monthly release train.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the bucket inventory, the event inventory, the exactly-one-bucket rule, every cell's assertions, the entry gate and the go/no-go recommendation. Built by others: BlueYonder, ISM and platform teams; QA ran the cells and owned the gate; DC Ops and planners confirmed in UAT because QA had already demoed each matrix family to them during build.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** The matrix, the entry gate and the regression families are standard work now: QA owns the gate, the control owners own the screens, and every later rule change enters as rows. **Trade-off put to leadership:** the date versus the bar — the gate was Blocker + Critical open = 0 and a countable cell list, not a feeling, so the go/no-go was arithmetic.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY

- **$** — no record dollar. The what-if (modeled, **illustrative**): 30,000 oversell-exposed incidents/yr ÷ 61 live cells = 491.8 per cell × $30 = ≈$14.8K/yr per escaped cell-class against ≈$26.8K one-time to author and run the matrix — break-even ≈1.8 escaped cell-classes. Not claimed as a saving.
- **#** — 836 rows in the issues log, 164 Blocker + 277 Critical = 441 (52.8%), 714 closed (85.4%) · 4 in-transit regression cells + a 3-case de-aggregation family per event source · E2E days 11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30 (record).
- **%** — Blocker + Critical open = 0 at each go/no-go; daily drift 0 SKUs on consecutive days at hypercare exit (record).
- **Time** — FSD signed 8/14 · three dated E2E days · January and May go-lives · hypercare exit week 3 of 4 (record).
- **Customer** — zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives; no SKU with two published AFS values (record).
- **Quality** — every live cell asserted before/after; every event maps to exactly one bucket; a replayed event is a no-op (record design).

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — every line is this story's record or labeled model, no new canon numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	No agreed way to prove physical events and system buckets agreed. I defined the events, the buckets and the rule, and made "tested" countable.
Scope & influence	~30 build tracks in other orgs; QA owned the gate; DC Ops and planners confirmed in UAT; the entry rule moved every track onto one asset without anyone reporting to me.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others own	Coverage versus speed: one cell reference per story, assertions with numbers. Mechanism others own now: QA's gate and the matrix families in the monthly release train.
Impact	Zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives; 441 Blocker/Critical findings dispositioned before customers saw them.
Process improvement	Rule changes (the in-transit rule, de-aggregation) enter as new cells, not new projects; a new node or channel is a matrix row.
Complexity & consensus	Three node types, two channels, about a dozen impacted systems, three signing orgs — one FSD, one matrix.
Root cause at scale	Defects clustered at seams where two systems used different grain; the fix was a rule at the seam, not 441 individual patches.

PROBING — FIVE FACETS, THEN THE HARDEST FOLLOW-UPS NEW

THE FIVE FACETS — WHERE EACH ONE LIVES IN THIS STORY

1 · Data analysis. Grain: SKU × node × channel × bucket × event. Sources: the bucket inventory (both books), the event inventory (POS, OMS, WMS, S/4 movement types 101/311/601/701/702), the 836-row issues log (severity, owner, function). Cuts: events by bucket cardinality (0 / 1 / 2), defects by severity and by seam. Revealed: the log shows where the book is heavy — 523 of 836 rows (62.6%) sit in the Outbound, Retail and Inbound flows, where an event crosses from one system to the next — but it carries no cell tag, so the matrix's yield against it is not measured.

2 · Solution design. Options: (A) happy-path E2E only; (B) per-system unit tests; (C) an event × node-channel matrix with before/after assertions. Chose C — A and B each pass while the seam between systems is wrong. Why: the oversell bug is a seam bug, and a matrix makes coverage countable and gateable.

3 · Math & data logic. AFS = Basis − PickRes − EcomPick − EcomPack − SNB; Basis = min(S4_Avail, WMS_OnHand); cardinality rule: 0 buckets → +3 error (560), 2 buckets → −3 error (554), exactly 1 → 557; replay no-op; drift = ISM.S4_Avail − MB52 = 0; de-aggregation Σ per-line COGS = posting COGS to the cent.

4 · Implementation. Phases and gates above; owners: me (rule, cells, go/no-go), QA (gate), DC Ops/planners (UAT), control owners (screens). Controls: entry gate, E2E days, Blocker + Critical = 0, drift = 0. Risks: vocabulary drift, feed latency, override abuse (the register's top three).

5 · Probe questions. Below: why a matrix, how you know it mattered, what it missed, what 61 cells cost, and the three trap drills.

FACET 5 — PROBE QUESTIONS (CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER)

Infra — why a matrix and not just more E2E days?

E2E proves the paths someone thought to walk; a matrix lists the cells nobody walked. We ran both — three dated E2E days — but the entry gate (no story enters QA without a cell reference) is what made coverage countable. The log tells you what broke; the matrix tells you what you never tried.

Infra — how do you know the matrix is what kept incidents at zero?

I can't isolate it and I won't claim to. The record is: zero customer-facing incidents, 441 Blocker/Critical rows dispositioned, Blocker + Critical open = 0 at each go/no-go. The number that would change my mind is a customer-facing incident traced to an event that had no cell.

Infra — what did the matrix miss?

My own first in-transit rule. The cells asserted the rule I wrote — "never promise in-transit" — and it passed every cell while starving dotcom of fast movers one day from the building. The fix added four cells and a back-test requirement: a matrix asserts the rule; only history tells you the rule is right.

Infra — what is a cell, concretely?

One event at one node-channel pair with a before state, an after state and the numbers: e.g. a store rings 3 units at 10:02 — AFS 560 → 557, SNB 40 → 43, replay at 10:04 → 557, overnight posting → S4_Avail 957, drift 0.

Infra — your 61-cell count — real?

No. Six node-channel pairs, 14 events, 84 candidate cells minus 36 structurally impossible = 48, plus 4 in-transit cells and a 3-case family on 3 event sources = 61 — all illustrative sizing. The record is the rule, the families and the log; I would confirm the actual count before quoting one.

Infra — what would you do differently?

Tag every issues-log row with its matrix cell from day one. I can say every story needed a cell reference; I cannot say what share of the 441 Blocker/Critical rows was found by a cell assertion rather than an E2E room. That is the one number that would prove the matrix's yield.

BUSINESS IMPACT MODEL — KPI DRIVERS, BASELINE → AFTER

DRIVER	BASELINE	AFTER	$ / EFFECT	BASIS
Event → bucket cardinality	unverified (0 or 2 possible)	exactly 1, asserted per live cell	±3 units per event on the worked SKU	record design
Working definitions of "available"	3	1 signed AFS	—	record
Blocker + Critical open at go/no-go	441 logged (52.8% of 836)	0 open at each go/no-go	—	record
Issues closed	836 rows	714 closed (85.4%)	—	record
Customer-facing incidents	0 allowed	0 through both go-lives	what-if ≈$14.8K/yr per escaped cell-class	record / modeled what-if

THE MATH — FOUR-TABLE DERIVATION (FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION → RESULT) NEW

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Working definitions	`definitions = 3 (Store · Retail DC · Dotcom DC)`	record	3
2	Definition A over-promise	`channel reads raw S/4: promises 1,000; truly promisable 560; 1,000 − 560 = 440`	S1 worked SKU (illustrative); committed buckets invisible	440 units over-promised
3	Definition B over-promise	`channel reads WMS on-hand: 980 − 560 = 420`	same SKU; same blind spot	420 units over-promised
4	Units already spoken for	`Σ buckets = 200 + 120 + 60 + 40 = 420`	PickRes 200 · EcomPick 120 · EcomPack 60 · SNB 40 (illustrative)	420 units
5	Event lands in 0 buckets	`store rings 3; AFS stays 560; true 560 − 3 = 557; error = 560 − 557 = +3`	illustrative event	+3 oversell exposure
6	Event lands in 2 buckets	`AFS = 560 − 3 − 3 = 554; error = 557 − 554 = −3`	double-subtract path (illustrative)	−3 hidden units

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
7	Issues log	`164 Blocker + 277 Critical = 441; 441 / 836 = 52.8%`	record (issues log)	52.8% high-severity

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Cell: supply basis	`Basis = min(1,000, 980) = 980`	asymmetric lower-of-two (record design)	980
2	Cell: AFS	`AFS = 980 − 200 − 120 − 60 − 40 = 560`	AFS = Basis − PickRes − EcomPick − EcomPack − SNB	560
3	Cell: floor above book	`Basis = min(1,000, 1,020) = 1,000; AFS = 1,000 − 420 = 580`	WMS 1,020 → OOB = −20 (illustrative)	580, not 600
4	Cell: store ring	`AFS = 560 − 3 = 557; SNB = 40 + 3 = 43`	one event → one bucket	557 / 43
5	Cell: replay	`replayed key → no-op; AFS = 557 − 0 = 557`	idempotency key (record design)	557
6	Cell: overnight posting + drift	`S4_Avail = 1,000 − 43 = 957; drift = 957 − 957 = 0`	tolerance 0 — a non-zero drift is a Sev	0
7	Cell: de-aggregation	`COGS_i = $300 × q_i / 12 → $75 + $50 + $100 + $25 + $50 = $300`	posting q = 12, C = $300; five lines (illustrative); last line absorbs rounding	$300.00 to the cent
8	Cell: late line	`SNB = 12 − 10 = 2 → aged row on the 24 h report`	one line (q = 2) late (illustrative)	2
9	Cell: in-transit lane	`Promisable = 120 × 1[0.4 ≤ 0.49] × 1[97% ≥ 95%] = 120 × 1 × 1 = 120; failing lane 80 × 0 = 0`	σ ≈ 0.3 d, window ≈ 0.49 d (record promise math); lane values illustrative	120 / 0
10	Sizing of the matrix	`6 pairs × 14 events = 84; 84 − 36 = 48; 48 + 4 + (3 × 3) = 61 live cells`	**illustrative** counts; 4 and the 3-case family are record	61

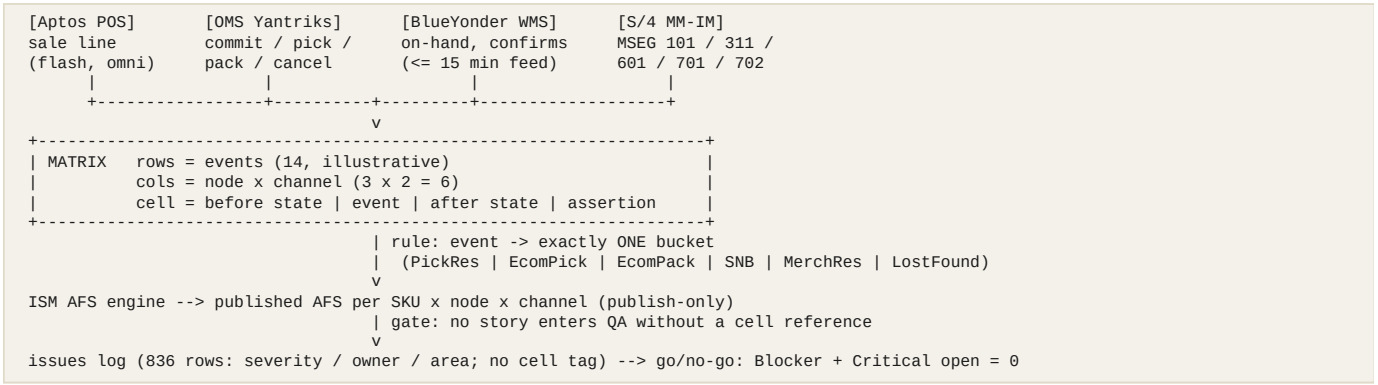
Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Working definitions of “available”	3	1 signed AFS	record
2	Event → bucket cardinality	0 or 2 possible	exactly 1 on every live cell	record design
3	Blocker + Critical open at go/no-go	441 logged of 836	0 open	record
4	Issues closed	0 of 836 at kickoff	714 of 836 = 85.4%	record
5	Customer-facing incidents	0 allowed	0 through both go-lives	record
6	Drift (ISM vs MB52)	unmeasured	0 SKUs on consecutive days	record

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Oversell-exposed incidents	`30,000,000 × 0.10% = 30,000/yr`	S1’s illustrative orders × benchmark rate (0.05–0.25%)	30,000/yr
2	Cost per incident	`$6 + $4 + $19 + $1 = $30`	CS contact · refund · lost margin · goodwill (benchmark)	$30
3	Exposure per live cell (uniform)	`30,000 / 61 = 491.8 incidents`	assumes uniform exposure across 61 cells (illustrative)	491.8/yr
4	Dollars per escaped cell-class	`491.8 × $30 = $14,754`	modeled what-if; not claimed	≈$14.8K/yr
5	Cost to author + run the matrix	`61 × 4 h = 244 h; 244 × $110 = $26,840`	4 h per cell (illustrative); $110/h engineering rate (modeled, as S5)	≈$26.8K one-time
6	Break-even	`$26,840 / $14,754 = 1.8`	escaped cell-classes per year to pay for the matrix	≈1.8 cell-classes

SOLUTION FLOW — THE SYSTEM & DATA MAP



SENSITIVITY — LOW / BASE / HIGH

INPUT	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Live cells (at 4 h × $110/h)	48 → $21.1K	61 → $26.8K	80 → $35.2K
Hours per cell (at 61 cells)	2 h → $13.4K	4 h → $26.8K	6 h → $40.3K
Oversell-exposed incidents / yr	15,000 (0.05%)	30,000 (0.10%)	75,000 (0.25%)
$ per escaped cell-class (÷ 61 × $30)	$7.4K	$14.8K	$36.9K
Break-even escaped cell-classes (at $26.8K)	3.6	1.8	0.7

SPOKEN STATEMENT

> “What I can prove is the rule and the gate: every physical event maps to exactly one bucket, and no story entered QA without a cell reference. Through both go-lives there were zero customer-facing incidents, with 836 issues logged — 441 Blocker or Critical, 52.8% — and 714 closed. What I cannot prove is how many of those the matrix caught versus the E2E rooms. The dollar view is a what-if on illustrative inputs: if the matrix keeps about two cell-classes a year from escaping, it has paid for itself.”

IF CHALLENGED

“Your cell count is invented.”

The design counts are illustrative sizing and I label them that way; the rule, the three de-aggregation cases, the four in-transit cells and the log are record. I would pull the real matrix from the QA workbooks before quoting a count.

“A matrix is shelfware — how do you know it was used?”

The entry gate: a story could not enter QA without a cell reference, and QA owned the gate and could fail a build. Use is enforced by the workflow, not by goodwill.

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you simplified a complex process.	Invent and Simplify	One rule (event → exactly one bucket), one asset (the matrix), one gate (cell reference to enter QA) across about a dozen impacted systems.	Do not quote 61 as the real count.
Tell me about a time you dug into the data to find a root cause.	Dive Deep	Event traces on one SKU: 0 buckets → 560, 2 buckets → 554, 1 bucket → 557; defects clustered at seams.	Never claim the matrix alone kept incidents at zero.
What does ‘tested’ mean to you?	Insist on the Highest Standards	Every live cell asserted with numbers; three dated E2E days; Blocker + Critical open = 0.	Skip the Kafka/ESB topology unless asked.
How do you test a launch at scale?	Functional — launch readiness	Coverage countable by cell; QA owns the gate; counted rows at go/no-go.	Never ‘I configured ISM’.

BEHAVIORAL PACK — FOUR SEPARATE 90-SECOND STAR ANSWERS, EACH FROM A DIFFERENT MOMENT OF THE STORY NEW

DIVE DEEP · AIQB Q1 **Q1. "Tell me about a time when you were trying to understand a complex problem on your team and you had to dig into the details to figure it out."**

I stopped reading oversell reports and started reading event traces — one SKU, one day, every event, every bucket. The pattern was never "the system is wrong"; it was an event landing in zero buckets or two. Take the worked SKU: 560 available. A store rings three units. If the event hits no bucket, AFS stays 560 and we promise three units that are gone. If it hits two — sold and shipped-not-billed both decrement — AFS goes to 554 and we hide three. Same event, three possible answers, one right: 557. So I wrote one rule — every event maps to exactly one bucket, a reversal must reference its original, a replay is a no-op — and turned it into before/after assertions per cell. Then I read the issues log against it: 836 rows, 441 Blocker or Critical. The defects were not random; they clustered where two systems used different grain. The result: zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives, and a rule the control owners could keep using after I left.

Number to land: 557 — not 560, not 554 · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF the same trace is unload → scan → stow → sellable; I would pull one ASIN's inbound event trace and look for events that land in zero or two states. · **Do NOT say:** that I wrote the code or personally found the bugs; that the matrix alone kept incidents at zero.

INVENT AND SIMPLIFY · AIQB Q1 **Q2. "Give me an example of a complex problem you solved with a simple solution."**

About a dozen impacted systems, about thirty build tracks — and I refused to write thirty test plans. I wrote one asset: a matrix of physical events against node-and-channel cells, each with a before and after assertion, and one entry rule — no story enters QA without a cell reference. Epics were per module — reserve module, AFS engine, SNB, control screens — slotted by business criticality × effort, so every track mapped onto the same cells. That turned "is it ready?" from an argument into a count: Blocker plus Critical open equals zero, and every live cell green. When my first in-transit rule turned out wrong, the matrix absorbed the fix as four new rows, not a new project. The same logic made a new node or channel a matrix row. The result was zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives with 85.4% of 836 logged issues closed.

Number to land: one rule · one asset · one gate (cell reference to enter QA) · **Pivot to NACF:** NACF launches many parallel tracks — a new vendor cohort, a new IXD lane; one event × node matrix gives a countable ready-to-launch gate. · **Do NOT say:** the 61-cell count as fact; that I built the tooling.

INSIST ON THE HIGHEST STANDARDS · AIQB Q2 **Q3. "Tell me about a time when you were unsatisfied with the status quo. What did you do to change it?"**

I changed what "tested" meant: not 'we ran the flow' but 'every live cell asserted, with numbers, before and after.' Each cell carried an expected state — AFS 560 to 557, SNB 40 to 43, drift zero — so a pass was a number, not an opinion. Then I put the standard in rooms, not memos: three dated end-to-end days — Inbound 11/22, Dotcom 12/20, Retail 1/30 — with every function in one room, every finding logged with a severity and an owner before anyone left. The go/no-go bar was written in advance: Blocker plus Critical open equals zero, mock three inside the 0.5% tolerance, runbook rehearsed, rollback armed. I said I would have called no-go on one open Blocker — and I never had to. The result: zero customer-facing incidents, and a gate QA, not I, defended.

Number to land: three dated E2E days; Blocker + Critical open = 0 · **Pivot to NACF:** Before any NACF launch I would publish the same bar — what the gate asserts, in numbers, and who may fail it. · **Do NOT say:** that I never faced pressure; that the bar was only mine — QA owned the gate.

EARN TRUST · AIQB Q5 **Q4. "Tell me about a time when your team's goals were out of alignment with another team you relied on in order to meet your goal."**

DC Ops did not trust a systems program to respect the floor, so I made sure nothing reached them as a surprise. During build, QA demoed each matrix family — receipts, transfers, pick and pack reserves, ship confirms — to DC Ops and the planners. By the time UAT started, their sign-off was confirmation, not discovery. QA owned the gate and could fail a build, and DC Ops saw that it could. I also kept the floor's reality inside the design: the January planning go-live (purchasing and inbound, reserve rules live against demand) left the floor untouched, and warehouse execution moved only in May. The result was go-lives where DC Ops owned the robotics gate and the dial and the floor ran on them, with zero customer-facing incidents.

Number to land: January reserve rules first; May execution second; zero incidents · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF I would demo each inbound event family to the building before the first live trailer — the same 'confirmation, not discovery' rule. · **Do NOT say:** that I ran the floor; DC Ops did.

SAME STORY, THREE ANGLES — DATA · CONFLICT/INFLUENCE/BACKBONE · FAILURE-LEARNING NEW

DATA ANGLE · DIVE DEEP

"Start with the log: 836 rows, 441 of them Blocker or Critical — 52.8%."

Headline metric: 441 / 836 = 52.8% high-severity; 714 closed = 85.4%

Cut the log by severity, owner and seam; the matrix made coverage countable. What it revealed: 62.6% of the rows sit in the three flows where an event crosses systems (Outbound 238, Retail 172, Inbound 113 = 523, computed from the file), which is where the matrix cells concentrate. Honest limit: rows were not tagged by cell.

CONFLICT / INFLUENCE ANGLE · EARN TRUST

"I owned a test asset for ~30 build tracks in other orgs and none of them reported to me."

Headline metric: ~30 build tracks · one entry gate

The gate (no story enters QA without a cell reference) moved every track onto one asset; QA owned it and could fail a build; DC Ops confirmed because QA had already demoed to them. Influence came from a countable rule, not rank.

FAILURE / LEARNING ANGLE · ARE RIGHT, A LOT

"My own first in-transit rule passed every cell I wrote — and it was wrong."

Headline metric: $\sigma \approx 0.3$ d → window ≈ 0.49 d ≈ 95%; 4 cells added

"Never promise in-transit" starved dotcom of fast movers one day from the building; the matrix asserted my rule, not whether the rule was right. Now: both sides of a rule get a number, back-test against history first. (Record: master S4.)

TRAP DRILLS — THE THREE NASTIEST FOLLOW-UPS, WITH NUMERIC ANSWERS NEW

How do you know it was the matrix and not the E2E days or the team?

You cannot, and I would not claim it. Record: zero customer-facing incidents, 441 Blocker/Critical rows dispositioned, B+C open = 0 at go/no-go. The measurable yield is the share of the 441 first detected by a cell assertion — the log was not tagged by cell, so I cannot produce it.

Say: *"I can't isolate the matrix from the E2E days; the number that would change my mind is a customer-facing incident traced to an event with no cell."*

Why is a 61-cell matrix not over-engineering against an 836-row log?

The log is the detector; the matrix is the coverage map. At 4 h a cell, 61 cells is 244 h ≈ $26.8K (modeled); one escaped cell-class is ≈$14.8K/yr on illustrative inputs — break-even ≈1.8 cell-classes.

Say: *"The log tells me what broke; the matrix tells me what I never tried — and it costs less than two escaped cell-classes."*

What did the matrix not catch, and what changed?

The v1 in-transit rule: cells asserted my rule and it was wrong; the fix added four cells and a back-test-before-publish requirement (σ ≈ 0.3 d, window ≈ 0.49 d ≈ 95%).

Say: *"A matrix checks that the system does what the rule says; only history tells you whether the rule is right — so now both sides of a rule get a number first."*

20-SECOND VERSION + NACF BRIDGE NEW

20-second version. At the Utah DC I made "tested" countable: every physical event had to land in exactly one inventory bucket, each cell asserted before and after, and no story entered QA without a cell reference — zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives, with 441 of 836 logged issues Blocker or Critical and none reaching a customer.

NACF bridge. NACF inbound has the same seam — a trailer unloaded, a pallet received, a unit stowed, a unit sellable. The booklet's "stranded" inventory is exactly an event that landed in zero states. I would build the same event × node matrix for receive → stow → sellable so every dock event lands in exactly one inventory state before a new FC ramps.

U2 — The profile before the design — SKU overlap, order shape and demand variability per node across both books (MCS and S/4): the discovery that sized the one-pool case and bounded its $2.2M NEW

LPs this story serves here: Dive Deep (primary — both books at SKU × node grain) · Are Right, A Lot (a bounded claim with a kill number) · Learn and Be Curious (backup — the pooling math and the retail/dotcom order shapes) · Think Big (backup — two pools to one)

Process family: Plan / Source — inventory positioning and pooling analysis; the discovery profile that sized the case for one comingle pool

Honesty label. Record: Discovery (3/29 → 4/30) profiled both books — MCS and S/4 — and the 801/901 nodes for SKU overlap and order profiles per node, with node-by-node sessions across ~15 functions; the design argument started from their data. The √2 pooling release, the $50M average inventory × 25% safety stock × 60% overlap and the ≈$1.6M/yr are S2's **modeled** numbers on an illustrative 100K-units/week DC. **Not in the record:** the profile's actual outputs — measured overlap, σ ratio, correlation, order-shape cuts. Every range below is toolkit math on labeled inputs. Never say the profile "measured" a release; say it bounded one.

LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES CARRIED — ONE-LINE PROOF EACH

Dive Deep. I profiled both books at SKU × node grain before any design argument, so the debate started from their own data instead of opinions about it.

Are Right, A Lot. I refused to carry the textbook $2.2M as a point: I showed what would shrink it (unequal pools, correlation), bounded it at ≈$0.74M–$2.20M, and named the measurement that settles it.

Learn and Be Curious. I worked the variance-pooling formulas by hand on small numbers and learned the retail-vs-dotcom order shapes in the node sessions, so I could ask the right three questions of the data.

Think Big. The recommendation was structural — two pools to one, with three planning identities — and it stood even when the pooling dollars shrank, because the case never rested on them alone.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Before anyone argued design at Sephora's Utah DC, there were two inventory books — MCS and S/4 — and two systemic warehouses in one building, Dotcom 801 and Retail 901, and a business case that said "pool them." Whether pooling was worth it turned on three things nobody had put side by side: how many SKUs both pools carried, whether the two nodes' orders looked alike, and how variable and how correlated the demand was. **Task.** Own the discovery profile that the location and inventory model would stand on — about a dozen impacted systems, 60+ stakeholders, none reporting to me. **Action.** Discovery ran 3/29 to 4/30: both books profiled for SKU overlap and order profiles per node, node-by-node sessions across about fifteen functions. I turned the profile into three tests — overlap, order shape, variability — and a bounded claim: textbook √2 pooling on $7.5M of duplicated poolable safety stock is a $2.2M ceiling; unequal or correlated pools cut it to roughly $0.7M to $2.2M, and about 87% of the $1.6M a year modeled benefit does not depend on pooling at all. That fed the decision — one physical pool, three planning identities. **Result.** Primary metric: the one-time pooling claim moved from a single textbook number to a bounded range, about $0.7M to $2.2M, modeled, with discovery closed on 4/30. The +15% and the zero incidents are S2's record; the profile outputs are illustrative and I would not quote them as measured.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — Two systemic warehouses in one building transferring stock to itself, two books (MCS and S/4), a case for one comingle pool resting on three unmeasured assumptions: that both pools carry the same SKUs, that their orders look alike enough to share a pick face, and that pooling their demand variability would release stock. A pooling claim built on a textbook assumption is the first number a skeptic pulls on.

T — Produce the profile the design could stand on and a claim that survives the first pull: which SKUs overlap, what each node's order looks like, how much of the $2.2M survives unequal and correlated pools — and which measurement turns the model into a record. None of the systems or analysts reported to me; ~15 functions sat in the sessions.

Baselines on the table: planning pools 2 · average inventory $50M (illustrative) × 25% safety stock × 60% held in SKUs both pools carry = $7.5M duplicated poolable stock · self-transfers ≈260,000 units/yr ≈5.0% of an illustrative 5.2M units/yr · efficiency index 100.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (3/29 → 4/30)** — pulled both books at SKU × node grain; cut for overlap (which SKUs live in both 801 and 901), order shape per node (retail store-replenishment style vs dotcom small-order style), and demand variability per SKU; ran node-by-node sessions with ~15 functions; wrote the bucket inventory. *Exit bar:* sessions closed 4/30; every bucket owned by one system; open questions carried with owner and date.

- **Plan & Design (5/15 → 8/14)** — turned the profile into the three-identity design (one physical location, three planning lenses) and into a bounded pooling claim in the sponsor pack: ceiling $2.2M, plausible floor ≈$0.74M, recurring benefit mostly independent of pooling. *Exit bar:* council sign-off 7/31 and FSD 8/14 with the range, not a point, in the case.
- **Build & Test (Aug → Jan/Apr)** — carried the profile's cuts into the matrix rows (U1) and the interim shadow monitor; the node/channel/order-shape cuts became test families. *Exit bar:* matrix families trace to a profile cut; E2E days 11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30.
- **Cutover & Go-Live (January; May 1 → Jul 1)** — no new analysis on the critical path — the profile's job was done at design; it re-entered only as the reference for the "which book does this report read" declaration during the interim. *Exit bar:* every report declared its system of record for the interim.
- **Hypercare / Close (Jun → Jul)** — the record's own firming measurement — SKU-level on-hand on the last day of 801 against the first stable month of 901 — is the way the release becomes a record; flagged as the open measurement. *Exit bar:* pooling stays labeled "modeled" until that comparison is run.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the profile design, the three tests, the bounded claim, the design recommendation. Others': the extracts (platform/data teams), the node sessions (DC Ops, Planning, Digital, Finance), the sign-off (steering). Digital's worry that a virtual Retail DC would blur their forecasting lens was answered by the design — three planning identities over one physical location — not by an argument.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** The profile cuts (overlap · order shape · variability) are the template the next DC's discovery reused; the three-identity design is the standing location model. **Trade-off put to leadership:** a precise-looking $2.2M versus an honest range — I took the range, because the first number a skeptic pulls on is the one resting on an assumption.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY

- **$** — pooling release (one-time, modeled): textbook ceiling $7.5M × 29.3% = ≈$2.2M; plausible floor ≈$0.74M at σ ratio 1/3 and ρ = 0.5. Recurring ≈$1.43M (87% of ≈$1.65M) does not depend on pooling. All modeled on S2's illustrative DC — never signed.
- **#** — 2 books profiled · 2 planning pools → 1 · 3 planning identities · self-transfers ≈260,000 units/yr (≈5.0% of illustrative volume) → 0 by construction (record design).
- **%** — release range 9.9%–29.3% of poolable stock; overlap sensitivity 40/60/80% → $1.46M / $2.20M / $2.93M (modeled).
- **Time** — sessions closed 4/30 (record); the profile preceded council 5/15 → sign-off 7/31 → FSD 8/14.
- **Customer** — zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives (S2 record) — the constraint the one-pool design had to live inside.
- **Quality** — every pooling dollar carries its input and basis label; the claim names the measurement that would firm it.

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — every line is this story's record or labeled model, no new canon numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	A case for pooling resting on assumptions nobody had measured. I defined the three tests and what each would change.
Scope & influence	~15 functions in node sessions; extracts from data teams; steering signed the criteria. I influenced by putting their numbers on one page.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others own	Point estimate versus honest range — chose the range. Mechanism others own: the three-test profile and the bounded-claim format in the sponsor pack.
Impact	A one-pool design whose recommendation survived a ≈$1.5M-smaller worst case on the one-time number.
Process improvement	Discovery ends with a profile (overlap · shape · variability) and a measurement that converts the model to a record — reused by the next DC.
Complexity & consensus	Retail and dotcom order shapes, two books and three planning lenses reconciled into one location model.
Root cause at scale	The fragile part of the case was an assumption (equal, independent pools), not a number; bounding it removed the single point of failure.

PROBING — FIVE FACETS, THEN THE HARDEST FOLLOW-UPS NEW

THE FIVE FACETS — WHERE EACH ONE LIVES IN THIS STORY

1 · Data analysis. Grain: SKU × node (801 / 901 / stores) in both books. Joins: MCS ↔ S/4 on SKU; overlap flag by node pair; demand history per SKU per node. Cuts: overlap by value; order shape per node (lines per order, units per line — illustrative until pulled); σ and correlation per overlapping SKU. Revealed (modeled): the case is most sensitive to correlation and σ ratio, and least to overlap, once the textbook is replaced by the range.

2 · Solution design. Options: (A) keep two pools and reconcile (status quo); (B) pool physically but plan as one blended identity; (C) one physical pool, three planning identities. Chose C — A keeps self-transfers; B blurs the forecasting lens Digital needed. Why: the profile showed the case did not need the safety-stock row to be big.

3 · Math & data logic. Equal independent pools: release = $1 - 1/\sqrt{n} = 1 - 1/\sqrt{2} = 29.3\%$. Unequal: $1 - \sqrt{(\sigma_1^2+\sigma_2^2)}/(\sigma_1+\sigma_2)$. Correlated: $1 - \sqrt{(\sigma_1^2+\sigma_2^2+2\rho\sigma_1\sigma_2)}/(\sigma_1+\sigma_2)$. Dollars = poolable stock × release; carry = release × 10%. Break-even sentence: the claim fails only if the recurring rows fail.

4 · Implementation. Discovery 3/29 → 4/30; design to FSD 8/14; the profile cuts carried into matrix rows; the SKU-level on-hand comparison (last day 801 vs first stable month 901) is the firming measurement. Owners: me (profile and claim), data teams (extracts), Finance (inventory

valuation).

5 · Probe questions. Below: why not trust √2, how you know the 60%, what if overlap is 20%, did the profile change the design, and the three trap drills.

FACET 5 — PROBE QUESTIONS (CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER)

Infra — why not just trust √2?

Because it assumes two equal, independent pools on the same SKUs — three assumptions at once. I showed the release at σ ratio 1, 1/2, 1/3 and 1/4 (29.3%, 25.5%, 20.9%, 17.5%) and at correlation 0.3 and 0.5 (19.4%, 13.4%); jointly pessimistic it is 9.9%. The textbook is the ceiling, not the base.

Infra — how do you know the overlap is 60%?

I don't — it is S2's illustrative input, the share of poolable stock in SKUs both pools carry. The profile is what measures it; at 20% overlap the equal-pool release is $0.73M, at 80% $2.93M. The case never depended on getting that one right.

Infra — if the release is that uncertain, why pool at all?

Because the pooling carry is only 13% of the modeled recurring benefit. Labor at +15% (≈$0.88M, record efficiency), split shipments (≈$0.45M) and self-transfer handling (≈$0.10M) are $1.43M; self-transfers alone were ≈260,000 units a year of movement that created no value.

Infra — did the profile change the design?

It shaped it: it is why I kept three planning identities over one physical location rather than one blended lens, and why the matrix has rows per node type and order shape. I would not claim it changed the decision to pool; that case was already strong on the recurring rows.

Infra — what would you pull first at a new node?

SKU-level on-hand and sales for the two pools, joined by SKU: overlap by value, σ and correlation per SKU, then order shape — lines per order and units per line. Three pulls, one afternoon, and the claim has inputs.

BUSINESS IMPACT MODEL — KPI DRIVERS, BASELINE → AFTER

DRIVER	BASELINE	AFTER	$ / EFFECT	BASIS
Planning pools	2	1 (three planning identities)	self-transfers → 0	record design
Pooling claim (one-time)	≈$2.2M point	≈$0.74M–$2.20M range	carry ≈$0.07M–$0.22M/yr	modeled (toolkit label)
Benefit independent of pooling	not separated	≈$1.43M/yr (87%)	labor + splits + self-transfer	modeled; +15% is record
Overlap sensitivity (equal pools)	—	40/60/80% → $1.46M / $2.20M / $2.93M	—	modeled
Measurement to firm the release	none	last-day 801 vs first-month 901 SKU on-hand	turns model into record	record proposal

THE MATH — FOUR-TABLE DERIVATION (FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION → RESULT) NEW

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Warehouses / pools	`planning pools = 2 (801 and 900/901 identities)`	record	2
2	Duplicated safety stock	`$50M × 25% = $12.5M; × 60% = $7.5M`	average inventory, SS share and overlap share are S2's illustrative inputs (modeled)	$7.5M poolable
3	Self-transfer burden	`260,000 / (100,000 × 52) = 260,000 / 5,200,000 = 5.0%`	260K units/yr modeled; 100K units/wk illustrative	5.0% of volume is non-work
4	Textbook release	`1 − 1/√2 = 1 − 0.707 = 29.3%`	equal, independent pools (toolkit label)	29.3%
5	What the textbook never saw	`σ ratio r = σ₂/σ₁ and correlation ρ unmeasured`	VERIFY — profile outputs not in the record	release could be lower

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Test 1 — overlap	`poolable = $12.5M × overlap → 40%: $5.0M · 60%: $7.5M · 80%: $10.0M`	overlap is a measured input at a new node	$5.0M / $7.5M / $10.0M
2	Test 2 — σ ratio	`f(r) = 1 − √(1+r²)/(1+r): r=1 → 29.3% · r=½ → 25.5% · r=⅓ → 20.9% · r=¼ → 17.5%`	unequal independent pools (toolkit label)	17.5%–29.3%
3	Test 3 — correlation (equal pools)	`f(ρ) = 1 − √((1+ρ)/2): ρ=0.3 → 1 − √0.65 = 19.4% · ρ=0.5 → 1 − √0.75 = 13.4%`	equal σ; correlation reduces release	13.4%–19.4%

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
4	Jointly pessimistic	`r = ⅓, ρ = 0.5: 1 − √(1 + 1/9 + 2×0.5×⅓)/(4/3) = 1 − √1.4444/1.3333 = 1 − 1.2019/1.3333 = 9.9%`	illustrative corner of the range	9.9%
5	Dollar range	`$7.5M × 9.9% = $0.74M · $7.5M × 29.3% = $2.20M`	poolable stock × release	≈$0.74M–$2.20M
6	Firming measurement	`last-day 801 SKU on-hand vs first stable month of 901 → release = the difference`	the record's own proposal (not yet run — VERIFY)	model → record

Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Planning pools	2	1	record design
2	One-time pooling claim	$2.2M point (textbook)	$0.74M–$2.20M range	modeled
3	Recurring benefit independent of pooling	not separated	$1.43M of $1.65M = 86.7%	modeled
4	Self-transfers	≈260,000 units/yr	0 by construction	record design
5	Headline total (recurring)	≈$1.65M	≈$1.50M–$1.65M	modeled

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Labor at +15%	`31,300 h × $28 = $876,400`	hours from S2 (record +15%); $28 loaded (modeled)	≈$0.88M/yr
2	Split shipments	`45,000 × $10 = $450,000`	S2 softest row (modeled)	≈$0.45M/yr
3	Self-transfer handling	`260,000 × $0.80 × 50% = $104,000`	the other half already sits in labor (modeled)	≈$0.10M/yr
4	Recurring without pooling	`876,400 + 450,000 + 104,000 = $1,430,400`	rows 1–3	≈$1.43M/yr
5	Carry on the release	`$2.2M × 10% = $220,000 · $0.74M × 10% = $73,959`	10% cost of capital (benchmark 8–12%)	≈$0.22M / ≈$0.07M
6	Headline range	`1,430,400 + 220,000 = $1,650,400 · 1,430,400 + 73,959 = $1,504,359`	rows 4–5	≈$1.65M / ≈$1.50M

SOLUTION FLOW — THE SYSTEM & DATA MAP

```
[MCS book]           [S/4 book]           [Demand history]
801 on-hand          900 / 901 on-hand    sales by SKU x node
     |                    |                    |
     +----------+----------+--------------------+
                v
JOIN on SKU -> overlap flag by value                    (Test 1: 40 / 60 / 80%)
                v
per overlapping SKU: sigma_801, sigma_901, rho          (Tests 2 and 3)
                v
release f = 1 - sqrt(s1^2 + s2^2 + 2*rho*s1*s2) / (s1 + s2)
                v
$ = poolable stock x f  ->  range 9.9% .. 29.3%         (bounded claim)
                v
order shape per node (lines/order, units/line) -> matrix rows + slotting questions
                v
DESIGN: one physical pool, three planning identities
```

SENSITIVITY — LOW / BASE / HIGH

INPUT	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Overlap share (equal pools)	40% → $1.46M	60% → $2.20M	80% → $2.93M
σ ratio r (ρ = 0)	⅓ → $1.57M	½ → $1.91M	1 → $2.20M
Correlation ρ (r = 1)	0.5 → $1.00M	0.3 → $1.45M	0 → $2.20M
Cost of capital on $2.2M	8% → $0.18M	10% → $0.22M	12% → $0.26M
Headline recurring total	≈$1.50M (floor release)	≈$1.65M (ceiling release)	pooling row ≤ 13% of total

SPOKEN STATEMENT

> "The profile did two things. It told me which SKUs, which node shapes and how much variability the case rested on, and it kept me from carrying a textbook number as a fact. The pooling release is about $2.2 million at the ceiling — equal, independent pools — and about three-quarters of a million at a pessimistic corner; I show the range. What does not move is that about 87% of the modeled benefit is labor at the signed +15%, split shipments and self-transfers, none of which depend on pooling. The thing that turns the model into a record is one comparison: SKU-level on-hand the last day of 801 against the first stable month of 901."

IF CHALLENGED

"So the $2.2M in S2 is wrong?"

It is the ceiling on S2's stated inputs, and S2 labels it modeled and textbook. This story is the bounding of it — what survives if the pools are unequal or correlated — not a retraction.

"You never ran the comparison?"

I would not claim it. The comparison is the measurement the record proposes; until it is run the number stays labeled modeled. If you ask me whether pooling released that stock, my answer is: here is the range and here is the one-afternoon pull that settles it.

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you used data to challenge an assumption.	Dive Deep	Both books at SKU × node grain; the equal-independent-pools assumption bounded at 9.9%–29.3%.	Never say the profile "measured" the release.
Tell me about a decision you made with incomplete data.	Are Right, A Lot	A bounded claim with a named measurement; recommendation stable across the whole range.	Do not present the 60% overlap as measured.
Tell me about learning something outside your area.	Learn and Be Curious	Variance pooling and the order shapes at retail vs dotcom nodes.	Skip the BlueYonder/Locus internals.
How do you decide whether to consolidate nodes in a network?	Functional — network design	Overlap, order shape, variability/correlation; recurring rows first, safety stock last.	Never quote $2.2M as a record.

BEHAVIORAL PACK — FOUR SEPARATE 90-SECOND STAR ANSWERS, EACH FROM A DIFFERENT MOMENT OF THE STORY NEW

DIVE DEEP · AIQB Q3 **Q1. "Tell me about a problem you had to solve that required in-depth thought and analysis."**

The accepted assumption was that two pools become one and safety stock drops by 29%. That is the square-root pooling result, and it assumes the two pools are equal and independent — which retail and dotcom demand for the same SKU almost certainly are not. So in discovery I stopped quoting the textbook and asked the data three questions: which SKUs do both pools carry, how big is each pool's variability relative to the other, and how correlated are they? I put the answer as a range instead of a point. Equal and independent gives 29.3%. If one pool is a third the size of the other, 20.9%. If correlation is 0.5, 13.4%. Jointly pessimistic, 9.9%. On $7.5 million of duplicated poolable stock that is $0.74 million to $2.2 million. Then I checked whether the case still stood: about 87% of the modeled benefit — labor at the signed +15%, split shipments, self-transfers — does not depend on pooling at all. The design stood; the claim became honest.

Number to land: 9.9%–29.3% → ≈$0.74M–$2.2M; 87% independent of pooling · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF the same three pulls decide whether two FCs' buffers belong together — same ASINs, same demand shape, correlation — before I claim any release. · **Do NOT say:** that the profile measured the release; that $2.2M is a record.

ARE RIGHT, A LOT · AIQB Q1 **Q2. "Tell me about a time when you didn't have enough data to make the right decision."**

I made the recommendation robust to the thing I did not know. I did not have measured σ or correlation for the overlapping SKUs when the sponsor pack was written. So I built the claim as a range with a kill number: the only way the one-pool recommendation fails is if the recurring rows fail, and those rest on a signed +15% efficiency, a split-shipment row I flagged as the softest, and the self-transfer move that disappears by construction. Then I named the measurement that converts model to record — SKU-level on-hand on the last day of 801 against the first stable month of 901 — and I told steering what number would change my mind: if split shipments didn't move, the total drops to about $1.1 million and I would say so. The recommendation was the same across the whole range, which is the test of a decision made with incomplete data.

Number to land: recommendation stable from $1.50M to $1.65M recurring · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF placement decisions are made on incomplete data constantly; the habit I would bring is a range, a kill number and the one measurement that firms it. · **Do NOT say:** that I knew the overlap; that the model was validated.

LEARN AND BE CURIOUS · AIQB Q1 **Q3. "Tell me about a time when you realized you needed a deeper level of subject matter expertise to do your job well."**

I started by asking what the word "pooling" actually assumes. The business case said "pooling," and I wanted to know exactly what that word assumed. So I worked the variance-pooling toolkit — equal independent pools, unequal pools, correlation — and checked each formula by hand on small numbers until I could do it on a whiteboard. Then I learned the shapes of the two nodes' orders: retail store-replenishment style versus dotcom single-customer orders, because that is what decides whether two pools can share a pick face. I sat in the node sessions with about fifteen functions asking what a normal day looked like. By the end of discovery I could explain, in one page, why the pooling number was a ceiling and what each node's order looked like. Zero customer-facing incidents later is not mine alone, but the design started from a profile I could defend.

Number to land: three formulas hand-checked; ~15 functions in node sessions · **Pivot to NACF:** NACF placement is the same toolkit — I would arrive having learned the ASIN-level demand shapes before proposing a buffer. · **Do NOT say:** that I invented the pooling math; it is the toolkit's, and I label it.

THINK BIG · AIQB Q1 **Q4. "Tell me about time when you were working on an initiative or goal and saw an opportunity to do something much bigger or better than the initial focus."**

The ask was to merge two warehouses' reporting; the bigger structure was one physical pool. Two systemic warehouses sat in one building and moved stock to each other — about 260,000 units a year on paper, roughly 5% of volume that created no value. I proposed collapsing them into one pool with three planning identities so each channel kept its forecasting lens without a second truth. Digital worried a virtual retail DC would blur their lens; I made the concern the design — the three identities — rather than arguing. The bigger structure was riskier, so I staged it: two go-lives, each carrying one defect class. And I made sure the case did not hang on the most uncertain number: even at the pessimistic pooling corner, the recurring benefit is about $1.5 million. Big, but with the downside bounded.

Number to land: ≈260K units/yr self-transfers → 0; 2 pools → 1 · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF a bigger structure — fewer buffers pooled upstream — needs the same discipline: bounded downside before ambition. · **Do NOT say:** that pooling alone paid for it; that the dollars are signed.

SAME STORY, THREE ANGLES — DATA · CONFLICT/INFLUENCE/BACKBONE · FAILURE-LEARNING NEW

DATA ANGLE · DIVE DEEP

"The textbook says 29%. Here is what survives when the pools are unequal and correlated."

Headline metric: 9.9%–29.3% release; $0.74M–$2.20M

Three tests (overlap, σ ratio, correlation) turned one number into a surface; the case's dependence on pooling is ≤13%. Honest limit: the inputs are illustrative until the profile is pulled.

CONFLICT / INFLUENCE ANGLE · EARN TRUST

"Digital worried a virtual Retail DC would blur their forecasting lens — the profile gave me a way to say yes to them."

Headline metric: 3 planning identities over 1 physical location

The concern became the design: each channel kept its lens; no second truth. No one had to lose an argument. Steering signed the criteria; DC Ops and Planning confirmed the node sessions.

FAILURE / LEARNING ANGLE · ARE RIGHT, A LOT

"In S2 I say $2.2M one-time — that is the equal-pools ceiling, and I should lead with the range."

Headline metric: $2.2M point → $0.74M–$2.20M range

I label it modeled and textbook, but a point invites the first pull and the first pull finds the equal-independent assumption. Do differently: say the range first, name the kill number, and never let the ceiling stand alone.

confirm whether the sponsor pack carried the poi

TRAP DRILLS — THE THREE NASTIEST FOLLOW-UPS, WITH NUMERIC ANSWERS NEW

What number would have changed your mind about pooling?

If the recurring rows failed: the split-shipment row (≈$0.45M, softest) not moving drops the total to ≈$1.1M; if the +15% were not signed the case would be different. Pooling's carry is only $0.07M–$0.22M/yr, so no outcome of the pooling math alone could flip it.

Say: *"The pooling row is at most 13% of the benefit, so the number that would change my mind is split shipments or the signed efficiency — not the safety-stock release."*

Isn't the 60% overlap just made up?

It is S2's illustrative input — said so. At 20% overlap the equal-pool release is $0.73M; at 80% it is $2.93M. The profile's job is to replace it with the measured value, join by SKU, value-weighted.

Say: *"It is an illustrative input I label as such; here is the one-afternoon pull that replaces it, and here is what the answer does to the claim across 20% to 80%."*

How do you know it was pooling and not seasonality that moved stock?

I can't — and I don't claim it. The record has +15% efficiency measured by DC Ops post-stabilization and zero incidents; the pooling release is modeled. The firming comparison is last-day 801 versus first stable month of 901 on SKU-level on-hand, seasonally matched.

Say: *"The pooling dollars are modeled; if you want it as a record, it is a seasonally-matched SKU-level on-hand comparison — that is the one measurement I would run."*

20-SECOND VERSION + NACF BRIDGE NEW

20-second version. Before the design argument at Sephora's Utah DC I profiled both inventory books for SKU overlap and order shape per node and turned the textbook pooling number — $2.2M — into a bounded range of about $0.74M to $2.2M, with about 87% of the modeled benefit not depending on pooling at all; that range, not a point, went into the sponsor pack.

NACF bridge. NACF's placement and buffer questions start with the same three pulls — do two FCs carry the same ASINs, do they see the same demand shape, how correlated are they — because pooling variability upstream only pays where correlation is low, and an INV-D transfer is how the pooled unit actually moves. I would bring the range-and-kill-number habit to any buffer-positioning claim.

U3 — Merch reserve — visible, never promisable: pricing the no (and the asymmetry behind it) so one comingled pool never sells stock the floor cannot pick NEW

LPs this story serves here: Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit (primary — the priced no) · Customer Obsession (oversell is a customer defect) · Earn Trust (visibility offered, the no written as a row) · Success and Scale Bring Broad Responsibility (a customer harm, not a ledger error)
Process family: Plan / Deliver — comingled-inventory allocation at a shared node: which stock is promisable to which channel, and which is physically present but not for sale

Honesty label. Record: Merch Reserve and Lost/Found sit outside S4_Avail, so there is no double-subtract path; Merchandising wanted merch reserve promisable; I priced it (unpickable stock sold) and offered visibility without promisability; the no went into the FSD as a row, not a meeting minute; the asymmetry (oversell is a customer defect, undersell a planning variance) is the policy; comingle-reserve improvements were held out of the release to protect zero incidents and priced as a later enhancement at steering; zero customer-facing oversell incidents through both go-lives. **Illustrative:** the 20% release rate, the 10,000-unit reserve, the 50-unit worked SKU and the retail/dotcom pool split. The margin $19 and the $6 + $4 + $1 + $19 = $30 incident cost are S1's benchmark. I do not know how Merchandising defined or sized the reserve. I owned the definition and the no; Merchandising owned the reserve.

LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES CARRIED — ONE-LINE PROOF EACH

Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit. Merchandising wanted merch reserve promisable; I priced it, said no, and wrote the no into the FSD as a row so it survived the room.

Customer Obsession. I treated oversell as a customer defect and undersell as a planning variance — and accepted visible undersell to make oversell zero by construction.

Earn Trust. I gave Merchandising what they actually needed — visibility of the reserve — so the no cost them a lever, not their standing.

Success and Scale Bring Broad Responsibility. A promise on stock the floor cannot pick is a customer harm at scale; the price in dollars was the floor of the argument, not the whole of it.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. At Sephora's Utah DC one physical pool had to serve two channels, and Merchandising held some of that stock back as reserve. Merchandising wanted the reserve promisable — it was in the building, so why not sell it. **Task.** I owned the definition of "available" across Store, Retail DC and Dotcom DC, and I owned no system. **Action.** Discovery: a bucket inventory where every bucket had one owning system; merch reserve and lost/found sat outside the supply the AFS engine computes from, so there was no double-subtract path. Plan & Design: I priced the ask — stock the floor may not pick, sold — as a break-even: promise it only if more than roughly 37 of every 100 reserved units would actually be released, and on a 20% release rate that is about −$50,000 per 10,000 units, or about −$200,000 on the all-in cost. Then I offered what Merchandising actually needed: visibility without promisability. The no went into the FSD as a row, signed by Strategy, Inventory Management and Inventory Accounting. Comingle-reserve improvements were held out of the release to protect zero incidents and priced as a later enhancement. **Result.** Primary metric: customer-facing oversell incidents — recurring across three node types → zero through both go-lives, with zero units of merch reserve in published AFS. The dollars are a what-if on labeled inputs; the zero is the record.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — One physical pool, two channels, three planning identities — and stock physically in the building that was not for sale: Merchandising's reserve, lost-and-found. Merchandising wanted the reserve promisable; Finance wanted on-hand to tie to the book; dotcom wanted in-transit promisable. Most oversell bugs are vocabulary bugs, and "available" had three meanings.

T — Define, per node and per channel, which buckets are subtracted from supply and which sit outside it — and say no to the one request that would have turned unpickable stock into a promise. I owned no system; the signatories were Supply Chain Strategy, Inventory Management and FSC Inventory Accounting.

Baselines on the table: working definitions of "available" 3 · customer-facing oversell incidents recurring across three node types, target zero · worked SKU: Basis 980, buckets 420, AFS 560 · merch reserve and lost/found outside S4_Avail.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (3/29 → 4/30)** — bucket inventory with one proposed owning system per bucket; node-by-node sessions; Merchandising's need written down as a need — see the reserve — not as a mechanism. *Exit bar:* every bucket owned by exactly one system; sessions closed 4/30.
- **Plan & Design (5/15 → 8/14)** — kept merch reserve and lost/found outside S4_Avail; wrote the lower-of-two basis and the AFS equation; priced the promisable-reserve ask as a break-even; offered visibility without promisability; held the asymmetry. *Exit bar:* FSD signed 8/14;

the no is a row; every bucket owned by exactly one system.

- **Build & Test (Aug → Jan/Apr)** — matrix cells that assert the reserve never appears in published AFS (U1) and a visibility view for Merchandising; held the comingle-reserve improvements out of the release. *Exit bar:* Blocker + Critical open = 0; reserve-copy invariants checked per SKU.
- **Cutover & Go-Live (January; May 1 → Jul 1)** — reserve rules live against demand at the January planning go-live with the floor untouched; execution moved in May; no SKU with two published AFS values. *Exit bar:* oversell incidents zero through both go-lives.
- **Hypercare / Close (Jun → Jul)** — daily ISM-vs-MB52 drift; Negative AFS and AFS Correction under control owners (U6); the improvement list handed to steering as a priced later enhancement. *Exit bar:* drift 0 on consecutive days; enhancement priced, not promised.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the bucket inventory, the break-even, the asymmetry, the offer of visibility, the row in the FSD. Merchandising owned the reserve; control owners own the screens. Digital's forecasting-lens concern was answered by the three-identity design, not by a ruling.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** The reserve rule is now a row in the FSD and a cell family in the matrix; Merchandising sees the reserve and Inventory Control chases variance on the screens. **Trade-off put to leadership:** sell the reserve and accept unpickable-stock cancellations, or hold it back and accept visible undersell — I priced both and recommended undersell.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY

- **$** — no record dollar for this decision. What-if (modeled, **illustrative**): at a 20% release rate, promising 10,000 reserved units costs −$50,000 (incremental cancellation cost) to −$202,000 (S1's all-in $30 per incident) against the ≈$38,000 of expected sales; break-even release 36.7% (61.2% all-in). Not claimed as a saving.
- **#** — 3 working definitions → 1 signed AFS; 0 units of merch reserve in published AFS (record design); 3 organizations signed the row.
- **%** — break-even release rate p* = 36.7% (modeled); oversell rate behind S1's ≈$0.9M row is 0.10% of orders (benchmark 0.05–0.25%; the record is incidents → zero).
- **Time** — FSD signed 8/14; January reserve go-live; May execution go-live (record).
- **Customer** — customer-facing oversell incidents recurring → zero through two go-lives (record); no SKU with two published AFS values.
- **Quality** — reserve and lost/found outside S4_Avail — no double-subtract path; the no lives in the FSD as a signed row (record design).

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — every line is this story's record or labeled model, no new canon numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	Three meanings of "available" and a request that would have promised unpickable stock; I defined which buckets are inside supply and which sit outside.
Scope & influence	Merchandising, Finance, Digital and Inventory Management each had a stake; I owned none of their systems; three orgs signed.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others own	Visible undersell versus unpickable-stock oversell — chose undersell. Mechanism others own: the FSD row and the Negative AFS / AFS Correction screens.
Impact	Oversell incidents recurring → zero through both go-lives; no SKU promised twice.
Process improvement	A priced no, written as a row; the same break-even shape (p* = cost ÷ (gain + cost)) applies to any reserve decision.
Complexity & consensus	Three node types, two channels, three planning identities, three signing orgs, one comingled pool.
Root cause at scale	Oversell is a vocabulary defect; the fix was a rule about which stock is inside supply, not 441 patches.

PROBING — FIVE FACETS, THEN THE HARDEST FOLLOW-UPS NEW

THE FIVE FACETS — WHERE EACH ONE LIVES IN THIS STORY

1 · Data analysis. Grain: SKU × node × channel × bucket. Sources: the bucket inventory, both books' on-hand, the reserve view Merchandising worked from. Cuts: stock by bucket (inside supply vs outside), by channel demand, by pool. Revealed: stock present in the building and absent from S4_Avail is physical truth the system must not promise.

2 · Solution design. Options: (A) reserve promisable; (B) reserve visible, not promisable (chosen); (C) reserve invisible. A overpromises on a release the floor cannot guarantee; C creates shadow spreadsheets. B gives Merchandising the lever they needed.

3 · Math & data logic. AFS = Basis − PickRes − EcomPick − EcomPack − SNB; MR outside S4_Avail → AFS stays 560 whether MR = 0 or 50. Break-even p* = c ÷ (g + c) = 11 ÷ 30 = 36.7%; EV per unit = p × $19 − (1 − p) × $11.

4 · Implementation. FSD row signed 8/14; matrix cells; visibility view; January/May go-lives; control owners for the screens. Risks: override abuse, vocabulary drift, feed latency (the register's top three).

5 · Probe questions. Below: how you priced it, what if the release is higher, who lost, what you deferred, and the three trap drills.

FACET 5 — PROBE QUESTIONS (CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER)

Infra — it was in the building. Why not sell it?

Physical presence is not pickability. The reserve is stock Merchandising controls; if it is promised and not released, the customer finds out. I priced it: at a 20% release rate, 10,000 units is −$50K on the cancellation cost alone, −$202K on S1's all-in cost — and it is a customer harm beyond the dollars.

Infra — what release rate would make you say yes?

More than 36.7% on the incremental-cost view, 61.2% on the all-in view. At 40% the incremental EV is +$10K per 10,000 units — thin. I would also want a hold-until date and a release SLA — a rate alone is not a promise.

Infra — who lost?

Merchandising could not sell the reserve in the channel until it was released; they kept full visibility. The comingle-reserve improvements were held out of the release and priced as a later enhancement (master S1); the architecture-council pack had already fenced them out of scope in writing — 'the comingle reserve math stays untouched' (Apple C4).

Infra — how does one pool serve two channels without a split?

Both channels read the same Basis; every event decrements one bucket. Two-pool example: retail 300 with demand 250 (50 idle), dotcom 260 with demand 290 (30 short) — one pool of 560 meets 540 with 20 left. The cost is that the pool's AFS must be right, which is the matrix's job (U1).

Infra — what is the downside of this policy?

Visible undersell: the SKU shows less than the floor could sell. On S1's benchmark undersell costs ≈$4.75 per unit against ≈$30 for an oversell — about 6.3 to 1 — and Inventory Control chases it on the screens. I accept that trade on purpose.

BUSINESS IMPACT MODEL — KPI DRIVERS, BASELINE → AFTER

DRIVER	BASELINE	AFTER	$ / EFFECT	BASIS
Reserve promisable?	requested	no — visible only	−$50K to −$202K avoided per 10,000 units (what-if)	modeled, illustrative
Working definitions of "available"	3	1 signed AFS	—	record
Customer-facing oversell incidents	recurring across 3 node types	zero through two go-lives	S1's ≈$0.9M row is modeled	record / modeled
Stranded stock between pools	30 short while 50 idle (worked SKU)	560 vs 540 demand — 0 short	$570 margin per SKU-week (illustrative)	illustrative
Reserve physically held	2,500 ft³ per 10,000 units	unchanged — not promisable	0.25% of CAP-C's 1.02M ft³	illustrative

THE MATH — FOUR-TABLE DERIVATION (FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION → RESULT) NEW

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Working definitions	`3 (Store · Retail DC · Dotcom DC)`	record	3
2	Worked SKU	`Basis = min(1,000, 980) = 980; AFS = 980 − 200 − 120 − 60 − 40 = 560`	S1 SKU (illustrative); MR outside S4_Avail	AFS 560
3	If the reserve were promisable	`50 reserved units → AFS = 560 + 50 = 610; over-promise exposure if unpickable = 50 units`	illustrative reserve	up to 50 units overpromised
4	Cost per oversell (all-in)	`$6 + $4 + $19 + $1 = $30`	CS contact · refund · lost margin · goodwill (benchmark)	$30
5	Incremental cost (margin never earned)	`$6 + $4 + $1 = $11; gain on a shipped sale = $19`	same inputs, margin removed from the cost side	c = $11, g = $19
6	Two pools — stranded stock	`retail 300 vs demand 250 → 50 idle; dotcom 260 vs 290 → 30 short`	illustrative split of one SKU	30 short, 50 idle
7	Physical footprint of the reserve	`10,000 × 0.25 ft³ = 2,500 ft³`	0.25 ft³/unit (booklet's illustrative); present on the floor, absent from AFS	2,500 ft³

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Break-even release (incremental)	`p* = c ÷ (g + c) = 11 ÷ (19 + 11) = 11 ÷ 30 = 36.7%`	same shape as the booklet's INV-D transfer breakeven (3 ÷ 12 = 25%)	36.7%
2	Break-even release (all-in)	`30 ÷ (19 + 30) = 30 ÷ 49 = 61.2%`	S1's $30 as the cost of a broken promise	61.2%
3	EV per promised unit at p = 20%	`0.20 × $19 − 0.80 × $11 = $3.80 − $8.80 = $-5.00`	release rate illustrative	−$5.00
4	EV per 10,000 units	`−$5.00 × 10,000 = −$50,000`	units illustrative	−$50,000
5	Same, all-in	`0.20 × $19 − 0.80 × $30 = $3.80 − $24.00 = $-20.20; × 10,000 = −$202,000`	S1 all-in cost	−$202,000
6	Option B (chosen)	`AFS = 560 whether MR = 0 or 50; MR shown in ISM, not in published AFS`	record design: MR outside S4_Avail	0 units overpromised
7	One pool, two channels	`300 + 260 = 560 supply; 250 + 290 = 540 demand; 560 − 540 = 20 left; short = 0`	same SKU, one pool	0 short

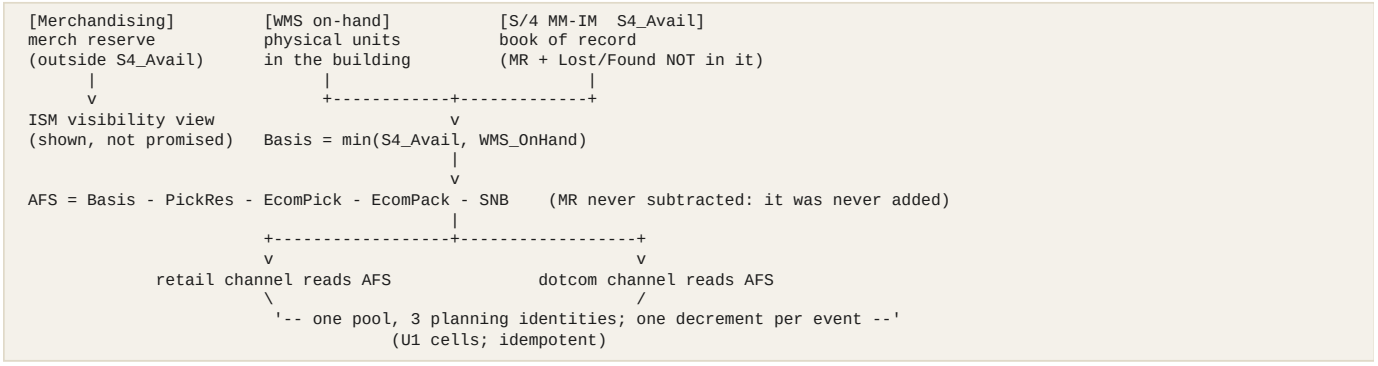
Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Working definitions of "available"	3	1 signed AFS	record
2	Reserve units in published AFS	all (the ask)	0	record design
3	Oversell incidents	recurring across 3 node types	zero through two go-lives	record
4	Units short while stock idle (worked SKU)	30 short / 50 idle (two pools)	0 short / 20 left (one pool)	illustrative
5	Reserve rule	meeting minute	a signed FSD row	record

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Expected sales forgone (reserve not promised)	`0.20 × 10,000 × $19 = $38,000`	20% of reserve released and sold at $19 margin	$38,000 not earned
2	Cancellation cost avoided (incremental)	`0.80 × 10,000 × $11 = $88,000`	80% not released → cancelled	$88,000
3	Net, incremental view	`$88,000 − $38,000 = $50,000`	rows 1–2	$50,000 avoided
4	Net, all-in view	`0.80 × 10,000 × $30 = $240,000; − $38,000 = $202,000`	S1 all-in	$202,000 avoided
5	Stranded-stock margin (two pools)	`30 × $19 = $570 per SKU-week`	worked SKU (illustrative)	$570
6	If release were 40%	`0.40 × $19 − 0.60 × $11 = $7.60 − $6.60 = +$1.00/unit → +$10,000 per 10,000`	above p* = 36.7%	+$10,000

SOLUTION FLOW — THE SYSTEM & DATA MAP



SENSITIVITY — LOW / BASE / HIGH

INPUT	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Release rate p (incremental cost)	10% → −$80K	20% → −$50K	40% → +$10K

INPUT	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Cost basis at p = 20%	incremental $11 → −$50K	midpoint $20.50 → −$126K	all-in $30 → −$202K
Reserve volume at p = 20%, $11	5,000 → −$25K	10,000 → −$50K	20,000 → −$100K
Break-even release p*	36.7% (incremental)	—	61.2% (all-in)
Undersell : oversell cost	$4.75 : $30 = 1 : 6.3	—	ratio sets the policy, not one deal

SPOKEN STATEMENT

> "Merchandising asked me to make the reserve promisable. I said no, and I priced the no: promising stock that may not be released is worth it only above about thirty-seven percent release on the incremental cost, sixty-one on S1's all-in cost; on a twenty percent release rate that is about fifty thousand dollars per ten thousand units on the low view and about two hundred thousand on the high view — illustrative inputs, and I show them. What I offered was visibility without promisability, and the no went into the FSD as a signed row. The record is zero customer-facing oversell incidents through both go-lives; the dollars are what that decision would have cost."

IF CHALLENGED

> **"Isn't that just a made-up release rate?"**
> The 20% is illustrative and I tag it. What is not illustrative is the shape: the decision flips only above p* = 36.7% (61.2% all-in). The measurement I would ask Merchandising for is the historical release rate by SKU class.

> **"You priced undersell at $4.75 — where from?"**
> $19 margin × a 25% share of undersold demand that does not come back — both illustrative; it is a 1 : 6.3 asymmetry on S1's benchmark, not a measured number. If the share were 100% the ratio would still be 1.6 : 1 against promising.

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you disagreed with a stakeholder and held your position.	Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit	The priced no on promisable reserve; visibility offered; the no written as a signed row.	Do not frame it as winning a fight.
Tell me about a time you protected the customer at a cost to the business.	Customer Obsession	Visible undersell accepted so oversell is zero by construction; asymmetry 1 : 6.3.	Do not claim the dollars as saved.
How do you decide whether to promise stock that is physically present?	Functional — promise design	Pickable vs present; p* = c ÷ (g + c); the promise reads published AFS, never computes.	Never 'I configured ISM'.
Tell me about a time you considered the broader impact.	Success and Scale Bring Broad Responsibility	Oversell as a customer harm at scale; the dollar price is the floor, not the whole.	Do not invent a customer count.

BEHAVIORAL PACK — FOUR SEPARATE 90-SECOND STAR ANSWERS, EACH FROM A DIFFERENT MOMENT OF THE STORY NEW

HAVE BACKBONE; DISAGREE AND COMMIT · AIQB Q1 **Q1. "Tell me about a time when you strongly disagreed with your manager or peer on something you considered very important to the business."**

Merchandising wanted the merch reserve to be promisable — stock in the building, why not sell it? I disagreed, but not by arguing. I priced the ask: promising a unit that may not be released only pays if more than about 37% of reserved units actually are released; on a 20% release rate that is about minus fifty thousand dollars per ten thousand units on the cancellation cost alone and about minus two hundred thousand on S1's all-in cost. Then I offered what they actually needed: visibility — the reserve shown, not promised. The no went into the FSD as a row signed by Strategy, Inventory Management and Inventory Accounting, so it was a decision, not a meeting minute that would be re-litigated weekly. The comingle-reserve improvements were held out of the release to protect zero incidents and priced as a later enhancement at steering. I disagreed once, with a number, and committed in writing.

Number to land: p* = 36.7%; −$50K to −$202K per 10,000 units (illustrative) · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF the same break-even decides when to promise ahead of a physical state — received-not-stowed, in transit — a number, not a feeling. · **Do NOT say:** that I won; that the dollars are saved; that the release rate was measured.

CUSTOMER OBSESSION · AIQB Q7 **Q2. "Sometimes customers make unreasonable requests. Tell me about a time when you've had to push back or say no to a customer request."**

I accepted visible undersell so that oversell would be zero by construction. The design policy was an asymmetry: an oversell is a customer defect — someone pays for something we do not have — and an undersell is a planning variance Inventory Control chases. On S1's benchmark one oversell costs about thirty dollars and an undersold unit about five, roughly a six-to-one asymmetry, so the supply basis is the lower of the two books and the reserve never enters it. That means some sellable stock shows as unavailable. I said so in the FSD and made the control owners own the screens that chase it. The result: customer-facing oversell incidents that were recurring across three node types went to zero through both go-lives. The cost of the policy is visible undersell, which I will always take over a broken promise.

Number to land: oversell incidents recurring → zero; asymmetry ≈ 1 : 6.3 · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF a promise date is a customer commitment; I would take a slightly conservative buffer over a missed date on the same arithmetic. · **Do NOT say:** a customer count; that undersell is free.

EARN TRUST · AIQB Q3 **Q3. "Describe a time when you needed to influence a peer who had a differing opinion about a shared goal."**

The relationship was the reason I started with what Merchandising needed, not what they asked for. They asked for the reserve to be promisable; what they needed was to see it and to know when it could be released. So the first thing I said was yes: yes to visibility, in ISM, alongside AFS. Then I said no to the mechanism and showed my arithmetic — the break-even and the cancellation cost — so the no was not an opinion. I made the cost to them explicit: the reserve could not be sold in the channel until released. I put the no into the FSD as a row so nobody had to defend it in a hallway, and the comingle-reserve improvements were held out of the release and priced rather than refused. The FSD was signed by three orgs (user anchor, master S1) with the row in it. The test of trust is that the no was written down and the offer was real.

Number to land: 3 orgs signed the row · 0 open 'who owns this bucket' (both user anchor) · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF I would open every no with the need I can say yes to and the number that makes the no checkable. · **Do NOT say:** that Merchandising agreed happily; I do not know their private view.

SUCCESS AND SCALE BRING BROAD RESPONSIBILITY · AIQB Q5 **Q4. "Tell me about a time when you considered everyone who was affected by your work, not just your direct customers or people within your organization."**

An oversell looks like a ledger error to a planner and a broken promise to a customer. At the scale of this DC — an illustrative thirty million orders a year at a benchmark 0.10% oversell rate — that is thirty thousand customers a year who paid for something we did not have. I did not let the dollar comparison be the whole argument for the no on promisable reserve. The dollar figure — fifty to two hundred thousand per ten thousand reserved units — is the floor of the case; the rest is what it does to a customer's trust in a promise. So the design treats a broken promise as a defect with an owner and a screen, not a variance to be tolerated. The record: customer-facing oversell incidents zero through two go-lives. At Amazon scale that is the difference between a rare event and a daily one.

Number to land: 30,000 incidents/yr (illustrative) → 0; zero through two go-lives · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF a promise date on a Prime order is the same contract; I would run the same defect-not-variance logic on the promise seam. · **Do NOT say:** a real customer count; that 30,000 is measured — it is S1's illustrative orders × benchmark rate.

SAME STORY, THREE ANGLES — DATA · CONFLICT/INFLUENCE/BACKBONE · FAILURE-LEARNING NEW

DATA ANGLE · DIVE DEEP	CONFLICT / INFLUENCE ANGLE · HAVE BACKBONE; DISAGREE AND COMMIT	FAILURE / LEARNING ANGLE · EARN TRUST
"I turned a stakeholder request into a break-even: promise the reserve only above 37% release." **Headline metric:** p* = 36.7% (61.2% all-in); −$50K per 10,000 units at 20% The decision is a one-line formula, p* = c ÷ (g + c), with two cost views; it flips only if the release rate is measured above the break-even. Honest limit: the 20% release rate is illustrative.	*"Merchandising wanted something I would not give them — so I gave them everything else."* **Headline metric:** visibility yes · promisability no · 3 orgs signed (user anchor) Priced no; visibility offered; the no written as an FSD row; the comingle-reserve improvements held out and priced as a later enhancement.	*"I priced the no with a release rate I never measured."* **Headline metric:** release rate 20% illustrative vs p* = 36.7% The row in the FSD carried the decision, but not the measurement that would flip it: the historical release rate by SKU class. Do differently: put the ask for that measurement in the same row.

TRAP DRILLS — THE THREE NASTIEST FOLLOW-UPS, WITH NUMERIC ANSWERS NEW

How do you know it was the right call and not just caution?

It is right as long as the release rate is below 36.7% (61.2% all-in). The record is zero oversell incidents; I cannot prove the counterfactual. The number that would change my mind is a measured release rate above the break-even with a hold-until date.

Say: *"The decision is right below a 37% release rate; I did not measure it, so the row I would add is that measurement — if it came back above 37%, I would reopen it."*

Isn't splitting the cost into $11 and $30 a way to get the answer you want?

No — the decision holds on both: −$50K and −$202K per 10,000 units at 20%. It flips only above p* in either view, and the two views bracket it between 36.7% and 61.2%.

Say: *"I show both cost views because the answer does not depend on which you believe — it depends on whether the release rate is above 37% or 61%."*

Who bore the cost of your no?

Merchandising: for a period the reserve was visible but not sellable in the channel until released; the comingle-reserve improvements were deferred and priced at steering.

Say: *"Merchandising bore it — visible but not sellable until release; the comingle-reserve improvements were held out of the release to protect zero incidents and priced, not promised."*

20-SECOND VERSION + NACF BRIDGE NEW

20-second version. At the Utah DC I said no to making merch reserve promisable — stock in the building but not for sale — by pricing the no: it pays only above about 37% release, which on a 20% illustrative rate is −$50K per 10,000 units. I offered visibility instead, wrote the no into the FSD, and customer-facing oversell went to zero through both go-lives.

NACF bridge. NACF has the same seam on the dock: units received but not yet stowed, quarantined or in transit are in the building and not pickable. The promise should read pickable; p* = cost ÷ (gain + cost) — INV-D's 3 ÷ 12 = 25% shape — says when promising ahead of the stow pays. 10,000 reserved units at 0.25 ft³ = 2,500 ft³: CAP-C's cube in miniature.

U4 — Where the node's constraint actually bound — labor hours, then pick accuracy, then cube: one capacity envelope that priced the robotics throttle and the pooled space NEW

LPs this story serves here: Bias for Action (primary — the throttle decision the week the gate failed) · Frugality (price both sides; pay for the cheaper one) · Dive Deep (the constraint was accuracy, not robot speed) · Strive to be Earth's Best Employer (the floor protected during the ramp)
Process family: Make / Deliver — DC capacity and throughput analysis: labor-hour envelope, automation ramp, constraint identification, cube

Honesty label. Record: robotics gate 98% published before the ramp; week two at 94%; bots throttled to ~30% of volume for a week; zone/slotting logic root-caused; full volume week three; +15% processing efficiency (Sephora-signed, measured by DC Ops); DC Ops owned the gate and the dial; peak (Oct–Dec) untouched. **Modeled / illustrative (S2's DC):** 100,000 units/week, 120 FTE × 2,000 h, $28/h. **Mine to label:** $12 per mis-pick, linear hours-versus-bot-share, 10,000 attempted picks, $25 per unit and 0.25 ft³ per unit — all illustrative. I priced the trade; DC Ops ran the floor; I do not claim whose budget carried the hours.

LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES CARRIED — ONE-LINE PROOF EACH

Bias for Action. The week-2 read was 94 against a published 98; the dial, built in advance and owned by DC Ops, went to ~30% the same week — a reversible decision with a number.

Frugality. I priced both sides: ≈$11.8K of extra labor hours against ≈$50.4K of mis-pick exposure, and paid the cheaper one with existing labor — no new tooling.

Dive Deep. The robots could pick; they could not pick right — the binding constraint at week 2 was accuracy, root-caused to zone and slotting logic, not robot speed.

Strive to be Earth's Best Employer. The throttle kept the floor from absorbing the mis-picks and the rework; the interim reporting burden was named as the price. No headcount or attrition figure is claimed.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Sephora's Utah DC was ramping Locus robotics behind a published 98% pick-accuracy gate, on an illustrative 100,000-units-a-week floor running 4,615 labor hours a week. Week two read 94%. **Task.** Decide, with DC Ops, how much robot volume the floor could carry — and where the node's constraint actually sat. **Action.** Analysis first: before the ramp the binding constraint was labor hours; in week two it had moved to accuracy, not robot speed. Four points of accuracy at full bot share is 6,000 mis-picks a week against a 2,000 budget. I priced the dial: a throttle to 30% keeps bot-side errors at 1,800, inside the full-volume budget — the maximum safe share is 33.3% — at a cost of about 421 extra labor hours, roughly $11,800, against about 4,200 mis-picks avoided, roughly $50,400 on an illustrative $12 each. DC Ops owned the dial before the ramp, so the rule fired and I did not improvise. Zone and slotting logic was root-caused and fixed; full volume in week three. Pooling had freed the safety stock the node did not need to hold — about $2.2M modeled, roughly 22,000 cubic feet on illustrative unit cube. **Result.** Primary metric: the gate held — 94 against 98 became full volume in week three, with +15% processing efficiency Sephora-signed and zero customer-facing incidents. The dollars are a model; the gate, the throttle and the +15% are the record.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — One physical node, one robotics ramp, one published gate. The floor was running at baseline productivity (index 100); the plan was +15% at stabilization; the robots were the lever. The week-2 gate read 94 against 98 with the Oct–Dec peak freeze ahead. Everyone could see the gap; nobody had a number for what each response would cost.

T — Say where the constraint bound and what each dial setting cost, on one page, in the week it mattered — and make sure the rule that fired was the floor owner's, not mine.

Baselines on the table: gate 98% (record) · week 2 = 94% (record) · 240,000 h/yr = 4,615 h/wk on an illustrative 100K-units/week node · target index 115 → 4,013 h/wk · full-share exposure 6,000 mis-picks vs a 2,000 budget · peak freeze Oct–Dec.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (3/29 → 4/30)** — profiled 801/901; read the node's labor and throughput as an envelope — hours per week, units per hour, what the floor could ship; success criteria included peak untouched. *Exit bar:* criteria signed by steering; every impacted system owned.
- **Plan & Design (5/15 → 8/14)** — wrote the gate (98% pick-accurate completed ÷ attempted), the throttle dial and the weekly read in the council pack before the robots arrived; DC Ops took ownership of the gate and the dial. *Exit bar:* council 7/31; FSD 8/14; the dial owned before the ramp.
- **Build & Test (Aug → Jan/Apr)** — the Locus gate definition and throttle spec in the build; the 3-day Locus workshop; RTL slipped three weeks, escalated the week it surfaced, re-slotted openly, UAT not compressed. *Exit bar:* Locus RTL retested after the slip; E2E days

dated.

- **Cutover & Go-Live (January; May 1 → Jul 1)** — ramp read weekly; week 2 = 94 against 98 → throttle to ~30% for a week → zone/slotting RCA → week-3 re-read at the same gate. *Exit bar:* rule fired; full volume week 3.
- **Hypercare / Close (Jun → Jul)** — +15% measured post-stabilization by DC Ops; hypercare exit week 3 of 4; the dial and the gate handed to the next DC as a template. *Exit bar:* exit at < 2 blockers/day sustained.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the capacity envelope, the dial arithmetic and the go/no-go on the ramp read. DC Ops: the gate, the dial, the floor and the +15% measurement. Locus and platform teams: the build and the slotting fix.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** DC Ops owns the dial and the weekly read; the template went to the next DC. **Trade-off put to leadership:** a week of robot volume for a root-caused ramp — recommended with the arithmetic on both sides.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY

- **$** — modeled on S2's illustrative DC: throttle premium ≈421 h × $28 = $11,799 against ≈4,200 mis-picks × $12 = $50,400 avoided; break-even mis-pick cost $2.81. Pooled safety stock released ≈$2.2M ≈ 22,000 ft³ (modeled). Not claimed as savings.
- # — gate 98%, week 2 at 94%, throttle ~30% for one week, full volume week 3 (record); 4,615 → 4,013 labor hours/wk at +15% (modeled on the record index).
- **%** — +15% processing efficiency (record, Sephora-signed); max safe bot share 33.3% against the ~30% dial (arithmetic).
- **Time** — one week at ~30%; week-3 re-read at the same gate; hypercare exit week 3 of 4; ~92 days of float from Jul 1 to the Oct freeze (lower bound).
- **Customer** — zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives; peak untouched (record).
- **Quality** — the gate stayed a gate — it fired at 94 and was re-read at the same number; the cause (zone/slotting logic) was removed, not routed around.

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — every line is this story's record or labeled model, no new canon numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	No agreed stop condition for the ramp. I defined the gate, the dial and the weekly read before the robots arrived.
Scope & influence	DC Ops owned the floor and the dial; Locus and platform teams the build; I owned the envelope and the recommendation.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others own	A week of robot volume for a root-caused ramp; the mechanism others own: the dial and the weekly read.
Impact	+15% processing efficiency; full volume week 3; peak untouched; zero incidents.
Process improvement	Gate → dial → RCA → re-read as standard work for the next DC.
Complexity & consensus	WMS upgrade, robotics and peak freeze on one critical path; Operations, IT and Supply Chain Strategy in steering.
Root cause at scale	The week-2 miss was zone/slotting logic — fixed at the cause before full volume.

PROBING — FIVE FACETS, THEN THE HARDEST FOLLOW-UPS NEW

THE FIVE FACETS — WHERE EACH ONE LIVES IN THIS STORY

1 · Data analysis. Grain: node × week × bot share. Data: labor hours, units, attempted and accurate picks, mis-pick cost. Cuts: accuracy by week; hours by share; exposure by share. Revealed: the constraint had moved from labor hours (pre-ramp) to accuracy (ramp) — robot speed was never the binding limit.

2 · Solution design. Options: (A) hold full volume and fix live; (B) throttle to 0 and re-test later; (C) throttle to ~30% and keep re-reading. Chose C — A's exposure is 4,000 mis-picks over budget; B costs ≈$5.1K more and loses the live volume the gate reads.

3 · Math & data logic. hours(s) = $H_0 - s(H_0 - H_1)$; premium = $(1 - s)(H_0 - H_1)$; errors = 6% × s × volume; s_max = (1 − 0.98)/(1 − 0.94) = 33.3%; z = 0.04/√(0.98 × 0.02/n).

4 · Implementation. Gate and dial published and owned by DC Ops before the ramp; weekly read; RCA; re-read; hypercare exit. Risks: ramp with no stop condition, two live truths, peak collision.

5 · Probe questions. Below: why 30, why not 0, is 94 noise, where was the constraint, and the three trap drills.

FACET 5 — PROBE QUESTIONS (CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER)

Infra — why a 30% throttle, not 0% or 50%?

At 30% the bot-side errors are 1,800, inside the 2,000-per-week budget the gate allows at full volume; the maximum safe share is 33.3%. At 50% errors would be 3,000 — over. At 0% the premium rises to ≈$16.9K and the gate has no live bot volume to read.

Infra — is 94 versus 98 noise?

No. On an illustrative 10,000 attempted picks the standard error is 0.14 points and the gap is 28.6σ; even on 500 picks it is 6.4σ. The week-2 read was a real miss, not sampling.

> **Infra — where did the node's constraint actually bind?**
>
> Pre-ramp: labor hours — 4,615 h a week for 100K units. In the ramp: accuracy, not robot speed — the zone/slotting logic. After: labor again, at +15% — 4,013 h. I did not claim space bound; I do not know the Utah cube utilization VERIFY-WITH-RAJESH.

> **Infra — what did the throttle cost, and who paid?**
>
> About 421 extra labor hours ≈ $11,799 on the illustrative $28 — about 10.5 FTE-weeks at 40 hours. I do not claim whose budget carried them; DC Ops ran the floor.

> **Infra — did the throttle create a backlog?**
>
> Not on this arithmetic: at fixed baseline hours the node's capacity under a 30% share is ≈104,072 units a week against 100,000 — 4.1% headroom. It is a linear model; the real node's hours were not fixed.

BUSINESS IMPACT MODEL — KPI DRIVERS, BASELINE → AFTER

DRIVER	BASELINE	AFTER	$ / EFFECT	BASIS
Bot share (week 2)	100% planned	~30% (record)	errors 6,000 → 1,800	record / arithmetic
Pick accuracy (gate)	94% (week 2)	≥98% re-read week 3	full volume	record
Labor hours per week	4,615	4,013 at index 115	−602 h/wk	modeled on record +15%
Throttle week premium	—	+421 h	$11,799 vs $50,400 avoided	modeled / illustrative
Cube equivalent of pooled release	—	22,000 ft³	≈2.2% of CAP-C's 1.02M ft³	illustrative

THE MATH — FOUR-TABLE DERIVATION (FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION → RESULT) NEW

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Baseline weekly hours	`240,000 / 52 = 4,615.4 h/wk; 100,000 / 4,615.4 = 21.67 units/h`	120 FTE × 2,000 h; 100K units/wk (S2 illustrative)	4,615 h/wk
2	Gate vs week-2 read	`98% − 94% = 4 pts`	record	4 pts short
3	Exposure at full bot share	`6% × 100,000 = 6,000 mis-picks; budget at the gate 2% × 100,000 = 2,000; excess = 4,000`	94% vs 98% on illustrative volume	4,000 over budget
4	Is it noise?	`SE(n=10,000) = √(0.98 × 0.02 / 10,000) = 0.0014; z = 0.04 / 0.0014 = 28.6`	10,000 attempts illustrative; z(n=500) = 6.4	28.6σ
5	Where the constraint bound	`pre-ramp: labor (21.67 u/h × 4,615 h = 100,000); ramp: accuracy T = 94% < 98%`	robot speed was not binding	accuracy
6	Calendar float	`Jul 1 → Oct 1 = 31 + 31 + 30 = 92 days`	peak freeze Oct–Dec (record); start date VERIFY	92 days (lower bound)

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Max safe bot share	`s_max = (1 − 0.98) / (1 − 0.94) = 0.02 / 0.06 = 33.3%`	bot-side errors ≤ the full-volume error budget	33.3%
2	Dial = ~30% (record)	`errors = 6% × 30,000 = 1,800 ≤ 2,000; avoided = 6,000 − 1,800 = 4,200`	inside the budget by 200	4,200 avoided
3	Hours at 30% share	`0.7 × 4,615.4 + 0.3 × 4,013.4 = 3,230.8 + 1,204.0 = 4,434.8`	linear in bot share (illustrative)	4,434.8 h
4	Premium vs plan	`4,434.8 − 4,013.4 = 421.4 h = 10.5% of plan hours ≈ 10.5 FTE-weeks`	40-h week (illustrative)	421.4 h
5	Capacity at fixed hours	`100,000 × 4,615.4 / 4,434.8 = 104,072 units/wk`	baseline hours held	104,072 (no backlog)
6	Upper bound premium	`0% share: 602.0 h × $28 = $16,856`	full manual week	≈$16.9K
7	Re-read	`week 3: T ≥ 98% at the same gate → full volume`	record	full volume week 3
8	Space — what pooling freed	`$2.2M / $25 = 88,000 units; × 0.25 ft³ = 22,000 ft³`	$25/unit and 0.25 ft³ illustrative	22,000 ft³

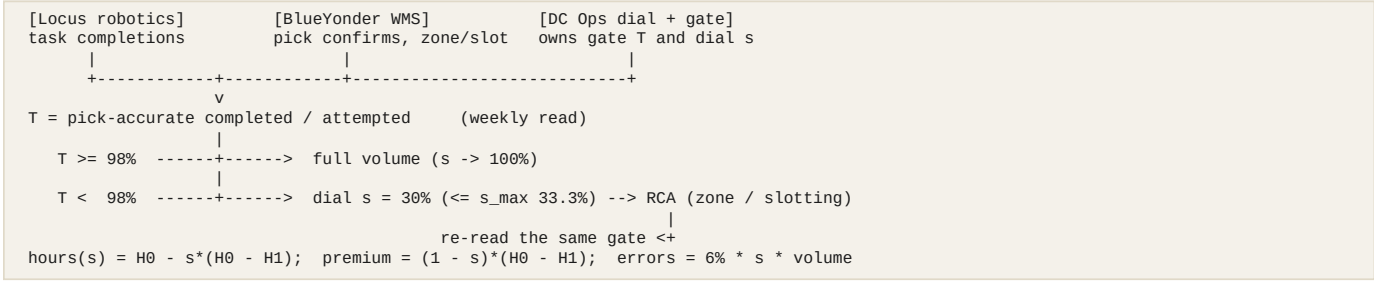
Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Bot share, week 2	100% planned	~30%	record
2	Pick accuracy	94%	≥98% at week-3 re-read	record
3	Full-share mis-picks / wk	6,000	≤2,000 at the gate	illustrative volume
4	Labor hours / wk (same volume)	4,615	4,013 (index 115)	modeled on record +15%
5	Customer-facing incidents	0 allowed	0 through both go-lives	record

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Throttle premium	`421.4 h × $28 = $11,799`	$28 loaded (modeled)	≈$11.8K
2	Mis-picks avoided, priced	`4,200 × $12 = $50,400`	$12 per mis-pick (illustrative)	≈$50.4K
3	Net	`$50,400 − $11,799 = $38,601`	rows 1–2	≈$38.6K
4	Ratio and break-even	`$50,400 / $11,799 = 4.3×; break-even cost per mis-pick = $11,799 / 4,200 = $2.81`	decision holds above $2.81	4.3× / $2.81
5	Premium as share of the annual labor benefit	`$11,799 / $876,400 = 1.35%`	S2's ≈$0.88M/yr (modeled)	1.35%
6	Upper-bound premium	`602.0 h × $28 = $16,856`	0% share	≈$16.9K

SOLUTION FLOW — THE SYSTEM & DATA MAP



SENSITIVITY — LOW / BASE / HIGH

INPUT	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Mis-pick cost	$6 → $25.2K avoided	$12 → $50.4K	$20 → $84.0K
Dial setting	20% → premium $13.5K, errors 1,200	30% → $11.8K, errors 1,800	33.3% → $11.2K, errors 2,000
Attempted picks n	500 → 6.4σ	10,000 → 28.6σ	100,000 → 90.4σ
Loaded labor rate	$24 → $10.1K	$28 → $11.8K	$32 → $13.5K
Break-even mis-pick cost	—	$2.81	decision holds above this

SPOKEN STATEMENT

> "Before the robots arrived the node's binding constraint was labor hours; in week two it was accuracy — 94 against a published 98 — not robot speed. On an illustrative hundred-thousand-unit week that is about 4,000 mis-picks over the gate's budget at full share. A throttle to 30% kept the errors inside the budget, because the maximum safe share is 33%, at a cost of about 420 extra hours, roughly twelve thousand dollars, against about fifty thousand dollars of mis-picks avoided — modeled, on a twelve-dollar mis-pick I label illustrative. DC Ops owned the dial, so the rule fired; the zone and slotting logic was fixed and week three ran at full volume. The +15% and the zero incidents are the record."

IF CHALLENGED

> **"The $12 mis-pick cost is invented."**
>
> Yes, illustrative — and the decision does not depend on it: the throttle pays above $2.81 per mis-pick, so the answer holds across any plausible cost. The record is the gate, the dial and the week-3 re-read.

> **“You only fixed it because the slotting logic was wrong — the throttle was irrelevant.”**
>
> Two levers: the throttle bounded exposure while the fix was made; the fix removed the cause. I cannot separate their contributions in the record, and I would not claim to — but the dial let the re-test run on live volume.

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you made a fast decision with imperfect data.	Bias for Action	Week-2 read; dial pre-built; ~30% the same week; reversible.	Do not say ‘the robots failed’.
Tell me about a time you did more with less / priced a trade-off.	Frugality	$11.8K vs $50.4K with existing labor; 4.3×; break-even $2.81.	Do not claim the dollars as savings.
How do you identify where the constraint is?	Dive Deep / Functional	Labor hours → accuracy → labor; speed was never binding.	Never claim space bound — unknown.
How did you protect the people on the floor?	Strive to be Earth’s Best Employer	Throttle kept mis-picks and rework off the floor; DC Ops owned the dial; interim reporting burden named.	Invent no headcount or attrition.

BEHAVIORAL PACK — FOUR SEPARATE 90-SECOND STAR ANSWERS, EACH FROM A DIFFERENT MOMENT OF THE STORY NEW

BIAS FOR ACTION · AIQB Q1 **Q1. “Give me an example of a calculated risk that you have taken where speed was critical.”**

Week two of the robotics ramp read 94 against a published 98. The gate was published before the robots arrived, and DC Ops owned the throttle dial, so I did not need a meeting to decide whether to act; I needed to decide how far to turn the dial. I priced it that week: at full bot share four points of accuracy is about 6,000 mis-picks a week against a 2,000 budget; a throttle to 30% keeps the bot-side errors at 1,800, inside the budget — the maximum safe share is 33.3% — and costs about 420 extra labor hours. The decision was reversible: re-read the same gate in a week. I dialed to roughly 30%, root-caused the zone and slotting logic, and ran full volume in week three. Speed came from the decision being built before the pressure arrived.

Number to land: 94 vs 98 → ~30% dial → full volume week 3 · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF the same pattern — a published ceiling, a pre-built reversible response, a weekly re-read — applies to a new FC’s inbound ramp. · **Do NOT say:** that the robots failed; that the dial was my invention — DC Ops owned it.

FRUGALITY · AIQB Q4 **Q2. “Tell me about a time when you had to make tradeoffs between quality and cost.”**

I did not buy a fix; I priced a setting on a dial that already existed. The choice in week two was between running at full volume and absorbing the mis-picks, or slowing the bots and covering the volume with the floor’s existing labor. I put both on one page: the throttle costs about 421 hours — roughly eleven thousand eight hundred dollars at an illustrative $28 — and avoids about 4,200 mis-picks, which is fifty thousand dollars at twelve dollars each, or any cost above about two dollars eighty. That is 4.3 to 1 on illustrative inputs. No new tooling, no new heads; the dial existed because DC Ops and I had built it before the ramp. And the pooled safety stock freed about 22,000 cubic feet of space the node no longer had to hold. The record is the gate holding and the +15%; the dollars are my model and I say so.

Number to land: ≈$11.8K vs ≈$50.4K (4.3×); break-even $2.81 · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF a node’s constraint is priced the same way — flex labor against dwell, CAP-B and CAP-E — before any new capacity is bought. · **Do NOT say:** that the $12 or the $28 is measured; that this was a saving.

DIVE DEEP · AIQB Q3 **Q3. “Tell me about a problem you had to solve that required in-depth thought and analysis.”**

Everyone assumed the question was how fast the robots could go. The data said the constraint had moved. Before the ramp the node was bound by labor hours — 4,615 a week for 100,000 units. In week two the robots were picking; they were not picking accurately: 94 against 98. At a full bot share that is thousands of mis-picks, and more robot speed would have made it worse. I asked what was different about the misses, and the answer was the zone and slotting logic — the cause was in how work was assigned, not in the robots. So the fix went to the logic, and the throttle bought the time. After the fix and the week-three re-read at the same gate, the constraint went back to labor hours — now at +15%, about 4,013 a week. The mistake I avoided was optimizing the non-binding constraint.

Number to land: constraint: labor → accuracy → labor; 94 vs 98; +15% · **Pivot to NACF:** NACF’s capacity chain is the same — doors, UPH, cube, dwell — and the first job is to find which one binds this week. · **Do NOT say:** that I fixed the slotting logic myself; the platform team did.

STRIVE TO BE EARTH'S BEST EMPLOYER · AIQB Q3 **Q4. “Describe a time when you implemented a change at work aimed at improving the work experience of yourself or coworkers.”**

The floor was the one place the cost of a bad ramp would land. If the bots had stayed at full volume at 94% accuracy, every mis-pick becomes rework for someone on the floor, during a go-live. I wrote the gate and the dial before the ramp, and DC Ops owned them — so the people who knew the floor held the stop condition, not a program manager on a schedule. When the gate fired, the throttle kept the mis-picks and the rework off the floor for a week while the logic was fixed. I also named the price of the interim to leadership: for four months every report had to declare which system of record it read. I will not quote a headcount or an attrition number — there is none in the record — but the design principle is the stop condition belongs to the people who carry the consequence.

Number to land: the dial owned by DC Ops before the ramp · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF the same principle applies to a peak ramp — the dock and the floor own the stop condition for their own safety and quality. · **Do NOT say:** a headcount, an attrition or a safety figure — none exists in the record.

SAME STORY, THREE ANGLES — DATA · CONFLICT/INFLUENCE/BACKBONE · FAILURE-LEARNING NEW

DATA ANGLE · DIVE DEEP

"Four points of accuracy is 6,000 mis-picks a week at full share against a 2,000 budget."

Headline metric: s_max = 33.3% vs ~30% dial; 28.6σ

The throttle share has a maximum that falls out of the gate (0.02/0.06). The record's ~30% sits just inside it. The misses were not noise (28.6σ on an illustrative 10,000 attempts). Honest limit: the volume and mis-pick cost are illustrative.

CONFLICT / INFLUENCE ANGLE · HAVE BACKBONE; DISAGREE AND COMMIT

"Letting a 94% system carry full volume was the path of least resistance; the gate was published before that temptation existed."

Headline metric: 94 vs 98; dial ~30%

Holding the gate was enforcement, not escalation; the trade was visible in dollars on both sides. Record: the alternative — a 94% system carrying full volume into the combined go-live — is how an incident with a robot in the photo happens.

FAILURE / LEARNING ANGLE · OWNERSHIP

"I had the Locus RTL on the plan as a task, not as a risk."

Headline metric: 3-week RTL slip; 94 vs 98

The slip was escalated the week it surfaced and re-slotted openly without compressing UAT, but it had no trigger or owner on the register at the start. Do differently: put vendor RTL on the register as a risk from day one, and publish the zone/slotting test as a gate prerequisite.

TRAP DRILLS — THE THREE NASTIEST FOLLOW-UPS, WITH NUMERIC ANSWERS NEW

How do you know the throttle — and not the slotting fix — got you to 98?

I don't, and I would not claim to. The throttle bounded exposure at 1,800 errors against a 2,000 budget while the fix was made; the fix removed the cause; the week-3 re-read at the same gate is the evidence of the combination.

Say: *"I can't separate them; the throttle bought exposure control and the time to test the fix on live volume, and the week-3 re-read is the evidence of both."*

Why not 0%? Why not 50%?

At 50% errors are 3,000 against 2,000 — over budget. At 0% the premium is ≈$16.9K instead of ≈$11.8K and the gate has no bot volume to read. 30% sits inside the 33.3% maximum.

Say: *"Thirty is just inside the maximum safe share of thirty-three; fifty breaks the error budget and zero costs five thousand more with nothing to re-read."*

What is the number that would have changed your mind?

A mis-pick cost below $2.81: the throttle would not pay on the arithmetic. Or a re-read at week 3 still below 98: the dial stays, and the RCA reopens.

Say: *"Below about three dollars a mis-pick the throttle doesn't pay, and a week-three read under 98 would have kept the dial down."*

20-SECOND VERSION + NACF BRIDGE NEW

20-second version. In week two of Sephora's robotics ramp the gate read 94 against a published 98; the constraint had moved from labor hours to pick accuracy, and a pre-built, DC-Ops-owned throttle to about 30% — inside the 33.3% maximum safe share — cost about 421 labor hours against roughly 4,200 mis-picks avoided, and full volume ran in week three.

NACF bridge. NACF's inbound capacity chain has the same shape: CAP-A doors held at an 85% ceiling because above it dwell goes about 3×, CAP-B's learning curve costing 13.6% more hours — the throttle week was +10.5% — and CAP-E's ~14 flex heads. The throttle's 421 hours is about ten and a half people for a week; the question for any new FC ramp is which of doors, UPH or cube binds this week, and who owns the dial.

U5 — The 343-task cutover runbook with one irreversible instant — priced rollback triggers, a three-SKU zero-then-publish trace, and what a week of slip is worth NEW

LPs this story serves here: Ownership (primary — the go/no-go and the rollback were mine to recommend) · Deliver Results (a 61-day window, peak untouched) · Have Backbone (no UAT compression; no-go on one open Blocker) · Dive Deep (the runbook arithmetic and the trace)
Process family: Deliver — cutover and go-live design: runbook, sequencing, rollback triggers, hypercare exit

Honesty label. Record: runbook 343 tasks / 48,885 task-minutes ≈ 815 hours, May 1 → Jul 1, each task with owner, duration and predecessor; six-step May choreography with step 4 (zero-then-publish) the one irreversible instant — I can name steps 1–4: clear negatives, transfer AFS to Uncommitted, scan-and-reserve, zero-then-publish **steps 5 and 6 not in the packet**; six invariants — I can name three (Σ AFS conserved; no SKU sellable on 800 and 900 at once; negatives cleared first) **other three not in the packet**; rollback triggers sync < 99% for four consecutive hours or order-flow p95 > 2× budget for one hour, consumers revert to the prior publish; armed for both go-lives, never fired; Blocker + Critical open = 0; mock 3 inside the 0.5% tolerance; monthly new-row arc 271 → 65 → 21 → 14 → 4 (June → October); hypercare exit week 3 of 4. **Modeled / illustrative:** the three-SKU trace, $110/h, 100K units/week, $30 per incident. User anchor, loop packet only (not in Apple or the master): the day-one pace in units. The weekly discovery curve is computed from the log. I built the runbook and recommendation; platform, DC Ops and vendor teams executed.

LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES CARRIED — ONE-LINE PROOF EACH

Ownership. The go/no-go recommendation, the runbook and the rollback triggers were mine; I wrote the recommendation off counted rows and I would have called no-go on one open Blocker.

Deliver Results. A 343-task, ~815-hour runbook ran inside a 61-day window with the peak freeze untouched: two go-lives, zero customer-facing incidents, hypercare exit week 3 of 4.

Have Backbone; Disagree and Commit. When the Locus RTL slipped three weeks I escalated the week it surfaced, re-slotted openly, and refused to compress UAT to absorb it.

Dive Deep. I read the cutover as arithmetic — task-hours, trigger exposure, a three-SKU trace — so every threshold had a number behind it.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Sephora's Utah DC cutover moved warehouse execution from two systemic warehouses to one comingle pool between May 1 and July 1, with zero customer-facing incidents allowed, an October–December peak freeze behind it, and about a dozen impacted systems in the path. **Task.** Own the runbook and the recommendation — what has to happen, in what order, who does it, and what makes us stop. **Action.** I built a 343-task, 48,885-minute — about 815-hour — runbook, each task with an owner, a duration and a predecessor; found the single irreversible instant, step 4, zero-then-publish, so no SKU was ever sellable on both selling locations at once; and wrote the rollback triggers as numbers per interface: sync below 99% for four consecutive hours, or order-flow p95 above twice the budget for an hour, consumers reverting to the prior publish. I wrote the go/no-go off counted rows — Blocker plus Critical at zero, mock three inside the 0.5% tolerance, runbook rehearsed — and I would have said no-go on one open Blocker. Hypercare was read as a decaying monthly arc of new issue rows, 271 → 65 → 21 → 14 → 4, and exited at under two blockers a day sustained. **Result.** Primary metric: zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives, rollback armed twice and never fired. The runbook cost about $90,000 of effort at an illustrative $110 an hour — less than three weeks of the modeled benefit it protected.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — A multi-system cutover in a fixed window: BlueYonder upgrade, comingle reserve rules, robotics ramp and about a dozen impacted systems moving the same two months, with the peak freeze behind it and no room for a customer-facing incident. The interim ran two live truths.

T — Write the runbook that makes the cutover a sequence of owned tasks, identify the instant that cannot be undone, and fix the stop conditions in numbers before anyone is tired.

Baselines on the table: 343 tasks · 48,885 task-minutes ≈ 815 h · 61 days · one irreversible instant · rollback triggers per interface · mock 3 ≤ 0.5% · Blocker + Critical open = 0 · hypercare exit at < 2 blockers/day.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (3/29 → 4/30)** — systems-impacted table with owner and written LOE per row; the interim-state risks named — two live truths, a ramp with no stop condition, a peak collision. *Exit bar:* every impacted system named to an owner (LOE landed 7/2).
- **Plan & Design (5/15 → 8/14)** — staged two-go-live timeline; peak-freeze boundary decided; the six invariants and six-step choreography drafted; rollback concept — consumers revert to the prior publish. *Exit bar:* council 7/31; FSD 8/14; freeze boundary signed.

- **Build & Test (Aug → Jan/Apr)** — three mock cutovers against the 0.5% tolerance; runbook tasks authored with owner, duration, predecessor; E2E days; the shadow monitor for the interim copy built and tested. *Exit bar:* mock 3 inside tolerance; E2E green three dates; B + C open = 0.
- **Cutover & Go-Live (January; May 1 → Jul 1)** — executed the runbook: clear negatives, transfer AFS to Uncommitted, scan-and-reserve, zero-then-publish; inbound re-pointed W801 → W901 per shipment in Proship/TMS; triggers armed per interface. *Exit bar:* six invariants held; rollback never fired.
- **Hypercare / Close (Jun → Jul)** — daily issue read; weekly Locus gate read; control-owner handoff; hypercare exit memo; template handed to the next DC. *Exit bar:* < 2 blockers/day sustained → exit week 3 of 4.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the runbook, the invariants, the choreography, the trigger numbers and the go/no-go recommendation. Executed by: platform, BlueYonder, Locus and DC Ops teams, each owning their tasks. QA owned the gate; steering signed the criteria.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** The runbook format (owner · duration · predecessor), the invariants and the numeric hypercare exit are the template handed to the next DC. **Trade-off put to leadership:** the date versus the bar — a counted go/no-go rather than a feeling, and a second cutover rather than two defect classes in one week.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY

- **$** — modeled: runbook effort 814.75 h × $110 = $89,622; one week of the modeled ≈$1.65M/yr benefit ≈ $31,731/wk → the runbook costs ≈2.8 weeks of what it protected. Not claimed as a saving.
- **#** — 343 tasks / 48,885 task-minutes ≈ 815 h; 61-day window; 836-row issues log, 85.4% closed; monthly new-row arc 271 → 65 → 21 → 14 → 4 (record, from the log).
- **%** — new-row arc −98.5% from June to October; sync trigger < 99% for 4 h; p95 trigger > 2× for 1 h (record).
- **Time** — May 1 → Jul 1; hypercare exit week 3 of 4; peak freeze Oct–Dec untouched (record).
- **Customer** — zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives; rollback armed twice, never fired (record).
- **Quality** — six invariants held; one irreversible instant identified; Blocker + Critical open = 0 at go/no-go.

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — every line is this story's record or labeled model, no new canon numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	A cutover with no agreed stop condition; I defined the invariants, the triggers and the go/no-go bar.
Scope & influence	About a dozen impacted systems, 60+ stakeholders; each task owned by someone who did not report to me.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others own	Two go-lives (a second cutover) versus one (two defect classes in the same week); the runbook format is the mechanism others own.
Impact	Zero customer-facing incidents; two go-lives landed; rollback never needed.
Process improvement	Runbook as owned tasks; irreversible instant named; triggers as numbers; hypercare exit as a number.
Complexity & consensus	Peak freeze, vendor RTL slip, interim two-truth reporting, six invariants across systems.
Root cause at scale	The cutover risk concentrated at one instant — zero-then-publish — so the design put the controls there.

PROBING — FIVE FACETS, THEN THE HARDEST FOLLOW-UPS NEW

THE FIVE FACETS — WHERE EACH ONE LIVES IN THIS STORY

1 · Data analysis. Grain: task × owner × duration × predecessor; SKU × selling location at cutover; issue × severity × day. Cuts: task-hours by day; blockers by day; negatives by SKU. Revealed: the cutover had many tasks and one irreversible instant.

2 · Solution design. Options: (A) one big-bang go-live; (B) two go-lives each carrying one defect class (chosen); (C) a parallel run. A mixes defect classes; C leaves two truths live. B costs a second cutover and buys single-cause diagnosis.

3 · Math & data logic. Σ AFS_800 + Σ AFS_900 conserved; min(AFS_800, AFS_900) = 0 at every instant; triggers: sync < 99% × 4 h → ≈24 events ≈ $714 exposure; p95 > 2× × 1 h; persistence: q^4 vs q.

4 · Implementation. Runbook of 343 tasks; six-step choreography; per-shipment inbound re-pointing; rollback per interface; daily issue read; control-owner handoff. Day-one pace planned in units — 280,000 units, 40 stores, 7 inbound appointments (user anchor, loop packet only) — and a discovery curve of 68 → 160 → 34 issues a week (record, computed from the log).

5 · Probe questions. Below: what made you say go, what did the triggers cost, what's irreversible, why two go-lives, and the three trap drills.

FACET 5 — PROBE QUESTIONS (CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER)

Infra — what made you say go?

Counted rows: Blocker + Critical at zero, mock 3 inside 0.5%, runbook rehearsed, rollback armed per interface. I would have said no-go on one open Blocker; I never had to.

Infra — what is irreversible and how did you handle it?

Step 4, zero-then-publish: AFS_800 set to zero, then the same AFS published at 900. The reversible steps came first (clear negatives, transfer to Uncommitted, scan-and-reserve) so by step 4 the only open question was the publish.

> **Infra — what do the triggers cost if they are wrong?**
> On illustrative volume ≈595 units/h, 1% unsynced for 4 h is ≈23.8 events ≈ $714 of oversell exposure; a p95 at 120 s instead of 60 s for an hour adds a 60 s staleness window ≈ 9.9 units ≈ $298. Small against the cost of a false rollback, which is why the persistence requirement matters.

> **Infra — why two go-lives?**
> So we never hunted two defect classes in the same week. January was the planning go-live — purchasing and inbound, reserve rules live against demand, the floor untouched; May left warehouse execution as the only class.

> **Infra — what did the interim cost?**
> For four months every report had to declare which system of record it read — the price of two live truths. I would staff the interim reporting workstream on day one, not month three.

BUSINESS IMPACT MODEL — KPI DRIVERS, BASELINE → AFTER

DRIVER	BASELINE	AFTER	$ / EFFECT	BASIS
Runbook	unplanned	343 tasks · 815 h · 61 days	$89,622 effort (modeled)	record / modeled
Irreversible instants	unknown	1 (step 4)	—	record
Rollback triggers	none	2 per interface; never fired	exposure ≈$714 / ≈$297	record / illustrative
New issue rows per month	271 (June)	4 (October)	−98.5%	record
Customer-facing incidents	0 allowed	0 through both go-lives	—	record

THE MATH — FOUR-TABLE DERIVATION (FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION → RESULT) NEW

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Runbook size	`48,885 / 60 = 814.75 h; 48,885 / 343 = 142.5 min per task`	record	≈815 h / 142.5 min avg
2	Window	`May 1 → Jul 1 = 31 + 30 = 61 days; 814.75 / 61 = 13.4 task-hours per day`	record	61 days
3	Irreversible instants	`1 — step 4, zero-then-publish`	record	1
4	Exposure of an unsynced event	`$6 + $4 + $19 + $1 = $30 per oversell`	S1 benchmark	$30
5	Interim state	`two live truths for four months`	record	4 months
6	Arc start	`271 new rows in June (the go-live month)`	record, from the log	271

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Step 1 — clear negatives	`SKU C: AFS_800 = −10 → corrected to 0 (audited); ΣAFS_800 = 560 + 120 + 0 = 680 (was 670)`	illustrative 3-SKU trace; invariant: negatives cleared first	680
2	Step 2 — transfer AFS to Uncommitted	`Σ Uncommitted = 680`	record step	680
3	Step 3 — scan-and-reserve	`reserve the scanned units; no change to Σ`	record step name; effect illustrative	680
4	Step 4 — zero-then-publish	`AFS_800 := 0 for A, B, C; then publish AFS_900 = 560, 120, 0; Σ = 0 + 680 = 680`	one irreversible instant	Σ conserved
5	Double-sellable window avoided	`publish-first would make 680 units sellable on both: 2 × 680 = 1,360 promised on 680`	why zero comes first	never both
6	False-zero window	`≤ 60 s budget; demand in 60 s = 0.165 units/s × 60 = 9.9 units`	100K units/week illustrative	≈9.9 units
7	Asymmetry applied	`undersell 9.9 × $4.75 = $47 vs oversell 9.9 × $30 = $298; ratio 6.3 : 1`	$4.75 = $19 × 25% (illustrative)	6.3 : 1
8	Trigger — sync	`1% × 595.2 u/h = 5.95 events/h × 4 h = 23.8 events × $30 = $714`	595.2 = 100,000/168 (illustrative)	≈$714

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
9	Why persistence	q = 2% healthy per-hour breach: P(4 consecutive) = 0.02^4 = 1.6×10^{-7} vs 0.02 for one hour; over 1,464 windows: 0.00023 vs 29.3 false fires	q illustrative; independence assumed	0.00023 vs 29.3

Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	New issue rows per month	271 (June)	4 (271 → 65 → 21 → 14 → 4, October)	record
2	Blocker + Critical open at go/no-go	441 logged	0 open	record
3	SKU sellable on both locations at once	possible in the interim	never — min(AFS_800, AFS_900) = 0	record invariant
4	Rollbacks fired	armed twice	0	record
5	Hypercare exit	—	week 3 of 4 at < 2 blockers/day	record

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Runbook effort	814.75 h × $110 = $89,622	$110/h blended (modeled)	≈$89.6K
2	Weekly benefit at stake	$1.65M / 52 = $31,731	S2's modeled recurring benefit	≈$31.7K/wk
3	Runbook as weeks of benefit	$89,622 / $31,731 = 2.82 weeks	rows 1–2	≈2.8 weeks
4	Sync-trigger exposure	23.8 events × $30 = $714	illustrative volume	≈$714
5	Staleness exposure at the p95 trigger	9.9 units × $30 = $298	60 s extra window	≈$297
6	One week of slip	$1.65M / 52 = $31,731	deferred benefit (modeled)	≈$31.7K

SOLUTION FLOW — THE SYSTEM & DATA MAP

```
RUNBOOK (343 tasks, owner + duration + predecessor, May 1 -> Jul 1)
 Step 1  clear negatives      (AFS Correction, audited)        reversible
 Step 2  transfer AFS -> Uncommitted                           reversible
 Step 3  scan-and-reserve                                      reversible
 Step 4  ZERO AFS_800 -> PUBLISH AFS_900         <== the one irreversible instant
 Step 5-6 (not in the packet - VERIFY)
      |
 per-interface triggers: sync < 99% for 4 h  |  p95 > 2x budget for 1 h
      | fire -> consumers revert to the prior publish
      v
 hypercare: new rows/month 271 -> 65 -> 21 -> 14 -> 4 ; exit when < 2 blockers/day sustained
 inbound dock side: Proship/TMS re-points wh_id W801 -> W901 shipment by shipment
```

SENSITIVITY — LOW / BASE / HIGH

INPUT	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Blended rate	$90 → $73.3K	$110 → $89.6K	$130 → $105.9K
Volume per hour (sync trigger exposure)	300 u/h → $360	595 u/h → $714	1,000 u/h → $1,200
Healthy per-hour breach q	1% → 0.00001 false fires	2% → 0.00023	5% → 0.0092
Weekly benefit	$1.1M/52 = $21.2K	$1.65M/52 = $31.7K	$2.4M/52 = $46.2K
Runbook as weeks of benefit	—	2.8	4.2 at the low benefit

SPOKEN STATEMENT

> "The cutover was 343 tasks and one irreversible instant. I put every control at that instant — clear the negatives, transfer to uncommitted, scan-and-reserve, then zero the old selling location and publish the new one — so no SKU was ever sellable in two places and the worst case was a sixty-second false zero, which costs about a sixth of a double-sell on S1's benchmarks. The triggers were numbers per interface, and the persistence requirement is why they would not false-fire. I wrote the go/no-go off counted rows; the record is zero customer-facing incidents and a rollback that was armed twice and never needed. The runbook cost about $90,000 of effort at an illustrative rate — under three weeks of the benefit it protected."

IF CHALLENGED

“The rollback never fired — how do you know it works?”

I don’t know it end to end under load, and I will say so. What the record has is that the triggers were armed per interface, the failback concept was consumers revert to the prior publish, and the three mocks ran against the tolerance. The right do-differently is a timed rollback drill in mock three.

“Why four hours?”

Persistence. At an illustrative 2% healthy per-hour breach, four consecutive hours is 1.6×10^{-7} per window; one hour would false-fire about 29 times over the cutover. The assumption is independence — correlated outages break it — so the p95 trigger is the fast path.

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a cutover you owned.	Ownership	343 tasks; one irreversible instant; triggers as numbers; go/no-go off counted rows; zero incidents.	Do not claim I executed the tasks.
Tell me about delivering under a tight timeline.	Deliver Results	61 days; peak untouched; two go-lives; a week of slip is ≈$31.7K modeled.	Do not bank the benefit.
Tell me about a time you held a line on quality under schedule pressure.	Have Backbone	No UAT compression; no-go on one open Blocker; escalated the RTL slip the week it surfaced.	Never claim a no-go that did not happen.
How do you decide when to roll back?	Functional — cutover design	Numeric triggers per interface; persistence; revert to prior publish; a timed drill.	Never say it ‘worked in prod’.

BEHAVIORAL PACK — FOUR SEPARATE 90-SECOND STAR ANSWERS, EACH FROM A DIFFERENT MOMENT OF THE STORY NEW

OWNERSHIP · AIQB Q4 **Q1. “Tell me about a time when you made a hard decision to sacrifice short term gain for something that would create long term value for the business.”**

I recommended giving up speed for certainty — two go-lives and a four-month bake — and wrote the go/no-go off counted rows rather than confidence. By the time of the May cutover Blocker plus Critical open was zero, mock three was inside the 0.5% tolerance, the 343-task runbook had been rehearsed, and rollback was armed per interface. I would have called no-go on one open Blocker, and I meant it. The runbook had one irreversible instant, step four, zero-then-publish, and I put every control at that instant: negatives cleared first, AFS transferred to uncommitted, scan-and-reserve, then zero the old selling location and publish the new. When something needed to be decided, it was decided against a number I had written before anyone was tired. The result was zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives and rollback armed twice, never fired. The interim reporting burden — four months of every report declaring its system of record — was a cost I should have staffed earlier, and I say that too.

Number to land: 343 tasks · 1 irreversible instant · 0 incidents · rollback armed twice, never fired · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF the owner of a new-FC launch writes the go/no-go off counted rows — doors tested, appointments scheduled, UPH validated — and the stop conditions before the first live trailer. · **Do NOT say:** that I executed the tasks; that the rollback was proven under load.

DELIVER RESULTS · AIQB Q1 **Q2. “Give me an example of a time when you were able to deliver an important project under a tight deadline.”**

The window was 61 days, May 1 to July 1, with the October to December peak freeze behind it — so slipping was not free. I wrote the runbook as 343 owned tasks, about 815 hours, each with a predecessor so the critical path was visible. A week of slip was worth about $31,700 of deferred benefit on S2’s modeled $1.65 million a year; the whole runbook cost about $90,000 of effort, under three weeks of that. So when the Locus RTL slipped three weeks I escalated the week it surfaced and re-slotted rather than letting it sit. Two go-lives landed on their dates, the monthly count of new issue rows fell 271 to 65 to 21 to 14 to 4, and hypercare exited in week three of four at under two blockers a day. The +15% processing efficiency was measured post-stabilization by DC Ops. The date held because every task had an owner and a predecessor.

Number to land: 61 days · 815 h · new rows 271 → 4 a month · exit week 3 of 4 · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF a new-FC date lives or dies on the same arithmetic — doors, hours, appointments — written as owned tasks. · **Do NOT say:** that the $31.7K is banked; that the $90K runbook cost is a record.

HAVE BACKBONE; DISAGREE AND COMMIT · AIQB Q5 **Q3. “Tell me about a time when you pushed back against a decision that negatively impacted your team.”**

The Locus RTL slipped three weeks, and the easy way to absorb it was to compress UAT. I refused. I escalated the slip the week it surfaced — not when it hurt — re-slotted the plan openly so everyone saw the new dates, and held UAT at its full length; the robotics were retested after the slip. My argument was the bar itself: Blocker plus Critical open had to be zero at go/no-go, and compressing UAT would have moved findings from the test room to the floor. One open Blocker is a no-go; I never had to call it, because the bar was written before the pressure arrived.

Number to land: RTL slipped 3 weeks · UAT not compressed · B + C open = 0 · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF the same line applies to a launch date — what is the bar, in numbers, that a slipped vendor does not get to lower. · **Do NOT say:** that I overruled steering; the dates were re-slotted openly, not forced.

DIVE DEEP · AIQB Q6 **Q4. "Have you ever created a metric that helped identify a need for a change in your department?"**

I did the arithmetic on the thresholds instead of accepting round numbers. The rollback trigger — sync below 99% for four consecutive hours — sounds arbitrary until you price it: on an illustrative 100,000-unit week, 1% unsynced for four hours is about 24 events, roughly $714 of oversell exposure at $30 each. The four-hour persistence is why it does not false-fire: at an illustrative 2% healthy breach, four consecutive hours is one in six million per window; a single hour would false-fire about 29 times across the cutover. And I traced three SKUs through the irreversible step to prove the invariant: the units across both selling locations sum to the same 680 before and after, and no SKU is sellable on both. The false-zero window costs about a sixth of a double-sell. Detail, not drama.

Number to land: ≈24 events ≈ $714; 0.02^4 vs 0.02; 680 conserved · **Pivot to NACF:** NACF dock and UPH plans run on the same detail — appointment slots and dwell — and I would price every threshold the same way. · **Do NOT say:** that the exposure numbers are measured; they are illustrative on 100K units/week.

SAME STORY, THREE ANGLES — DATA · CONFLICT/INFLUENCE/BACKBONE · FAILURE-LEARNING NEW

DATA ANGLE · DIVE DEEP

"343 tasks, 48,885 minutes, 61 days — and the cutover had one irreversible instant."

Headline metric: 814.75 h · $89.6K · 2.8 weeks of benefit

The runbook arithmetic plus the trigger pricing ($714) and the persistence math show every threshold has a number behind it. Honest limit: volume, rate and q are illustrative.

CONFLICT / INFLUENCE ANGLE · HAVE BACKBONE; DISAGREE AND COMMIT

"When the vendor slipped three weeks, the easy answer was to squeeze UAT. I said no."

Headline metric: RTL +3 weeks; UAT not compressed

Escalated the week it surfaced; re-slotted openly; UAT held at full length; the no-go bar (one open Blocker) was set before the pressure.

FAILURE / LEARNING ANGLE · OWNERSHIP

"For four months every report had to say which system of record it read — and I staffed that workstream in month three."

Headline metric: interim reporting staffed month 3, not day 1

The record's own do-differently: the interim cost was predictable and I treated it as a task, not a workstream. Second honest limit: rollback armed twice, never fired — I cannot prove it under load

confirm whether a timed rollback drill ran in the m

TRAP DRILLS — THE THREE NASTIEST FOLLOW-UPS, WITH NUMERIC ANSWERS NEW

How do you know the cutover worked because of the runbook and not because the team was good?

I can't separate them, and a good team is part of the design: each task had an owner, duration and predecessor. The measurable thing is the invariants held (Σ AFS conserved, no SKU sellable twice) and the monthly new-row arc 271 → 4.

Say: *"The runbook's job was to make good people's work sequenceable; the evidence is that the invariants held and the monthly new-row arc went 271 to 4 — not that the team was lucky."*

Why not one go-live and save the second cutover?

The second cutover buys single-cause diagnosis: in a one-go-live world every issue triages against two hypotheses. The cost of the second go-live is real and in the record: a deliberate four-month bake running two systems of record, with daily reconciliation (Apple C1). The decision is qualitative — triage time, not fix time, is what a 160-issue week costs, and the issues log confirms that week: 68, then 160, then 34 identified in the weeks of June 9, 16 and 23 (computed from the file).

Say: *"I paid for a second cutover to keep diagnosis univariate; that is a judgment call, and I put the price on the table at steering."*

What would have changed your mind on go?

One open Blocker; mock 3 outside 0.5%; a sync read below 99% in the rehearsal; or a rollback I couldn't describe in a sentence per interface.

Say: *"Any one of four numbers — one open Blocker, mock three over half a percent, sync under 99%, or a rollback I couldn't state per interface."*

20-SECOND VERSION + NACF BRIDGE NEW

20-second version. I owned the Utah DC cutover runbook — 343 tasks, about 815 hours, a 61-day window — with one irreversible instant, zero-then-publish, rollback triggers written as numbers per interface (sync under 99% for four hours; p95 over twice budget for an hour), and a go/no-go off counted rows; zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives and rollback never needed.

NACF bridge. NACF's new-FC launch has the same irreversible instant — the first live inbound appointment — and I would write it the same way: an owned-task runbook, a numeric go/no-go, and stop conditions before the first trailer. At Sephora the dock-side version was re-pointing each inbound shipment's warehouse ID W801 → W901 in Proship/TMS, shipment by shipment; at NACF the CAP-A 85% door ceiling is the slack that absorbs a re-pointed or late trailer.

U6 — Negative AFS and the AFS Correction screen — detecting an over-committed SKU, root-causing it to one of three seams, and giving every AFS-changing act a screen, a role and an audit row NEW

LPs this story serves here: Dive Deep (primary — decomposing a negative to its cause class) · Ownership (the control-owner map handed off) · Customer Obsession (a negative is a promise we cannot keep) · Insist on the Highest Standards (drift tolerance zero; negatives clean at T+1)
Process family: Deliver / Return — inventory-accuracy control: exception detection, root cause by cause class, control-owner governance

Honesty label. Record: AFS = Basis − PickRes − EcomPick − EcomPack − SNB; negatives cleared first at cutover; Negative AFS clean at T+1 was a go-live exit bar; daily ISM-vs-MB52 drift with tolerance 0 — a non-zero drift is a Sev, not a planning variance; control-owner map: Negative AFS → Inventory Control, Internal Audit and Finance; AFS Correction → ISM app team; the daily drift report → Inventory Control; every AFS-changing act had a screen, a role and an audit row; the register's top three risks — vocabulary drift, feed latency from WMS/OMS/POS, override abuse on AFS-changing screens — are my three cause classes. **Illustrative:** the −10 SKU, its 5/3/2 split, $30 per incident, the σ = 10 sanity check. Record-from-docs (issues-log file, Comments column): row ID 716 and row ID 818 — the only two of 836 rows that name AFS. I defined the screens, owners and cause classes; ISM app and platform teams built them; the control owners run them.

LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES CARRIED — ONE-LINE PROOF EACH

Dive Deep. A negative AFS is a symptom; I decomposed it into three cause classes — event cardinality, feed latency, override — each with a different fix and a different owner.

Ownership. Every AFS-changing act had a screen, a role and an audit row before I stepped back; the control owners ran the Negative AFS report without me.

Customer Obsession. A negative AFS is units already promised that the floor cannot back; I treated it as a customer defect with a clock, not a variance.

Insist on the Highest Standards. Drift tolerance was zero — a non-zero drift is a Sev — and the exit bar was zero SKUs of drift on consecutive days, with negatives clean at T+1.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Once Sephora's Utah DC became one comingled pool with one published AFS per node per channel, there was one new failure mode: a SKU whose committed buckets exceed what the floor can back — a negative AFS, units we have already promised and cannot ship. **Task.** Own how that is detected, root-caused and fixed, and who is allowed to change an AFS at all. **Action.** I defined the screens and the control-owner map before go-live: the Negative AFS report to Inventory Control, Internal Audit and Finance; the AFS Correction screen to the ISM app team; the daily drift report, ISM-vs-MB52, to Inventory Control, with tolerance zero — a non-zero drift is a Sev, not a planning variance. Every AFS-changing act had a screen, a role and an audit row. Root cause went by cause class — the register's top three: event cardinality, feed latency, override — so a worked SKU at minus ten decomposes into a duplicate event, a lagging WMS feed and a manual override, each with its own owner. The asymmetry behind it: oversell costs about $30 and an undersold unit about $4.75, a 6.3-to-1 ratio, so the published number sits near the 14th percentile of true availability — and the lower-of-two basis gets within a unit of that. **Result.** Primary metric: customer-facing oversell incidents zero through both go-lives; negatives clean at T+1 at cutover; drift at zero SKUs on consecutive days at hypercare exit; the control owners running the report without me.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — A comingled pool publishes one AFS per node per channel and the OMS reads it, never computes it. When committed buckets exceed Basis, AFS goes negative: units promised that the floor cannot back. Before ISM, two books were reconciled by hand — about 4 FTE — and a negative surfaced as an order that could not ship.

T — Design detection, cause-class root-causing and ownership for exceptions that change AFS — so that a negative is found, explained, fixed and audited by the people who own the consequence, not by me.

Baselines on the table: ≈4 FTE reconciling two books by hand · drift unmeasured → tolerance 0 · negatives clean at T+1 as a go-live bar · the register's top-three risks (vocabulary drift, feed latency, override abuse) each with a trigger, a mitigation and an owner — mine was drift.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (3/29 → 4/30)** — bucket inventory with one owner per bucket; where in the old world negatives appeared and who chased them; sessions closed 4/30. *Exit bar:* every bucket owned by one system; open questions dated.
- **Plan & Design (5/15 → 8/14)** — wrote AFS = Basis − buckets; asymmetry (oversell customer defect / undersell planning variance); drift tolerance 0; screens and roles; the three cause classes from the risk register. *Exit bar:* FSD signed 8/14; every AFS-changing act has a

screen and a role.

- **Build & Test (Aug → Jan/Apr)** — matrix cells for negatives, replays and overrides (U1); AFS Correction audit-row assertions; SIT contract defects closed before UAT. *Exit bar:* Blocker + Critical open = 0; E2E days dated.
- **Cutover & Go-Live (January; May 1 → Jul 1)** — step 1 of the May choreography: clear negatives first; Negative AFS clean at T+1; the screens live with control owners assigned. *Exit bar:* negatives clean at T+1; no SKU with two published AFS values.
- **Hypercare / Close (Jun → Jul)** — daily drift report; Negative AFS / AFS Correction audit review; control-owner handoff; exit into the monthly release train. *Exit bar:* drift = 0 SKUs on consecutive days; owners running the report without me.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the cause classes, the screens' definitions, the owner map, the tolerance. ISM app and platform teams built the screens; Inventory Control, Internal Audit and Finance run Negative AFS; the ISM app team runs AFS Correction.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** Control owners and the monthly release train own the screens now. **Trade-off put to leadership:** visible undersell and a zero-tolerance drift — more investigations — against oversell as a customer defect; I accepted the investigations.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY

- **$** — modeled from S1: reconciliation 4 → 1 FTE = 3 × $110K = $330K/yr; baseline oversell exposure 30,000/365 = 82.2 incidents/day × $30 = $2,466/day on illustrative orders. Not claimed as savings; the record movement is incidents → zero.
- **#** — negatives clean at T+1 at cutover; drift = 0 SKUs on consecutive days; 3 cause classes; 3 control-owner orgs + the ISM app team (record).
- **%** — asymmetry 1 : 6.3; critical ratio 13.7% (modeled on S1's benchmark).
- **Time** — T+1 at cutover; hypercare exit week 3 of 4; FSD signed 8/14 (record).
- **Customer** — customer-facing oversell incidents zero through both go-lives (record).
- **Quality** — every AFS-changing act has a screen, a role and an audit row; drift tolerance 0 (record design).

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — every line is this story's record or labeled model, no new canon numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	Nobody owned exceptions to the published number; I defined cause classes, owners and tolerances.
Scope & influence	Inventory Control, Internal Audit, Finance and the ISM app team — four groups that did not report to me — own the screens.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others own	Zero-tolerance drift (more investigations) against ambiguity; the mechanism others own: the screens and the audit rows.
Impact	Oversell incidents zero through both go-lives; reconciliation moved from argument to a daily report.
Process improvement	Exceptions have a class, an owner, a screen and an audit row; the same map applies to any new node or channel.
Complexity & consensus	Three orgs signed the definitions; four groups run the controls.
Root cause at scale	Negatives collapse into three seams (cardinality, latency, override); the fix is at the seam, not the SKU.

PROBING — FIVE FACETS, THEN THE HARDEST FOLLOW-UPS NEW

THE FIVE FACETS — WHERE EACH ONE LIVES IN THIS STORY

1 · Data analysis. Grain: SKU × node × channel × bucket × time. Data: ISM buckets, MB52 snapshot, the audit rows — and, for the legacy-side evidence, the 836-row WMS/Locus issues log: a keyword search of its five text columns finds only two rows that name AFS. Row ID 716 (Critical, IC): 'Dept 96 has 1800 SKUs. 400 are − AFS in MCS and 0 in BY' — 22.2% of that department's SKUs negative in the legacy book and none in the WMS. Row ID 818 (Critical): inventory holds validated moving units 'from AFS to Merch Res after about 10min' — a latency datum inside the ≤15-minute feed budget. Cuts: negatives by cause class. Revealed: the WMS defect book is nearly silent on AFS, so exceptions to the published number needed their own controls in ISM/S/4.

2 · Solution design. Options: (A) reconcile by hand (4 FTE); (B) a daily report with no owners; (C) a screen + role + audit row per AFS-changing act with a cause class (chosen). A and B leave exceptions unowned.

3 · Math & data logic. AFS = 25 − (12 + 10 + 8 + 5) = −10; critical ratio = $4.75 ÷ ($4.75 + $30) = 13.7%; z = -1.10; buffer = 1.10 × σ(10) = 11.0; lower-of-two sits 10 below the mean of the books (990 → 980); drift = 957 − 957 = 0.

4 · Implementation. Screens and owners at design; clear negatives first at cutover; T+1; daily drift at hypercare; handoff and exit memo. Risks: vocabulary drift, feed latency, override abuse.

5 · Probe questions. Below: how do you root-cause a negative, why tolerance zero, what the screen cannot see, who owns what, and the three trap drills.

FACET 5 — PROBE QUESTIONS (CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER)

Infra — a SKU shows −10. What do you do?

Decompose by cause class. Cardinality: an event in two buckets (a duplicate SNB) — fix the event, replay is a no-op, add a matrix cell. Latency: a WMS adjustment still inside the ≤15-minute feed plus under-5-minute consumer lag — wait and re-read. Override: a manual AFS change — check role and audit row. On the illustrative split 5/3/2 the first fix takes the −10 to −5.

Infra — why drift tolerance of zero?

Because the books should agree and a difference means one of them is wrong; a non-zero drift is a Sev, not a planning variance. It also made the hypercare exit crisp: zero SKUs of drift on consecutive days. If I had to set a non-zero tolerance I would price it: each unit is up to $30.

Infra — what can the Negative AFS screen not see?

Undersell. It is a one-sided detector: a SKU showing less than the floor could sell never goes negative. The asymmetry makes that deliberate, but it means a wrong rule that starves a channel (my first in-transit rule, master S4) is invisible to it.

Infra — who owns what?

Negative AFS: Inventory Control, Internal Audit and Finance. AFS Correction: the ISM app team. The daily drift report: Inventory Control. Every AFS-changing act has a screen, a role and an audit row; override abuse was the register's third risk.

Infra — why is the lower-of-two the right buffer?

Sanity check, not a derivation: a critical ratio of 13.7% puts the published number about 1.10σ under the mean; if the two books' half-gap (10) is one σ, that is ≈11.0 units — and min(1,000, 980) sits 10 under the books' mean of 990.

BUSINESS IMPACT MODEL — KPI DRIVERS, BASELINE → AFTER

DRIVER	BASELINE	AFTER	$ / EFFECT	BASIS
Exception ownership	unowned; 4 FTE by hand	screen + role + audit row; ≈1 FTE reading the drift report	≈$0.33M/yr (S1 modeled)	modeled
Drift (ISM vs MB52)	unmeasured	0 SKUs on consecutive days	tolerance 0	record
Negatives at cutover	present	clean at T+1	—	record
Oversell incidents	recurring	zero through two go-lives	baseline ≈$2,466/day exposure (illustrative)	record / illustrative
Asymmetry	implicit	1 : 6.3 (explicit)	critical ratio 13.7%	modeled

THE MATH — FOUR-TABLE DERIVATION (FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION → RESULT) NEW

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	A negative SKU	`Basis = min(30, 25) = 25; buckets = 12 + 10 + 8 + 5 = 35; AFS = 25 − 35 = −10`	illustrative SKU	−10
2	Exposure	`10 × $30 = $300`	S1 all-in cost per incident (benchmark)	$300
3	Cost of an oversell vs an undersell	`oversell $30; undersell = $19 × 25% = $4.75; ratio = 6.3`	$19 margin; 25% not recovered (illustrative)	6.3 : 1
4	Baseline oversell rate	`30,000,000 × 0.10% / 365 = 82.2/day × $30 = $2,466/day`	S1 illustrative orders; benchmark rate	≈$2.5K/day
5	Reconciliation burden	`≈4 FTE by hand`	record baseline	≈4 FTE
6	Where the AFS evidence sits in the log	`2 of 836 rows name AFS (0.24%); ID 716: 400 ÷ 1,800 = 22.2% of Dept 96 SKUs negative in MCS, 0 in BY`	issues-log file, Comments column (record-from-docs)	22.2%

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Cause class — cardinality	`duplicate SNB event: SNB 5 → 0; AFS = 25 − (35 − 5) = −5`	illustrative 5 of the 10	−10 → −5
2	Cause class — latency	`WMS adjustment +3 arrives inside the 15-min feed: Basis = 28; AFS = 28 − 30 = −2`	illustrative 3 of the 10	−5 → −2

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
3	Cause class — override	`unauthorized 2-unit manual hold reversed via AFS Correction (role + audit row): AFS = −2 + 2 = 0`	illustrative 2 of the 10	−2 → 0
4	Decomposition check	`5 + 3 + 2 = 10 = |−10|`	illustrative split	10
5	Critical ratio	`CR = cu ÷ (cu + co) = 4.75 ÷ 34.75 = 13.7%; z = -1.10`	newsvendor (toolkit label)	13.7%
6	Buffer sanity check	`σ = (1,000 − 980) ÷ 2 = 10; buffer = 1.10 × 10 = 11.0; mean of books 990; min = 980 → 10 below`	illustrative; not a derivation	≈11.0 vs 10
7	Daily drift	`Drift = 957 − 957 = 0`	record tolerance 0	0
8	Exit bars	`negatives clean at T+1; drift = 0 SKUs on consecutive days`	record	met

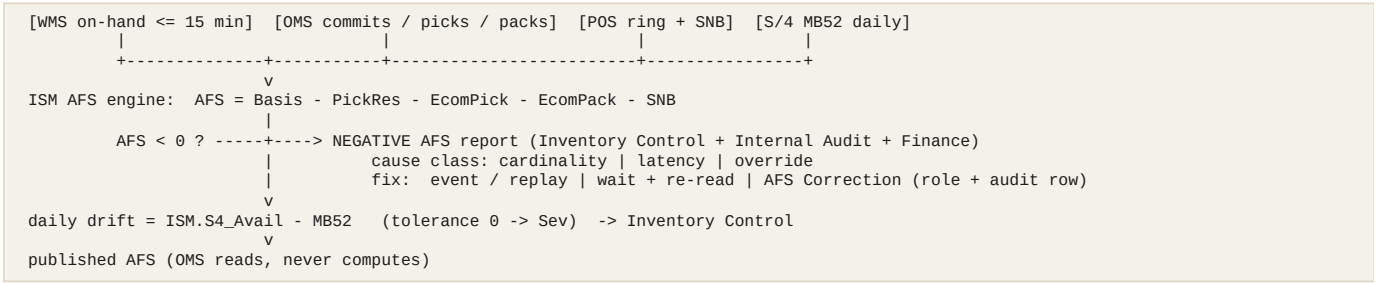
Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Exception ownership	unowned / hand reconciliation	screen + role + audit row	record design
2	Drift	unmeasured	0 SKUs on consecutive days	record
3	Reconciliation FTE	≈4	≈1	modeled
4	Oversell incidents	recurring	zero through two go-lives	record
5	Negatives at cutover	present	clean at T+1	record

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Reconciliation labor	`(4 − 1) × $110,000 = $330,000`	S1 modeled; $110K loaded (benchmark)	≈$0.33M/yr
2	Oversell exposure per day (baseline)	`82.2 × $30 = $2,466`	S1 illustrative orders × benchmark rate	≈$2.5K/day
3	Exposure of the worked negative	`10 × $30 = $300`	illustrative SKU	$300
4	Exposure if the −10 is cured in cause-class order	`−10 → −5 → −2 → 0: remaining exposure $150 → $60 → $0`	illustrative split	$300 → $0
5	Asymmetry in dollars	`$30 vs $4.75; 30 ÷ 4.75 = 6.3`	S1 benchmark; 25% illustrative	6.3 : 1

SOLUTION FLOW — THE SYSTEM & DATA MAP



SENSITIVITY — LOW / BASE / HIGH

INPUT	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Undersell recovered share	50% → cu $9.50 · CR 24.1%	25% → cu $4.75 · CR 13.7%	10% → cu $1.90 · CR 6.0%
Gap between books (σ = half-gap)	10 → σ 5 → buffer 5.5	20 → σ 10 → buffer 11.0	40 → σ 20 → buffer 21.9
Oversell rate	0.05% → $1.2K/day	0.10% → $2.5K/day	0.25% → $6.2K/day
Reconciliation FTE released	2 × $95K = $0.19M	3 × $110K = $0.33M	4 × $130K = $0.52M
Cause-class split (illustrative)	1 / 1 / 8	5 / 3 / 2	8 / 1 / 1

SPOKEN STATEMENT

> “A negative AFS is units we have already promised and the floor cannot back. I did not treat it as one thing: it decomposes into three seams — an event that landed in two buckets, a feed that has not caught up, and a manual override — and each has a different fix and a different owner. Inventory Control, Internal Audit and Finance run the Negative AFS report; the ISM app team runs the AFS Correction screen; every AFS-changing act has a screen, a role and an audit row. The drift tolerance is zero because a difference means one book is wrong. The record is negatives clean at T+1, drift at zero on consecutive days at hypercare exit, and zero customer-facing oversell incidents through both go-lives; the dollar view is an asymmetry — about six to one — on benchmark inputs.”

IF CHALLENGED

“The 5/3/2 split is made up.”

It is illustrative, tagged, and I would not quote it. What is record is the three cause classes — they are the register’s top three risks — and the owner for each. The real split is a pull from the audit rows.

“How do you know the controls — not the matrix — kept incidents at zero?”

I can’t isolate them. The controls and the matrix are two halves: the matrix proves the events are mapped; the screens catch what the mapping did not. The record is the combination: zero incidents, drift at zero, negatives clean.

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you found the root cause of a recurring issue.	Dive Deep	A negative decomposes into cardinality / latency / override; fix at the seam.	Never quote the 5/3/2 split as measured.
Tell me about a time you built something that others now own.	Ownership	Screens, roles, audit rows; control-owner map; they ran it without me.	Do not claim I built the screens.
Tell me about a time you put the customer ahead of an internal metric.	Customer Obsession	Visible undersell accepted so oversell is zero by construction; 1 : 6.3.	Do not claim the dollars as saved.
What does a high standard look like in inventory accuracy?	Insist on the Highest Standards	Drift tolerance 0; negatives clean at T+1; zero SKUs on consecutive days.	Do not call 0 tolerance easy.

BEHAVIORAL PACK — FOUR SEPARATE 90-SECOND STAR ANSWERS, EACH FROM A DIFFERENT MOMENT OF THE STORY NEW

DIVE DEEP · AIQB Q2 **Q1. “Tell me about a situation that required you to dig deep to get to the root cause.”**

The recurring problem was a negative available-to-sell — units promised that the floor could not back — and the first instinct is to fix the SKU. I looked at what a negative actually is: committed buckets exceeding the supply basis. Take a worked SKU with a basis of 25 and 35 units committed: minus ten. I decomposed it into three cause classes — the register’s top three: an event that landed in two buckets, a feed that had not caught up, and a manual override. A duplicate event in the shipped-not-billed bucket takes the minus ten to minus five; a warehouse adjustment still inside the fifteen-minute feed takes it to minus two; an unauthorized override, removed through the AFS Correction screen with a role and an audit row, takes it to zero. Each cause class has a different fix and a different owner, so the fix is at the seam, not the SKU. That is why the matrix has a cell for each, and why the control owners had a cause class to write on every audit row.

Number to land: −10 → −5 → −2 → 0 (illustrative); 3 cause classes · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF, a negative-available ASIN decomposes the same way — a double receive scan, dock-to-stock lag, a manual adjustment — and I would ask which seam first. · **Do NOT say:** that the 5/3/2 split is measured; that I built the screens.

OWNERSHIP · AIQB Q5 **Q2. “Describe a time when you had to transition a project you owned to a new owner.”**

I did not finish the program until the exceptions had owners who did not need me. Before go-live I mapped every AFS-changing act to a screen, a role and an audit row, and every exception report to an owner: the Negative AFS report to Inventory Control, Internal Audit and Finance; the AFS Correction screen to the ISM app team; the daily ISM-versus-MB52 drift report to Inventory Control. In hypercare the test was whether the control owners ran the report without me — part of the exit bar, along with drift at zero SKUs on consecutive days and blockers under two a day. Then the design entered the monthly release train, so a new node or channel is a matrix row and an owner row, not a project. I measure ownership by whether the process survived my leaving.

Number to land: 3 owner orgs + ISM app team; drift 0 on consecutive days · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF I would hand a launch’s exception reports to named owners with a screen, a role and an audit row before the first live trailer. · **Do NOT say:** that I run the screens now; the control owners do.

CUSTOMER OBSESSION · AIQB Q8 **Q3. "Tell me about a time when you had to balance the needs of the customer with the needs of the business."**

The convenient metric was a clean-looking available number; the customer's interest was a promise we could keep. A negative AFS is a customer we have already told yes. So the policy is an asymmetry: an oversell is a customer defect, about thirty dollars on benchmark inputs; an undersell is a planning variance, about five. That is roughly six to one, and the asymmetry decides the design — the supply basis is the lower of the two books, so the published number sits conservatively under the truth. The price is visible undersell: some sellable stock shows as unavailable, and Inventory Control chases it. I accepted that on purpose. A sanity check supports it: a six-to-one asymmetry puts the right published number about one standard deviation below the mean, and the lower-of-two sits within about a unit of that on the worked SKU. The record is customer-facing oversell incidents going to zero through both go-lives.

Number to land: 1 : 6.3 asymmetry; critical ratio 13.7%; incidents → zero · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF the promise date on an order is the same commitment — I would hold a conservative buffer against a missed date on the same arithmetic. · **Do NOT say:** that undersell is free; that 6.3 is measured — it rests on S1's benchmark and a 25% assumption.

INSIST ON THE HIGHEST STANDARDS · AIQB Q1 **Q4. "Describe a time when you refused to compromise your standards around quality/customer service, etc."**

I set the drift tolerance at zero, and people reasonably asked whether that was realistic. The daily check is ISM's copy of S/4 available against the MB52 snapshot, and a non-zero drift is a Sev, not a planning variance, because two books that should agree and don't mean one of them is wrong — and you do not know which one a customer will meet. The cost is more investigations — the trade I accepted. I made the standard checkable: negatives clean at T+1 at cutover, drift zero SKUs on consecutive days as the hypercare exit, and blockers under two a day. It held because the exit was a number nobody could negotiate. The thing I would say honestly is that zero tolerance is a posture, not a guarantee — it is only as good as the cause class written on each audit row.

Number to land: drift tolerance 0; exit: 0 SKUs on consecutive days · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF I would set the same kind of zero-tolerance reconciliation on dock-received versus system-available counts, with a number for the exit. · **Do NOT say:** that zero tolerance is easy or free; that it guarantees correctness.

SAME STORY, THREE ANGLES — DATA · CONFLICT/INFLUENCE/BACKBONE · FAILURE-LEARNING NEW

DATA ANGLE · DIVE DEEP

"A negative AFS decomposes into three seams — cardinality, latency, override."

Headline metric: −10 → −5 → −2 → 0 (illustrative)

Cause class decides the fix and the owner; a real log row shows the shape — Dept 96, 400 of 1,800 SKUs negative in the legacy book and zero in the WMS (22.2%) — and a hold feed validated at about 10 minutes against a ≤15-minute budget. Honest limit: the split is illustrative until audit rows are pulled.

CONFLICT / INFLUENCE ANGLE · OWNERSHIP

"Four groups that did not report to me had to own the exception screens before I stepped back."

Headline metric: 3 owner orgs + the ISM app team

The map was in the FSD signed by three orgs (user anchor, master S1); hypercare tested whether the control owners ran the report without me. Influence: a screen, a role and an audit row per act — not a meeting.

FAILURE / LEARNING ANGLE · INSIST ON THE HIGHEST STANDARDS

"'Clean' meant zero negatives — and zero can be reached by an override."

Headline metric: negatives clean at T+1 ≠ cause removed

The exit bar measured the symptom; override abuse was the register's third risk. Do differently: a clean requires a cause class on the audit row, not just a zero.

confirm whether cause class was recorded on au

TRAP DRILLS — THE THREE NASTIEST FOLLOW-UPS, WITH NUMERIC ANSWERS NEW

How do you know the Negative AFS screen is why incidents went to zero?

I can't isolate it. The matrix proves the events are mapped; the screens catch what the mapping missed; drift at zero is the check that books agree. The record is the combination.

Say: *"I can't separate the screens from the matrix — I can tell you the three checks each caught a different class, and that the combination went to zero incidents."*

Zero-tolerance drift isn't realistic — what is the false-positive cost?

Every difference is investigated, so the cost is investigator hours; the benefit is no unexplained difference between books. A non-zero tolerance would price each unit at up to $30 of exposure; the exit bar made zero crisp.

Say: *"A zero tolerance costs investigation time, and I chose it because an unexplained difference between books is a customer promise I cannot see."*

What can your detector not see?

Undersell — a one-sided detector. A wrong rule that starves a channel never goes negative; the asymmetry makes that deliberate but unusual undersell needs a separate watch — which is what I would add.

Say: *"The Negative AFS screen is blind to undersell by design; the missing control is a watch on unusual undersell, and I would add it."*

20-SECOND VERSION + NACF BRIDGE NEW

20-second version. At the Utah DC I owned exception control for the published AFS: a negative AFS decomposes into three cause classes — duplicate event, feed latency, override — each with an owner, every AFS-changing act has a screen, a role and an audit row, and drift tolerance is zero; negatives were clean at T+1, drift zero on consecutive days, and customer-facing oversell went to zero through both go-lives.

NACF bridge. NACF's equivalent is an ASIN whose committed units exceed what the building can back — a double receive scan, dock-to-stock lag (the dwell side of CAP-D) or a manual adjustment. I would stand up the same map — cause class, owner, screen, role, audit row — and a zero-tolerance reconciliation between dock-received and system-available counts before an FC ramps.

U7 — The 836-row issues log as the building's readiness instrument — severity-first reading, and the 42 rows where the dock, the floor, the power and the footprint were the problem NEW

LPs this story serves here: Dive Deep (primary — three cuts of one book: severity, flow, month) · Insist on the Highest Standards (one grammar; a visible deferral over a buried blocker) · Ownership (rows with no system owner: conveyor, aisle 45, power, guardrails) · Earn Trust (the worst number in the room was mine to say out loud)
Process family: Plan / Execute — program readiness measurement: one log, one grammar, severity-first triage, and the physical-node slice of the defect book

Honesty label. Record-from-docs, computed with pandas from *UDC_Consolidated_Issues_Log_for_BY_WMS-Locus - Copy* (sheet 1; 836 rows × 19 columns; an .xlsx container with a .CSV extension): status, priority, category, type, operation, functional area, owner and date counts are exact. Where I cut a free-text field (Operation; Functional Area) I say which labels I counted. **Limits I will state before I am asked:** the file has no close-date column, so I cannot compute time-to-close or reconstruct what was open at go/no-go from it; it is a late snapshot (last row 2025-10-01); the building slice is my own label grouping. The ACL request-row counts (Dev 310 · QA 255 · Perf 200 · Prod 221) are record from my Apple workbook (C2), not recomputed. Dollar figures in Table 4 are **modeled/illustrative** (30 min a row; $110/h blended, as S5/U5) and are not claimed as savings.

LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES CARRIED — ONE-LINE PROOF EACH

Dive Deep. I read one 836-row book three ways — severity, flow, month — and the three cuts said different things: Blockers and Criticals closed at 99.4% and 97.1% against 60.0% for Lows; Dotcom was the most severe flow; June was a spike with a 0.35 monthly decay.

Insist on the Highest Standards. One log, one grammar, no side lists; a parking-lot status meant 'decided not now' in writing with an owner — never silently deleted — and the weekly review read Blocker and Critical rows first.

Ownership. 17 of the 42 building rows (conveyor, aisle 45, Locus power, guardrails, chargers) sat with Operations, Engineering or Maintenance — not IT; they went into the same log with a name and a date.

Earn Trust. Any VP could open the log any Monday and see what the team saw; the worst number in the room was mine to say out loud, including the 271-row June spike.

60-SECOND BUSINESS-FIRST PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. The Sephora Utah DC conversion ran about thirty build tracks and sixty-plus stakeholders over about a dozen impacted systems; status by opinion would have drowned it. **Task.** Build the instrument that told us whether the building was ready — before cutover week, not during it. **Action.** One consolidated issues log with one grammar — status, priority, operation, functional area, owner on every row — read Blocker and Critical first at a weekly two-block review, with a parking-lot status for 'decided not now' and one coupled build plan beside it. **Result.** 836 rows; 714 closed — 85.4% — and 98.0% of the 441 Blockers and Criticals; the June go-live spike of 271 rows burned down 65, 21, 14, 4; and the 42 rows where the building itself was the problem — dock, appointments, conveyor, aisle 45, Locus power, footprint — were 92.9% closed with none of the open three a Blocker or Critical. Zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives.

SITUATION / TASK — THE BUSINESS PROCESS PROBLEM, SCOPE, SCALE, BASELINES

S — About thirty build tracks, sixty-plus stakeholders, about a dozen impacted systems and a building that kept shipping. The risk I was asked to instrument was go-live readiness: defect burn-down, track completion, cutover preparedness. Issues arrived from IT, DC Ops, Engineering, Maintenance and the robotics vendor, in different vocabularies, with no shared priority scale.

T — Make a surprise show up in a Monday review, not in cutover week: one log, one build plan, one runbook — three views of the same dataset — and a way to read the book that put the dangerous rows first.

The book as it stands (computed): 836 rows · 714 closed (85.4%) · 122 not closed, of which 112 carry an open status and 10 have a blank status · Blocker 164 + Critical 277 = 441 (52.8% of the book) · bugs are only 115 rows (13.8%) — the rest are requirements, actions, questions and parked decisions: a work-triage system, not a defect list.

ACTION — THE PROCESS / OPERATING-MODEL REDESIGN, IN GATED PHASES

- **Discovery (3/29 → 4/30)** — agreed the grammar before the first real row: one status ladder (A open → F closed), one priority scale (0 Blocker → 4 Low), operation, functional area and owner on every row; one owner per row. *Exit bar:* grammar signed by IT and DC Ops; no side lists.
- **Plan & Design (5/15 → 8/14)** — decomposed the build plan into about thirty tracks, holiday freeze and critical path visible; physical-node work (conveyor, aisle 45 relabel, guardrails, footprint defaults) entered the log with a named owner and a date rather than living in a facilities thread. *Exit bar:* every track mapped to an E2E gate; building rows owned.
- **Build & Test (Aug → Jan/Apr)** — weekly two-block review (30 min IT, 30 min business) reading Blocker and Critical first; monthly arc watched — about 90 rows in each of February and March from the January bake plus Locus physical testing; Locus-side rows held to 86

(10.3%). *Exit bar:* every red row has a name and a date.

- **Cutover & Go-Live (January; May 1 → Jul 1)** — the log as the readiness gate: both go-lives read burn-down curves, not confidence; network ACL request workbooks per environment as the access gate (Dev 310 · QA 255 · Perf 200 · Prod 221 rows). *Exit bar:* Blocker + Critical bar from the go/no-go; access gate closed per environment.
- **Hypercare / Close (Jun → Oct)** — the 271-row June spike read as healing: 65 → 21 → 14 → 4; the open tail stayed visible and owned. *Exit bar:* decay, not plateau; every open row owned.

Influence and ownership. Mine: the grammar, the weekly read order, the parking-lot rule, the coupling of log, plan and runbook, and the readiness call off counted rows. Sephora IT/WMS (342 rows), Operations (111), Engineering/Maintenance and Locus (86) owned and closed their rows.

> **Designed the process; others own it now.** The log, the plan and the runbook are one dataset in three views, so the next program inherits an instrument, not a habit. **Trade-off put to leadership:** attention — the parking-lot status made deferral explicit so the Blocker-and-Critical half of the book got the room's time.

RESULTS — $ · # · % · TIME · CUSTOMER · QUALITY

- **$** — modeled, not claimed: triaging 836 rows at 30 minutes each ≈ 418 h × $110 = $45,980 ≈ 1.45 weeks of the modeled ≈$31,731/week benefit — the log pays back if it prevents about a week and a half of slip.
- **#** — 836 rows; 714 closed; 441 Blocker + Critical, 432 closed; June spike 271 → 4; building slice 42 rows, 39 closed (computed from the file).
- **%** — 85.4% closed overall; 98.0% of Blocker + Critical closed; closure falls with severity — 99.4%, 97.1%, 75.4%, 69.7%, 60.0% — the read order showed in the curve.
- **Time** — fifteen months discovery through go-live; June spike decay ≈0.35 per month, half-life ≈20 days.
- **Customer** — zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives (record).
- **Quality** — one grammar, no side lists; deferral explicit; every red row with a name and a date.

L6 LEVEL EVIDENCE — every line is this story's record or labeled model, no new canon numbers

L6 DIMENSION	EVIDENCE IN THIS STORY
Ambiguity	Nobody owned 'ready'; I defined it as counted rows in one log read in a fixed order.
Scope & influence	Sixty-plus stakeholders; IT, Operations, Engineering, Maintenance and the robotics vendor all wrote to the same log — none reported to me.
Execution trade-off + mechanism others own	Attention to Blocker and Critical over a flat read of 836 rows; the mechanism others own: the log grammar and the Monday review.
Impact	Both go-lives read readiness from rows; 432 of 441 Blockers and Criticals closed.
Process improvement	Log, plan and runbook as one dataset in three views; deferral made explicit.
Complexity & consensus	Different vocabularies reduced to five fields; one scale.
Root cause at scale	The monthly shape — ramp, spike, decay — separates a healing cutover from a design problem.

PROBING — FIVE FACETS, THEN THE HARDEST FOLLOW-UPS NEW

THE FIVE FACETS — WHERE EACH ONE LIVES IN THIS STORY

1 · Data analysis. Grain: one row per issue; 19 columns. Joins: none — the discipline was one table. Cuts: severity × status (closure gradient); operation (five flows by exact label: 675 of 836 rows, 161 free-text or blank); month; owner; functional area (dock and building labels). Revealed: closure rates fall monotonically with severity; Dotcom was the most severe flow (64.5% Blocker + Critical); the June spike was 88.2% Go-Live category and decayed fast; the building slice ran more severe than the book (64.3% vs 52.8%) but z = 1.50 — directional, not proven.

2 · Solution design. Options: (A) status by opinion in decks; (B) one tool per track; (C) one log with one grammar, coupled to one build plan and one runbook (chosen). A and B make two rows describe one issue and the counts lie; C makes the count the gate.

3 · Math & data logic. Closure = closed ÷ rows by severity; Blocker + Critical share = 441 ÷ 836 = 52.8%; decay r = (4 ÷ 271)^(1/4) = 0.349, half-life = ln 2 ÷ −ln r = 0.66 months ≈ 20 days; building-slice z = (0.643 − 0.528) ÷ √(0.528 × 0.472 ÷ 42) = 1.50.

4 · Implementation. Five gated phases; the log, the build plan (~30 tracks) and the cutover runbook (343 tasks) as three views; ACL request workbooks per environment as the access gate; weekly two-block review. Risks: duplicate rows, free-text drift, priority inflation.

5 · Probe questions. Below: is 836 a defect fire, how do you know the log is honest, what does the monthly shape tell you, what is in the building slice, and the three trap drills.

FACET 5 — PROBE QUESTIONS (CHALLENGE Q&A TUNED TO THIS INTERVIEWER)

Infra — 836 issues. Isn't that a defect fire?

No — the log proves it. Bugs are 115 rows, 13.8%; the rest are requirements (159), action items, questions (23) and parked decisions. It was the program's work-triage system. What I do read as a risk signal is that 52.8% of the book is Blocker or Critical — and then the closure gradient: 99.4% of Blockers closed against 60.0% of Lows. If everything had been priority one, the curve would be flat; it is not.

Infra — what did the log say about the physical building?

Forty-two rows — 5.0% of the book — carried dock and appointment flow (23) or floor, power and footprint (19): TMS appointments with no POs attached in training (Blocker), retail pallet-build positions not available (Critical), ‘Facilities team remove half of conveyor’ (Critical), remove the west side of aisle 45 and relabel (Critical), Locus IDF temporary power until January 6 (Blocker), remove the yellow guardrail between retail and dotcom (Blocker), update large and standard footprint per SKU with large as the default (Blocker). 27 of the 42 were Blocker or Critical — 64.3% — and 39 closed; the three open were not B+C.

Infra — what does the June spike tell you?

271 rows in one month — 32.4% of the book — 239 of them Go-Live category. Then 65, 21, 14, 4: each month retained about a third of the last, r = 0.35, half-life about 20 days. A spike with fast decay is a healthy cutover; one that plateaus is a design problem. I would have wanted that picture on the wall from the first hundred rows.

Infra — how do you know the log is honest?

One row per issue, one grammar, a weekly read where the worst number was mine to say, a dedupe step in the rhythm — two rows for one issue and the counts lie — and ‘parking lot’ meaning decided-not-now in writing. The file does not carry close dates, so I will not claim a time-to-close from it.

Infra — why were Locus rows only a tenth of the book?

86 rows — 10.3% — because the robotics workstream had its own rhythm and owner, and the 98% gate with the throttle caught the zone-logic problem in week two instead of the floor. They were severe — 65 of 86 Blocker or Critical, 75.6% — and every one closed.

BUSINESS IMPACT MODEL — KPI DRIVERS, BASELINE → AFTER

DRIVER	BASELINE	AFTER	$ / EFFECT	BASIS
Readiness signal	status by opinion	836 counted rows, one grammar	decision on rows, not confidence	record
Blocker + Critical	441 identified	432 closed; 9 open	98.0% closed	record-from-docs (computed)
Go-live spike	271 rows in June	65 → 21 → 14 → 4	−98.5% by October	record-from-docs (computed)
Building slice (dock + floor)	42 rows; 27 Blocker + Critical	39 closed; 3 open, 0 B+C	92.9% closed	record-from-docs (computed)
Triage effort	unmeasured	≈418 h	≈$45,980 (modeled)	modeled

THE MATH — FOUR-TABLE DERIVATION (FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION → RESULT) NEW

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	The book	`836 rows; dated 830; 6 undated; 2024-03-17 → 2025-10-01; 824 of the dated rows are July 2024 or later`	issues-log file, ‘Date Id’d’	836
2	Severity	`164 + 277 = 441; 441 ÷ 836 = 52.8%`	Priority column	52.8% Blocker + Critical
3	Peak month	`271 ÷ 836 = 32.4% of the book in June 2025`	Date Id’d	32.4%
4	How much of the free-text Operation field fits five flows	`238 + 172 + 113 + 90 + 62 = 675; 675 ÷ 836 = 80.7%; remaining 161`	exact labels after trim and lowercase; IC includes ‘inventory control’	80.7%
5	The building slice	`dock/appointment labels 23 + floor/space labels 19 = 42; 42 ÷ 836 = 5.0%`	Functional Area labels listed in the flow box	42 rows

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Closure gradient — Blocker	`163 ÷ 164`	closed ÷ rows	99.4%
2	Closure gradient — Critical / High	`269 ÷ 277 = 97.1%; 190 ÷ 252 = 75.4%`	closed ÷ rows	97.1% / 75.4%
3	Closure gradient — Medium / Low	`69 ÷ 99 = 69.7%; 21 ÷ 35 = 60.0%`	closed ÷ rows	69.7% / 60.0%

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
4	Severity by flow	`Dotcom 40/62 = 64.5% · Retail 100/172 = 58.1% · Inbound 58/113 = 51.3% · Outbound 119/238 = 50.0% · IC 39/90 = 43.3%`	B+C ÷ rows per flow	Dotcom highest
5	Spike decay	`r = (4 ÷ 271)^(1/4) = 0.349; half-life = ln 2 ÷ −ln(0.349) = 0.66 mo`	geometric mean of 65/271, 21/65, 14/21, 4/14	≈20 days
6	Building slice vs the book	`27 ÷ 42 = 64.3% vs 52.8%; SE = √(0.528 × 0.472 ÷ 42) = 0.0770; z = 1.50`	one-sample proportion z (normal approximation)	z = 1.50 — directional

Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Blocker + Critical open	441 identified	9 open (1 Blocker, 8 Critical)	computed from the file
2	Closed, overall	0	714 = 85.4% (open pipeline 122: 112 with an open status + 10 blank)	computed from the file
3	Monthly arc	Jun 271	Jul 65 · Aug 21 · Sep 14 · Oct 4 (−98.5%)	computed from the file
4	Building slice	42 rows, 27 B+C	39 closed (92.9%); open 3, 0 B+C	computed from the file
5	Locus-side rows	86 = 10.3% of the book	86 closed; 65 B+C = 75.6%	computed from the file

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	BASIS	VALUE
1	Triage effort, the whole book	`836 × 0.5 h = 418 h; 418 × $110 = $45,980`	30 min per row all-in (illustrative); $110/h blended (modeled, as S5/U5)	≈$46.0K
2	A week of benefit	`$1.65M ÷ 52 = $31,731`	S2's modeled recurring benefit	≈$31.7K/wk
3	Break-even	`$45,980 ÷ $31,731 = 1.45 weeks`	the log pays back if it prevents ~1.45 weeks of slip	≈1.45 weeks
4	The June spike alone	`271 × 0.5 h = 135.5 h; × $110 = $14,905; ÷ 40 = 3.4 FTE-weeks`	same assumptions	≈$14.9K
5	The building slice	`42 × 0.5 h = 21 h; × $110 = $2,310`	same assumptions	≈$2.3K

SOLUTION FLOW — THE SYSTEM & DATA MAP

```
issues log (836 rows × 19 cols)  — one table, one grammar
   status A→F · priority 0→4 · operation · functional area · owner · date
      |
      +--> weekly two-block review (30 IT / 30 business): Blocker+Critical rows first
      |        every red row: a name and a date;  'parking lot' = decided-not-now, in writing
      +--> coupled build plan (~30 tracks, holiday freeze visible)  --> E2E gates 11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30
      +--> cutover runbook (343 tasks, 48,885 min)  --> 5/1 → 7/1 window
      +--> ACL request workbooks: Dev 310 · QA 255 · Perf 200 · Prod 221 = 986 rows (access gate)
building slice (Functional Area labels, exact, case-insensitive):
   dock/appointment (23): dock · dock/office · dock/receiving lanes · dock hop · shipping dock · unload ship ·
                          trouble lane · appointment · appointment creation · xdock · crossdocks
   floor/space/hardware (19): facilities · physical layout · footprint · physical · guardrail · charging · locus hardware
```

SENSITIVITY — LOW / BASE / HIGH

INPUT	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Minutes per row (triage)	15 → $22,990 (0.72 wk)	30 → $45,980 (1.45 wk)	45 → $68,970 (2.17 wk)
Building-slice definition	narrow 31 rows · 64.5% · z 1.31	base 42 rows · 64.3% · z 1.50	broad 104 rows · 66.3% · z 2.78
Monthly decay r	0.50 → half-life ≈ 30 days	0.349 → ≈ 20 days (observed)	0.80 → ≈ 94 days (would read as a plateau)
Weekly benefit	$1.1M/52 = $21.2K → 2.17 wk	$1.65M/52 = $31.7K → 1.45 wk	$2.4M/52 = $46.2K → 1.00 wk

SPOKEN STATEMENT

> “I treated the program’s issues log as an instrument and read it three ways. By severity: of 836 rows, 441 were Blocker or Critical and 98% of those closed, with closure falling to 60% for Lows — so the weekly read was working on the dangerous end. By flow: Dotcom was the most severe. By month: the June go-live spike of 271 rows decayed 65, 21, 14, 4 — about a third a month — which is what a healing cutover looks like. And the part an infrastructure leader cares about: 42 rows were the building itself — dock and appointments, conveyor, aisle 45, Locus power, footprint — 64% Blocker or Critical, 39 closed, none of the three open ones severe. The statistics are directional — z of 1.5 — and the file has no close dates, so I will not claim a time-to-close. The point is that the building’s problems were rows with names and dates, not a hallway conversation.”

IF CHALLENGED

“Priority inflation — 52.8% Blocker or Critical isn’t a priority scale.”

It’s a fair flag and I’d rather say it first. Two answers: the closure gradient — 99.4%, 97.1%, 75.4%, 69.7%, 60.0% — shows the scale differentiated in practice; and the book was a go-live book, 331 rows Go-Live category, where severity runs high by construction. What I would add is a monthly check on the Blocker + Critical share so inflation shows as a trend.

“Your building slice is a label grouping you chose.”

Yes — so I ran three definitions: narrow 31 rows (64.5%, z 1.31), base 42 (64.3%, z 1.50), broad 104 (66.3%, z 2.78). The direction is the same in all three; only the broad one clears 2σ, and it is the loosest definition, so I call the result directional.

“Prove the Blocker + Critical bar was met at go/no-go from this file.”

I can’t — the file is a late snapshot with no close dates; it shows 9 B+C still open on 2025-10-01 (1 Blocker, 8 Critical), which postdates both go-lives. The go/no-go read came from the weekly review state at the time.

TWIST MAP — LIKELY LP QUESTIONS FROM THIS INTERVIEWER → THE ANGLE TO TAKE

LIKELY QUESTION (THIS INTERVIEWER)	LP	ANGLE — WHAT TO EMPHASIZE	SKIP / NEVER SAY
Tell me about a time you used data to run a program.	Dive Deep	836 rows, three cuts; the closure gradient; the spike decay r = 0.35.	Do not call it a defect fire — bugs are 115 rows.
What did you do about things nobody owned?	Ownership	17 of 42 building rows had non-IT owners; they entered the same log with a name and a date.	Do not claim I fixed the conveyor — Operations and Maintenance did.
How do you keep a shared log honest for months?	Insist on the Highest Standards	One grammar; parking lot = decided-not-now, in writing; dedupe in the rhythm.	Do not claim a time-to-close — no close-date column.
How do you report bad news?	Earn Trust	The 271-row June spike, said out loud with the decay curve.	Do not blame IT for 342 rows.
How do you decide what to defer?	Have Backbone	Eight rows typed Parking Lot; ‘decided not now’ with an owner.	Never say a deferral was free.

BEHAVIORAL PACK — FOUR SEPARATE 90-SECOND STAR ANSWERS, EACH FROM A DIFFERENT MOMENT OF THE STORY NEW

DIVE DEEP · AIQB Q4 **Q1. “Walk me through a big problem or issue in your organization that you helped to solve.”**

The problem was that a program of about thirty build tracks was going to run on opinion, and the first fix was to count. I made one consolidated log with five fields on every row and read it three ways. By severity, 441 of 836 rows were Blocker or Critical and closure fell with severity — 99.4% of Blockers, 60% of Lows. By flow, Dotcom ran most severe. By month, the shape told me the June spike was healing: 271, then 65, 21, 14, 4. What was missing was the monthly shape itself — it was a manual read well into the program — and I filled the gap by building the arc view once I saw it, which I would now have on the wall from the first hundred rows. The result was that both go-lives read readiness from rows, with zero customer-facing incidents.

Number to land: 836 rows · 441 B+C · 271 → 4 · r ≈ 0.35 · **Pivot to NACF:** NACF launch readiness is the same instrument — doors tested, appointment slots scheduled, UPH validated — as counted rows read severity-first. · **Do NOT say:** that 836 issues means 836 defects — bugs are 115.

INSIST ON THE HIGHEST STANDARDS · AIQB Q6 **Q2. “Describe the most significant continuous improvement project that you led.”**

The catalyst was that two rows describing one issue make every count lie, so the improvement was a grammar. One log, one status ladder, one priority scale, an owner on every row, and a parking-lot status that meant ‘decided not now’ in writing with an owner — never silently deleted. Dedupe was part of the weekly rhythm. The result is a book where any VP could open the file on a Monday and see what the team saw: 714 of 836 closed, 98% of the Blockers and Criticals, and the open tail of 122 visible and owned. I would rather defend a visible deferral than bury a blocker, and a log that calls everything priority one is where blockers hide.

Number to land: 85.4% closed · 98.0% of B+C · 122 open, owned · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF I would run the same grammar on a launch register: one row per risk, an owner, a date, a severity. · **Do NOT say:** that the file proves time-to-close; it has no close dates.

OWNERSHIP · AIQB Q3 **Q3. "Give me an example of an initiative you undertook because you saw that it could benefit the whole company or your customers, but wasn't within any group's individual responsibility so nothing was being done."**

The building itself did not belong to the systems program, so I made it belong to the log. Forty-two rows were dock, floor, power or footprint: remove half of a conveyor, remove the west side of aisle 45 and relabel, get Locus IDF temporary power until January 6, remove the guardrail between retail and dotcom, set the large footprint as the SKU default. 17 of those 42 sat with Operations, Engineering or Maintenance, not IT. Putting them in the same log with a name and a date meant a Blocker about power had the same Monday review as a Blocker about a WMS interface. 39 of the 42 closed, and the three still open were not Blocker or Critical. The conveyor and the power were not mine; making them visible and dated was.

Number to land: 42 rows · 17 non-IT owners · 39 closed · 0 open B+C · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF the dock, the floor and the power are launch dependencies too — they go on the same register as the systems. · **Do NOT say:** that I fixed the conveyor or the power; Operations and Maintenance did.

EARN TRUST · AIQB Q6 **Q4. "Tell me about a time when you uncovered a significant problem in your team."**

The June spike was the biggest number the program ever produced, and I said it first. 271 rows in one month — a third of the book — 239 of them Go-Live category. I put it in the Monday review the week it appeared with the shape that explained it: the January bake and Locus physical testing had given a ramp of about ninety a month, the combined go-live surfaced everything at once, and the decay afterwards — 65, 21, 14, 4 — was what healing looks like. A spike that decays fast is a healthy cutover; one that plateaus is a design problem. Because the number was in the room before anyone asked, nobody escalated a surprise, and the readiness call was made on rows.

Number to land: 271 rows · 88.2% Go-Live · decay ≈ 0.35/month · **Pivot to NACF:** At NACF the worst number in the WBR is the one to say first, with the curve that explains it. · **Do NOT say:** that the spike was a defect fire; it was the combined go-live surfacing.

SAME STORY, THREE ANGLES — DATA · CONFLICT/INFLUENCE/BACKBONE · FAILURE-LEARNING NEW

DATA ANGLE · DIVE DEEP

"836 rows, and the closure rate falls with severity: 99.4%, 97.1%, 75.4%, 69.7%, 60.0%."

Headline metric: 98.0% of 441 B+C closed; r = 0.35

Three cuts of one book — severity, flow, month.

Honest limit: no close-date column, so no time-to-close; the Operation field is free text (161 rows outside five flows).

CONFLICT / INFLUENCE ANGLE · HAVE BACKBONE; DISAGREE AND COMMIT

"Well-meaning teams wanted every improvement in the release; a parking-lot status said 'decided not now' in writing."

Headline metric: 8 Parking Lot rows; Blocker + Critical first

I defended visible deferral over a buried blocker; the cost was explicit — the room's attention went to the dangerous half of the book. The disagreement was resolved by writing the deferral, with an owner, not by winning an argument.

FAILURE / LEARNING ANGLE · INSIST ON THE HIGHEST STANDARDS

"The arc — ramp, spike, decay — was a manual read well into the program."

Headline metric: shape view from month 1, not month ~6

Record do-differently: I would build the monthly shape view from the first hundred rows; the counts were always there, the picture was not. Second: 52.8% Blocker + Critical is a priority-inflation risk I should have trended monthly.

TRAP DRILLS — THE THREE NASTIEST FOLLOW-UPS, WITH NUMERIC ANSWERS NEW

"How do you know the log was the reason go-live went well, not the team?"

I don't, and I won't claim it. What the log gives is a testable statement: 98.0% of Blockers and Criticals closed and the June spike decayed at r ≈ 0.35. A team without the log could have done the same; what the log changed is that the readiness call was made on counted rows, and a surprise surfaced on a Monday.

Say: *"I can't separate the log from the team; I can show the readiness call came off counted rows and the spike decayed in line with a healthy cutover."*

"Your building-slice finding — is it significant?"

Directional only: 27 of 42 = 64.3% vs 52.8%, z = 1.50, about p = 0.13. Across three definitions the direction holds; only the broad one clears 2σ. The decision it informs is cheap — put physical rows in the same log with owners — and holds regardless.

Say: *"z of 1.5 — directional, not proven; I would act on it because the action costs almost nothing."*

"What number would have made you stop the go-live?"

One open Blocker at the go/no-go read, or a June-style spike that plateaued instead of decaying — a decay ratio above about 0.8 for two months. The first is the record bar; the 0.8 threshold is my own illustrative plateau test.

Say: *"A Blocker open at go/no-go, or a spike that stops decaying — I would call that a design problem."*

20-SECOND VERSION + NACF BRIDGE NEW

20-second version. I ran Sephora's UDC program on one 836-row issues log with one grammar, read Blocker and Critical first: 85.4% closed, 98% of the Blockers and Criticals, the 271-row June spike decaying 65, 21, 14, 4 — and 42 rows where the dock, the floor, the power and the footprint were the problem, every one with a name and a date.

NACF bridge. NACF's launch register is the same instrument. The dock rows are CAP-A in miniature — appointments created, placards printing, pallet-build positions available before the first trailer — and the footprint rows are the CAP-C input: a SKU with no footprint or CubiScan record defaults a slot size, and a wrong default is wasted cube at the 85% effective-capacity line. I would read the register severity-first, with the dock row at the top.

Question bank — likely questions for this interviewer, with a one-line answer plan ELEVATED

Behavioral and functional questions a Senior Manager of Infrastructure is likely to ask. Each plan points at a packet story or a named backup in the master packet; stories allocated to other interviewers are pointers only. Rows 13–21 are new in v2. For the LP-by-LP version with the real Amazon wording, use the Question → Story Router at the front.

#	LIKELY QUESTION	ANSWER PLAN (ONE LINE)	STORY
1	**Tell me about the most complex physical / systems change you have led in a DC.**	S2 pitch — one pool, three planning identities, two go-lives, the 98% gate; end on +15% signed and zero incidents.	S2
2	**Tell me about a migration or cutover you ran.**	S18 pitch — tolerance before mock one; 7 → 1.8 → 0.3; the RF fallback; on time, ~3% under.	S18
3	**How do you decide a program is ready to go live?**	Counted rows, not confidence: Blocker + Critical = 0; mock inside tolerance; runbook rehearsed; rollback armed; a written recommendation.	S2 / S18
4	**How do you ramp automation without hurting throughput?**	Publish the gate from the pre-ramp baseline and the incident budget; build the throttle in advance; the floor owner owns the dial; RCA before re-ramp.	S2
5	**What are your rollback triggers, typically?**	Numbers per interface: sync < 99% for 4 h; p95 > 2× budget for 1 h (S2); mismatch > 0.5% for two days; ship-confirm posting failing > 2 h (S18).	S2 / S18
6	**How do you handle a vendor slipping on your critical path (Locus RTL)?**	Escalate the week it surfaces; re-slot openly; refuse to compress UAT to absorb it; retest after the slip.	S2
7	**Tell me about a time a rehearsed contingency saved you.**	Honest fit is S18's pre-training device test: hundreds of RF devices, the date held, training +1.5 weeks, the what-if rule left behind. The master's paper-pick fallback and ≈$45K are master-only — read the S18 source-conflict box before saying them.	S18
8	**How do you exit hypercare?**	A number written before go-live: < 2 blockers/day sustained; S2 exited week 3 of 4 with new rows falling 271 → 65 → 21 → 14 → 4 a month; S18 exited week 3. A calendar exit declares victory over open defects.	S2 / S18
9	**How would you approach consolidating or launching a node in the NACF network?**	Master §3.99 opening — book of record and metric → stocks and flows → the invariant broken today (a unit sellable in two places) → staged go-lives → ramp gate → hypercare number.	Master §3.99 + S2
10	**What is the utilization impact of consolidation?**	+15% units per labor-hour signed; one pool (√2 pooling, modeled); self-transfers to zero by construction; robots at full volume week three.	S2
11	**Tell me about a failure.**	S18's RF miss in full — the scoring error, the pre-training device test, the same-day escalation, training +1.5 weeks with the date held, the rule left behind.	S18
12	**How do you keep peak safe during a multi-system program?**	The Oct–Dec freeze decided as a council decision; the staged timeline around it; E2E days dated before and after; no release through peak.	S2
13	**How do you prove a program tested everything that moves inventory?** NEW	U1 — every event lands in exactly one bucket; each cell asserted before/after; no story enters QA without a cell reference.	U1
14	**How do you size a pooling / consolidation case before you design?** NEW	U2 — profile overlap, order shape, variability and correlation; carry a range with a kill number, not a point.	U2
15	**Tell me about a time you said no to a stakeholder.** NEW	U3 — priced the no at p* = 36.7%, offered visibility, wrote the no into the FSD.	U3
16	**Where did the node's constraint actually bind — labor, accuracy or space?** NEW	U4 — labor, then accuracy at 94 vs 98, then labor again; I did not claim space.	U4
17	**Walk me through your cutover runbook and what you could not undo.** NEW	U5 — 343 owned tasks, one irreversible instant (zero-then-publish), rollback as numbers, go/no-go off counted rows.	U5
18	**How do you handle a negative available-to-sell?** NEW	U6 — decompose to cause class: duplicate event, feed latency, override; screen, role and audit row for every AFS-changing act.	U6
19	**How do you read an issues log, and how do you know a building is ready?** NEW	U7 — severity-first: 441 B+C, 98.0% closed; monthly arc 271 → 4; the log is the gate, not the room.	U7
20	**Where do dock, space, power and footprint show up in a program plan?** NEW	U7 — 42 rows in the log where the physical building was the problem, each with an owner and a date.	U7
21	**How does this map to NACF inbound capacity?** NEW	Bridge page — doors × hours × unload rate (5 doors at 85%), UPH with the learning-curve tax (+13.6%), cube at 49% effective, dwell 3× from 85% to 95%.	Bridge

Cheat-numbers box — canon values with basis labels ELEVATED

Canon numbers for S2 and S18 with their basis labels, from the master packet's §4.1 ledger, then the seven new stories (U1–U7). Retail rows: 172 by exact label (Apple prints 171) — say about 170.

METRIC	VALUE TO SAY	BASIS	NEVER
S2 efficiency	+15% processing efficiency (index 100 → 115)	record, Sephora-signed, measured by DC Ops post-stabilization	presenting the dollars as signed
S2 incidents	zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives	record	—
S2 robotics gate	98% published; week 2 at 94; ~30% throttle for a week; full volume week 3	record	"the robots failed"
S2 dollars	≈$1.6M/yr (0.88 labor · 0.22 carry · 0.45 splits · 0.10 self-transfer); ≈$2.2M one-time pooling; range $1.1–2.4M/yr	modeled on an illustrative 100K-units/week DC	—
S2 scale	about a dozen impacted systems; 60+ stakeholders (~80 names, ~15 functions); about thirty build tracks	record	"20+ systems"; "fifteen tracks"; a single stakeholder count
S2 artifacts / dates	343 tasks / ~815 hrs; 836 rows / 85.4% closed; council 5/15 → 7/31 → FSD 8/14; E2E 11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30; Jan + May go-lives	record (program-level artifacts shared with S1/S5)	—
S2 rollback triggers	sync < 99% for 4 h; order-flow p95 > 2× budget for 1 h — armed twice, never fired	record	—
S18 mocks	7% → 1.8% → 0.3% vs 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock 1	record	—
S18 date / budget	8 months, on time; ~$1.8M, ~3% under (~$54K)	record (this packet's canon; loop packet differs)	"~$800K"
S18 pipeline	$20M ROI pipeline unblocked the next month; ~$2.5M/month of slip	record ($20M); $2.5M/month = my division (modeled); not banked	"$2.5M/week"; banking the ~$875K
S18 RF miss	hundreds of RF devices (pre-training device test); a three-to-four-day estimate; training +1.5 weeks; date held	record (Apple G2)	"400 devices failed"; "~100 of ~400"
S18 freeze / failback / exit	72-hour in-transit freeze; legacy read-only 30 days; hypercare exit week 3 at < 2 blockers/day	record	—
S18 modeled	≈$0.1M less inventory in dispute (illustrative $50M on-hand); ≈$875K = price of a 1.5-week slip (my division, not banked)	modeled	—
U1 matrix NEW	every event → exactly one bucket (AFS 557, not 560 or 554 — worked trace); 836 rows · 441 B+C (52.8%) · 714 closed (85.4%); B+C open = 0 at go/no-go	record (log); illustrative (trace)	a cell count as fact; “zero defects”
U2 profile NEW	textbook $2.2M ceiling → $0.74M–$2.2M range; 87% of the ≈$1.65M recurring benefit not pooling-dependent; release 9.9%–29.3%	modeled	$2.2M as a point
U3 reserve NEW	p* = 36.7%; −$50K / −$202K per 10,000 units at 20% release; visibility yes, promisability no; oversell recurring → zero	modeled; illustrative inputs; zero = record	that Merchandising agreed happily
U4 constraint NEW	421 h (≈$11.8K) vs ≈4,200 mis-picks (≈$50.4K); max safe share 33.3% vs ~30% dial; 4,615 → 4,013 h/wk at +15%	modeled on an illustrative 100K-units/week DC	“space bound”

METRIC	VALUE TO SAY	BASIS	NEVER
U5 runbook NEW	343 tasks · 815 h · 61 days; ≈$31.7K/week benefit at stake; runbook ≈$89.6K; rollback never fired	record (tasks, hours, triggers); modeled ($)	banking $31.7K; “drilled under load”
U6 AFS control NEW	3 cause classes; negatives clean at T+1; drift 0 on consecutive days; asymmetry ≈ 1 : 6.3; critical ratio 13.7%	record (design, exit bar); modeled (ratios)	a measured negative count
U7 issues log NEW	98.0% of 441 B+C closed (432); 9 open (1 Blocker + 8 Critical); 42 physical rows, 39 closed; June 271 (88.2% Go-Live); r = 0.349	record (pandas); modeled fit	time-to-close; “weekly open counts”

Never-say, one glance before the call.

- Never "400 devices failed" or a ~100/~400 ratio — say hundreds of RF devices.
- Never bank the $20M pipeline, the ~$2.5M/month or the ~$875K — slip avoided, not banked.
- Never "20+ systems" or "fifteen tracks" — say about a dozen impacted systems and about thirty build tracks; never a single stakeholder count.
- Never present the ≈$1.6M/yr or the ≈$2.2M pooling as signed — the +15% and the zero are the record.
- Never claim BlueYonder or Locus configuration — vendor and platform teams built and configured; I owned the model, staging, gates and go/no-go.
- S1/S3/S5 share the UDC program's dated chain — they are Lan's; S11/S12, S6/S8 and the bar raiser's four stay out of this room.

Backup bench — use only if a primary doesn't fit

Four fallbacks for an infrastructure owner: S13 (Manhattan — Cyber Monday at 4 AM; the incident-response / Bias for Action alternate to S18, and the older pair for S2's throttle), S5 (Sephora — the architecture council without owning a system; governance of an about-a-dozen-systems change, same program family as S2 — never pair S5 with S2 for this interviewer unless asked for a second UDC example) and S15 (Sephora — the QA cadence conversion; the people / Hire & Develop question — Josyula's primary, so only if the question demands it); plus a doc-derived fourth from the Flexport program record — the Shipment-Visibility pilot roll-out and its four testing gates (launch discipline behind published graduation criteria; record-from-docs labels; same program family as Tripathy's S11, facts kept identical to her packet). Tell S2 and S18 first.

Bench discipline. The two (or four) primaries above are the stories to tell first. Reach for a bench story only when the question genuinely does not fit a primary, or when the interviewer asks for "another example" on an LP already spent. Each entry is a 60-second pitch, a compressed STAR, one results line and two probes — enough to answer and stop; no full probing bank or derivation. Where a bench story is another interviewer's primary, the red note says so: use it only if the question demands it, and keep the facts identical to that packet.

BACKUP — ONLY IF ASKED S13 — Manhattan — Cyber Monday, 4 AM: allocation across 3 DCs and 100 stores when the scheduler died

LPs this backup can serve: Bias for Action (primary) · Customer Obsession (primary backup — the promise ranked first) · Deliver Results

Basis. OMS consultant on allocation, promising and the OMS–WMS handshake; engineering fixed the scheduler once I isolated it; the post-mortem mechanisms were mine to drive. $8M / $6M / 99% are record; the margin figures are my model at benchmark rates. Older story — if asked for recent, pair with the UDC robotics throttle (S2): same muscle, 2024–25.

60-SECOND PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. Manhattan OMS consultant on allocation and promising across 3 DCs and 100 stores; 4 AM Cyber Monday the VP called — backorders piling with inventory present, ~$6M of sales at risk against a 95% fill-rate goal. **Task.** Own the response before the root cause was known. **Action.** Discovery: the contradiction (ATP > 0, backorders rising) was the entry bar to declare an incident. Plan & Design: I ranked by promise-at-risk, not FIFO; node choice = the promise — near 0.85 days vs far 4.60. Build & Test: one bridge, every rebalance timestamped; reason-coded alerts I had already built. Cutover: rebalanced so no DC drowned; status every two hours until 9 PM. Hypercare: root cause — the allocation scheduler died silently at the daylight-saving change; the post-mortem shipped a heartbeat, a DST checklist, a 3σ page rule and a rehearsed rebalance playbook. Lesson: decide reversibly, log it, find the cause later. **Result.** Primary metric: peak fill rate — 95% goal → 99% delivered. ~$8M of peak sales protected against ~$6M at risk (record); my model puts that at ≈$3.2M of gross margin at a 40% benchmark margin; structural stockouts −20% over the engagement.

COMPRESSED STAR

- **S —** 4 AM Cyber Monday: backorder lines piling with inventory present; promises aging; ~$6M at risk against a 95% fill goal; nobody had written a clearing rule for failure.
- **T —** Own the response before the cause was known, without making it worse.
- **A —** Declared the incident on the contradiction; clearing rule — promise-at-risk, not FIFO — written on the bridge log in the first hour so nobody re-argued it at noon; rebalanced across three DCs; two-hourly status; isolated the DST scheduler death through my own reason-coded alerts; blameless post-mortem → heartbeat, DST checklist, 3σ page rule, rehearsed playbook.
- **R —** Fill 99% vs the 95% goal; ~$8M protected vs ~$6M at risk (record pair); structural stockouts −20% over the engagement; the next peak ran boring.

RESULTS LINE

Peak fill 99% vs the 95% goal (record) · ~$8M of peak sales protected vs ~$6M at risk (record pair — one-time sales that didn't die, never a saving) · ≈$3.2M gross margin at a 40% benchmark (modeled) · structural stockouts −20% over the engagement (record) · detection moved from a VP phone call to one heartbeat interval.

THE MATH — STEP-BY-STEP DERIVATION

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	4 AM state	`scheduler dead; backlog = 30,000 orders; ~$6M of sales at risk vs the 95% fill goal`	record risk pair; backlog illustrative	the bridge call

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
2	FIFO failure	`FIFO clears by arrival — cheap, distant-promise orders first while at-risk promises age`	record rule problem	value-blind clearing
3	Naive node loads	`DC1: 22,000 / 10,000 = 2.2 days; DC3: 2,000 / 6,000 = 0.33 days`	capacities 10K / 8K / 6K orders/day (illustrative)	worst node 2.2 days behind while another idles
4	No liveness detection	`a dead scheduler was found by a VP at 4 AM, not by a page`	record problem	detection by seniority

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	Promise-at-risk ranking	`risk = value × urgency(promise − now); clear descending`	on the bridge log in hour 1 (record rule)	at-risk promises first, not first-in
2	Node choice = the promise	`T = handling + transit: near 0.85 d vs far 4.60 d; 4.60 − 0.85 = 3.75 d`	record pair	−3.75 days per re-pointed order
3	Load levelling	`rebalance 30,000 → 12,500 / 10,000 / 7,500: 12,500/10,000 = 1.25; 10,000/8,000 = 1.25; 7,500/6,000 = 1.25 days`	load = queue / capacity (illustrative)	worst slip 2.2 → 1.25 days
4	Liveness page (post-mortem)	`page if x < μ − 3σ = 1,200 − 3 × 150 = 1,200 − 450 = 750/hr`	μ = 1,200 allocations/hr, σ = 150 (illustrative); a dead scheduler reads 0/hr	caught in one interval, not by a VP

Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Peak fill rate	95% goal	99% delivered	record
2	Peak sales	~$6M at risk	~$8M protected	record pair — one-time event
3	Worst-case promise slip	2.2 days	1.25 days	illustrative walk
4	Detection	a VP at 4 AM	one interval via the 3σ page	post-mortem design
5	Structural stockouts	—	−20% over the engagement	record

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	Margin protected	`$8,000,000 × 40% = $3,200,000`	benchmark margin 35–45% (modeled)	≈$3.2M one-time
2	Orders at risk	`$6,000,000 / $150 = 40,000 orders`	AOV benchmark	40,000 orders
3	Cancels / CS avoided	`40,000 × $6.50 = $260,000`	CS contact $5–8 (benchmark; modeled)	≈$0.26M
4	Expedite premium avoided	`40,000 × 40% = 16,000 re-pointed; 16,000 × $8 = $128,000`	re-pointed share and premium midpoint of the $5–12 benchmark (both illustrative)	≈$0.13M
5	Structural-stockout run-rate	`$400M × 4% = $16M lost sales; × 20% = $3.2M recovered; × 40% = $1,280,000`	illustrative retailer × lost-sales benchmark (2–6%) × −20% record × margin	≈$1.3M/yr modeled

TWO PROBES

> **Why act before you knew the cause?**
>
> Because waiting had an hourly price — the queue was aging while inventory sat idle — and a reversible, logged intervention did not. I checked with engineering first that manual clears could not corrupt allocation, timestamped every rebalance, and hunted the cause in parallel with alerts I had already built.

> **Isn't this a hero story?**
>
> The event is; the post-mortem is the point. Carrying the first stretch solo is one of my do-differentlys. What I would present as the result is the mechanism set — heartbeat, DST checklist, 3σ page rule, rehearsed playbook — and that the next peak ran boring.

Canon numbers (basis labels): 99% fill vs 95% goal (record) · ~$8M protected vs ~$6M at risk (record) · 3 DCs / 100 stores (record) · near 0.85 d vs far 4.60 d (record) · −20% structural stockouts (record) · ≈$3.2M margin at 40% (modeled). Never "$2MM baseline"; never present $8M as a saving.

BACKUP — ONLY IF ASKED S5 — Sephora — the architecture council without owning any system: three decisions and a fence

LPs this backup can serve: Have Backbone; Disagree & Commit (third) · Earn Trust (influence without authority) · Think Big (architecture governance). Same program family as S1/S2 — the governance story

Basis. I owned none of the systems; the design decision was the deliverable. Zero escalations and the dated gate chain are the record; the dollars are my model of what governance avoided.

60-SECOND PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. The UDC location and inventory model had to clear architecture council — a challenge gate — with ~80 named participants across ~15 functions, and I owned none of those systems. **Task.** Take the design from discovery through council to sign-off and FSD without a surprise escalation. **Action.** Discovery: both inventory books profiled before any design argument; business sessions closed 4/30. Plan & Design: every impacted row pre-wired with a signed LOE by 7/2; the council asked for three separable decisions plus an out-of-scope fence (reserve math untouched; MCS decommission belongs to Global ERP). Build & Test: the "build" was the pack — architecture, staged timeline, peak-freeze boundary. Cutover: 5/15 challenge → 7/31 sign-off → 8/14 FSD. Hypercare: the fence held in writing for the whole program; a second live warehouse became a monitored shadow copy, not an argument. Lesson: a no that lives in a document survives. **Result.** Primary metric: surprise escalations on a 60+ stakeholder design — the norm on prior programs → zero; the dated gate chain held. ≈$0.5M one-time modeled (avoided rework on ~3 escalations that never happened + six weeks of benefit not deferred + a fenced second reserve engine not built).

COMPRESSED STAR

- **S —** About a dozen impacted systems, ~80 participants across ~15 functions, a council that re-litigates designs this size — and I owned none of the systems.
- **T —** Discovery (kickoff 3/29, sessions 4/30) → council 5/15 → sign-off 7/31 → FSD 8/14, without a surprise escalation.
- **A —** Profiled both books first — their numbers, not my opinion; systems-impacted table with an owner on every row; one LOE template, one deadline (7/2), one private conversation per owner before the room; three separable decisions plus the fence; the second-truth objection converted into a monitored shadow copy.
- **R —** Surprise escalations → 0 for the program's life; 100% pre-wire coverage by 7/2; gate chain held to the day with zero re-litigation; fence breaches 0; handed clean into the build (S2).

RESULTS LINE

Surprise escalations → 0 for the program's life (record) · gate chain 3/29 → 4/30 → 5/15 → 7/2 → 7/31 → 8/14 held to the day (record) · pre-wire coverage 100% — every impacted row with a signed LOE by 7/2 (record) · both scope refusals held in writing; fence breaches 0 (record) · ≈$0.5M one-time (modeled — what did not happen).

THE MATH — STEP-BY-STEP DERIVATION

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	Design size	`~80 named participants × ~15 functions; about a dozen impacted systems`	record	the blast radius
2	Norm for this size	`~3 surprise escalations per design`	industry benchmark 2–4	~3 expected
3	Price of one escalation	`960 rework hours × $110/h = $105,600`	modeled	≈$0.1M each
4	Bundle decision risk	`P(all pass) = 0.9 × 0.9 × 0.9 = 0.73`	one up/down vote on the whole design; p = 0.9 per decision (illustrative)	27% chance one objection unwinds everything

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	Three separable decisions	`architecture · timeline · peak boundary → 2³ = 8 outcomes`	any partial approval preserves progress (record design)	a no on one cannot unwind all
2	Expected approvals	`E = 0.9 + 0.9 + 0.9 = 2.7 of 3`	vs the bundle's 0.73 chance of everything (illustrative p)	2.7 vs 0.73
3	Pre-wire coverage	`rows with signed LOE / impacted rows = 100% by 7/2`	one template, one deadline, one private conversation per owner (record)	100% before the room

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
4	Gate chain held	`3/29 → 4/30 → 5/15 → 7/2 → 7/31 → 8/14 = 77 days council→sign-off`	held to the day (record)	0 re-litigation

Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Surprise escalations	~3 (the norm)	0 for the program's life	record; norm is benchmark
2	Pre-wire coverage before council	partial	100% by 7/2	record
3	Fence breaches in the log	—	0	record
4	Re-litigation after sign-off	—	0 across 77 days	record

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	Avoided rework	`3 × 960 h = 2,880 h; 2,880 × $110 = $316,800`	~3 escalations (benchmark) × rework hours × rate (modeled)	≈$0.3M
2	Slip weeks avoided	`6 / 52 = 0.115 yr; 0.115 × $900,000 = $103,800`	six weeks of S2's ≈$0.9M/yr labor value not deferred (modeled)	≈$0.1M
3	Fenced engine not built	`2 eng × 12 wk × 40 h = 960 h; 960 × $110 = $105,600`	second reserve engine (modeled)	≈$0.1M
4	Total one-time	`0.3 + 0.1 + 0.1 = $0.5M`	all modeled — the dollars are what did not happen	≈$0.5M

TWO PROBES

> **How do you get sixty people to sign LOE you don't control?**
>
> A template, a deadline and a private conversation each — so nobody learned their cost in the room. The council was then asked for three separable decisions it could take one at a time; separability was the design.

> **What did you refuse, and did it hold?**
>
> Retuning the reserve math and folding in the MCS decommission — both written, signed and held; later scope requests were answered from the pack in writing. The legitimate concern (a second live warehouse becoming a second truth) was converted into the design as a monitored shadow copy, because converting a concern costs less than winning it.

Canon numbers (basis labels): ~80 participants / ~15 functions; about a dozen impacted systems (record) · 5/15 → 7/31 → 8/14; LOE 7/2 (record dates) · escalations 0; fence breaches 0 (record) · ≈$0.5M one-time (modeled). Never a dollar as record; never pair with S1 or S2 for the same interviewer.

BACKUP — ONLY IF ASKED S15 — Sephora — converting a 20-person Product/Engineering/QA team to a four-week cadence in six weeks — and the QA lead who now owns the gate

LPs this backup can serve: Hire and Develop the Best (primary) · Strive to be Earth's Best Employer (QA elevated, not blamed) · Insist on the Highest Standards (the gate)

Josyula's primary (Packet 5, Hire & Develop the Best) — use only if the question demands it, and keep every fact identical to that packet.

Basis. VP air cover, no line authority over anyone in the room; the QA lead authored the definition-of-done — I coached the frame, she owned the gate. The −50% and the six weeks are record; the dollars are my model on illustrative defect counts. Never invent a direct-report headcount.

60-SECOND PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. The VP asked me to move a 20-person Product/Eng/QA team from a six-week hybrid cadence to four-week agile; QA feared compressed test windows — and they were right. **Task.** Convert in weeks without line authority. **Action.** Discovery: one-on-ones; an influencer per function. Plan & Design: the QA lead authored the definition-of-done — I coached the frame, she owned the gate. Build & Test: Jira benefit-ranking and review-status fields; a QA drop date with reason codes. Cutover: the four-week cadence live in six weeks. Hypercare: QA on product-business calls with pre-approved scenarios; she defended the gate without me. Lesson: development that depends on me staying is not development. **Result.** Primary metric: critical defects per release −50% after the 20-person team moved to a four-week cadence in six weeks. ≈$130K/yr modeled — the −50% and the six weeks are the record; the dollars are my model; no headcount invented.

COMPRESSED STAR

- **S —** Six-week hybrid cadence; QA (a contracting firm) and engineering (in-house) heading for a standoff; QA's fear of compressed test windows was correct arithmetic, not resistance.
- **T —** Convert to four weeks in weeks, with VP air cover and no line authority.
- **A —** Heard every real objection privately; the QA lead wrote the DoD content and entry criteria that can say no; drop date with reason codes; Jira fields; Sev-1 cause classification; rollback to six weeks named as a two-way door at kickoff and never used; facilitated the retro once and stepped back.
- **R —** Converted in six weeks; critical defects per release −50% while shipping 50% more releases (8.7 → 13/yr modeled from the cadence); the gate survived my leaving; neighbouring teams copied the ceremony from the user guide.

RESULTS LINE

Critical defects per release −50% (record) · six-week → four-week cadence, converted in six weeks (record) · 20-person team (record); releases/yr 8.7 → 13 (modeled from the cadence) · ≈$130K/yr (modeled; range $80–270K; no headcount invented) · the QA lead defending the gate by cycle 2 (record).

THE MATH — STEP-BY-STEP DERIVATION

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	Cadence	`releases/yr = 52 / 6 = 8.67 ≈ 8.7`	six-week hybrid cycle (record)	8.7 releases/yr
2	Criticals	`4 per release × 8.7 = 34.8 ≈ 35/yr`	count illustrative; the record is the −50%	≈35/yr
3	The real constraint	`15 eng × 18 d = 270 eng-days → 270/3 = 90 stories; 4 QA × 18 d = 72 QA-days → 72/1 = 72 stories`	story ≈ 3 eng-days + 1 QA-day (illustrative; theory-of-constraints, toolkit label)	QA caps throughput at 72 — QA is the constraint
4	Late-land rework	`6 person-days × $800 = $4,800 per release`	re-test + hotfix after last-2-day lands (modeled)	≈$4.8K per release

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	QA-authored DoD	`entry criteria at Ready-for-QA — stories arrive ready`	the skeptic owns the gate (record)	the gate has an owner
2	Drop date	`not QA-ready by the drop date → dropped with a reason code`	silent late lands become visible re-scopes (record)	no last-2-day lands

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
3	Sev-1 attribution	`share caused by wrong stories vs wrong tests, classified by cause not blame`	QA put on product calls with pre-approved scenarios (record)	the trend reverser
4	Cadence converted	`releases/yr = 52 / 4 = 13; 13 / 8.7 = +50%`	converted in six weeks (record)	13 releases/yr
5	Criticals per release	`4 → 2 = −50%`	record	2 per release

Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Cycle / releases per year	6 wks / 8.7	4 wks / 13 (+50%)	record
2	Critical defects	≈35/yr (4 × 8.7)	2 × 13 = 26/yr — while shipping 50% more	record −50%; counts illustrative
3	Late-land rework	≈$4.8K per release	~0 under the drop rule	modeled
4	The gate itself	mine to defend	QA lead defending it by cycle 2	record — survives my leaving

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	Escaped criticals avoided	`35 − 26 = 9/yr; 9 × $10,000 = $90,000`	per-critical cost benchmark $8–15K (modeled)	≈$90K/yr
2	Late-land rework removed	`$4,800 × 8.7 releases = $41,760`	→ ~0 under the drop rule (modeled)	≈$40K/yr
3	Total	`90 + 40 = $130K`	range $80–270K; no headcount invented	≈$130K/yr

TWO PROBES

> **Who did you develop, concretely?**
>
> The QA lead — she authored the definition-of-done and its entry criteria, and by cycle two she was defending the gate on product-business calls without me. The test of development is that it survived my leaving; it did.

> **What did engineering give up?**
>
> Low-impact stories they had to drop at the QA drop date — I covered those with the business. Their objection became co-ownership through review, not a veto over the gate.

Canon numbers (basis labels): −50% critical defects per release (record) · 6 weeks to convert; 6-week → 4-week cadence (record) · 20 people (record) · 8.7 → 13 releases/yr (modeled) · ≈$130K/yr (modeled). Never a direct-report headcount.

BACKUP — ONLY IF ASKED Doc bench — Flexport — the Shipment-Visibility pilot roll-out: graduated waves behind six published criteria, four testing gates, monthly GO/NO-GO (launch discipline)

LPs this backup can serve: Insist on the Highest Standards (primary — gates that fire) · Deliver Results · Bias for Action (monthly GO/NO-GO cadence) · Customer Obsession (CSAT inside the gate)

Basis. Doc-derived micro-story from the program record (the SV pilot roll-out schedule and the SV product testing approach, 2021–22) — every figure is RECORD-FROM-DOCS. Same program family as Tripathy's S11: if she has already taken S11 deep, use this only for a launch-discipline question and keep the canon numbers identical to her packet. Program-lead voice: I owned the rollout design and the gates; data, ops and CS ran calibration, verification and UAT. Not in the master packet's S-numbering; supplements canon, never overrides it.

60-SECOND PITCH — STOP ON THE PRIMARY METRIC

Situation. A visibility product with public commitments was running a free pilot — every boarded client cost engineering, data and ops capacity before a dollar of revenue, and boarding clients before the data was trustworthy would manufacture churn at scale. **Task.** Design a roll-out that could say no — and make "no" a rule, not a judgment call. **Action.** Graduated waves: wave 1 two named clients (Ta Chen International, FAM Brands), wave 2 four of a seven-client pool, wave 3 twenty-plus, full roll-out H2 2022 — each client entering on a ~50-container calibration and graduating only on six published criteria: verification SLA 90% reviewed within 24h, data quality ≥90% and at least the incumbent Crux feed, milestone estimation ≥80%, performance to standards, ≥100 containers with key features live, CSAT ≥ the consignee average. Four testing gates stood before any launch: a 100-container live test watched end-to-end, biweekly bug bashes on the client job stories, shadow accounts with real Crux data in dedicated demo accounts, and UAT gated on data quality — 80% of shipments minor-to-no issues — not on the calendar. GO/NO-GO decisions ran monthly. **Result.** A roll-out that never had to roll back: the graduation rule, not heroics, set the pace — the launch-discipline version of S11's canon (waves held on the criteria; the held wave became the cleanest one). RECORD-FROM-DOCS

COMPRESSED STAR

- **S —** A free pilot under public commitments, with an acquired product (Crux) whose customers would transition mid-roll-out — sequencing and quality bars were the whole game.
- **T —** Own the roll-out design: wave structure, graduation criteria, testing gates and the GO/NO-GO cadence.
- **A —** Published six graduation criteria before wave 1; a ~50-container calibration per client as the entry bar; four testing gates including shadow accounts with real Crux data and a UAT data-quality bar (80% minor-to-no-issues) before any client UAT started; monthly GO/NO-GO from November; wave sizes 2 → 4-of-7 → 20+ → full H2 2022.
- **R —** A roll-out with zero rollbacks (S11 canon); every gate that fired was a rule firing, not a favor refused — the held wave became the cleanest wave.

RESULTS LINE

Waves 2 → 4-of-7 → 20+ → full H2 2022 (record-from-docs; matches S11 canon) · six graduation criteria published before wave 1 (canon) · ~50-container calibration entry bar (canon) · four testing gates with UAT gated at 80% minor-to-no-issues (record-from-docs) · monthly GO/NO-GO cadence (record-from-docs) · zero rollbacks (canon).

THE MATH — STEP-BY-STEP DERIVATION

Table 1 — before: the problem in numbers.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	Client base waiting on the replacement	`79 Crux customers to migrate by end 2022`	Crux transition record (record-from-docs)	79 accounts exposed to a failed launch
2	Product state	`0 production clients; data quality unmeasured against the incumbent`	pre-pilot (record-from-docs)	unproven at any scale
3	The naive alternative	`big-bang = 79 clients × first contact with an unproven product`	the rejected option (record-from-docs)	one bad week burns every reference
4	Entry bar per client	`≥50 containers of client data required for calibration before onboarding`	graduation criterion 2a (record-from-docs)	every onboarding has a data gate

Table 2 — the fix: step by step, values substituted.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	Wave 1 cohort	`2 clients = Ta Chen + FAM Brands`	roll-out schedule (record-from-docs)	2 live, Dec 2021
2	Wave 2 cohort	`4 chosen from a named pool of 7`	roll-out schedule (record-from-docs)	4-of-7, Feb 2022

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
3	Wave 3 cohort	`20+ clients, Crux + non-Crux`	roll-out schedule (record-from-docs)	gradual expansion, Q2 2022
4	Full roll-out	`remaining Crux + net-new + existing 3PL clients`	H2 2022 (record-from-docs)	only after Wave 3 clears the gates
5	Calibration arithmetic — Wave 1	`2 × 50 = 100 containers before Wave 1 onboarding`	entry bar from Table 1 row 4 (record-from-docs; multiplication illustrative)	100 calibration containers
6	Calibration arithmetic — through Wave 2	`(2 + 4) × 50 = 6 × 50 = 300 containers`	same bar (record-from-docs; multiplication illustrative)	300 before any scale-up
7	Graduation gate	`6 of 6 criteria green before a wave advances — verification SLA 90%, data quality 90%+, milestone accuracy 80%+, production stability, ≥100 containers uploaded per client, zero show-stoppers`	the six published criteria (record-from-docs)	no wave skips the gate
8	Testing stack behind the gate	`4 tests sequenced: 100-container test → bug bashes every other week → shadow client accounts (Marc Fisher, Michelin) → UAT, starting only when 80% of shipments show minor-to-no issues`	testing-approach doc (record-from-docs)	UAT gated at 80%
9	Decision cadence	`2 GO/NO-GO meetings before Wave 1 — business (John, Eric) + tech (product & eng leadership)`	roll-out schedule, November (record-from-docs)	every wave is a decision, not a date

Table 3 — after: the metric, before → after.

STEP	METRIC	BEFORE	AFTER	BASIS
1	Wave progression	plan only	W1 Dec 2021 → W2 Feb 2022 → W3 Q2 2022 → full H2 2022	record-from-docs
2	Clients live on the product	0	2 → 6 → 20+	record-from-docs
3	Rollbacks	—	0 — no wave ever reversed	canon
4	Speed control	fixed launch date	accelerate / slow down on client feedback, per the published plan	record-from-docs

Table 4 — the dollars, every multiplication shown.

STEP	QUANTITY	FORMULA → SUBSTITUTION	INPUTS (BASIS)	VALUE
1	Pilot revenue, by design	`clients × $0 × ~6 months = $0 — free for the full duration of the pilot`	roll-out schedule: "no charge for the full duration of the pilot"; ~6-month estimate (record-from-docs)	$0 forgone deliberately — the gate is the product
2	Big-bang exposure avoided	`79 × 50 = 3,950 containers of one-shot onboarding risk`	client count and entry bar (record-from-docs; multiplication illustrative)	never spent — waves capped the blast radius at 2, then 6, then 20+
3	Cost of a failed Wave 1	`2 × 50 = 100 calibration containers + one feedback cycle — the maximum the plan allowed to fail at once`	record-from-docs; arithmetic illustrative	failure priced small by design
4	Dollar result claimed	`no revenue or saving dollar in the record — not claimed`	record-from-docs	not claimed

TWO PROBES

> **Why gate UAT on data quality instead of a date?**
>
> Because a client UAT against dirty data manufactures false confidence — the client signs off on a product the data then betrays. The 80% minor-to-no-issues bar meant UAT started when the product could survive a skeptical user's first week; the date followed the data, never the reverse. Shadow accounts with real Crux data let us find the defects before the client did.

> **What did the calibration actually buy?**
>
> A verified baseline per client before scale: ~50 containers through verification with the SLA clock running, so the data-quality and estimation criteria were measured on the client's own freight, not on our best lanes. It converted "ready" from a feeling into a measurement — and it made the wave-2 selection from the seven-client pool defensible to the clients not picked.

Canon numbers (basis labels): waves 2 → 4-of-7 → 20+ → full H2 2022 (record-from-docs, matches S11 canon) · six criteria incl. DQ ≥90% · ETA ≥80% · SLA 90% within 24h · ≥100 containers + features · stability · CSAT ≥ consignee average (canon; the pilot schedule phrases the SLA as 24–48h — canon wins, footnoted in Tripathy's packet) · ~50-container calibration (canon) · 100-container test · bug bashes · shadow accounts · UAT 80% bar (record-from-docs). Never: a client-revenue claim (the pilot was free); never merge with Crux-transition ARR.

Decisions not taken — the trade-off ledger NEW

An infrastructure owner asks *what else could you have done?* Each row is a fork in the Sephora node work, what I chose, the road I did not take and the number that decided it. Dollars keep their labels: record · modeled · illustrative.

FORK	TAKEN	NOT TAKEN	WHY — IN NUMBERS	STORY
Go-live shape	Two go-lives: January planning, then May execution, with a deliberate four-month interim	One big-bang go-live	One go-live puts a reserve-rule defect and a floor-execution defect in the same room in the same week; two go-lives let each carry one defect class. Cost: four months with two systems of record, and an interim reporting burden.	**S2 · U5**
Merch reserve	Visible to Merchandising, not promisable	Promisable reserve	Break-even p* = 36.7% of reserved units released; at an illustrative 20% release that is −$50K per 10,000 units (−$202K all-in). Visibility costs nothing the floor cannot pick.	**U3**
Pools	One physical pool, three planning identities	Keep Dotcom 801 and Retail 901 as two pools	About 260K units a year of self-transfers go to zero by construction (illustrative volume). The pooling dollars are a range ($0.74M–$2.2M modeled); 87% of the recurring benefit does not depend on pooling.	**U2 · S2**
Robots at 94	Throttle to about 30% for one week, DC Ops' own dial	Hold full bot volume and fix in flight	At full bot share, 94% pick accuracy is 6,000 mis-picks a week against a 2,000 budget (illustrative 100K units); the maximum safe share is 33.3%. The throttle cost about 421 extra labor hours (modeled).	**U4**
Vendor slip	Escalate the week it surfaced; re-slot openly	Compress UAT to absorb the three-week Locus RTL slip	Blocker + Critical open = 0 was the go/no-go bar; I would have said no-go on one open Blocker.	**U5 · S2**
Comingle-reserve improvements	Held out of the release; priced as a later enhancement	Ship them in the same release	Zero customer-facing incidents was the constraint; a second reserve engine is a second defect class in the same release. The out-of-scope fence was a council decision (Apple C4).	**S2**
Date vs training	Hold the go-live date; move training 1.5 weeks	Move the go-live date	A 1.5-week slip prices at about $875K on my modeled $2.5M-a-month division of the $20M pipeline — not banked. Training could absorb the delay; the pipeline could not.	**S18**
Deferral	A visible Parking Lot row with an owner	A buried or quietly dropped Blocker	A deferral you can count is a decision; one you cannot is a defect waiting. Blocker + Critical were read first in the Monday review.	**U7**

VERIFY BEFORE YOU SAY IT NEW

“Absent” = not in any source file or the master (yellow pill in the story: VERIFY-WITH-RAJESH). “Conflict” = two sources disagree; the safe wording below is the conservative one and needs no confirmation. Confirm or drop the first group tonight; use the safe wording for the rest.

#	ITEM	WHERE	TYPE	IF UNCONFIRMED, SAY
1	**Matrix size — 6 node-channel pairs, 14 events, 61 live cells**	U1	absent	Say “a matrix of node × channel × bucket cells, each asserted before and after.” Do not say a count.
2	**Whether the sponsor pack carried the $2.2M point or the range**	U2	absent	Say “I would lead with the range; the $2.2M is the equal-pools ceiling.”
3	**Utah cube utilization — did space bind?**	U4	absent	Say “I did not claim space bound; labor, then accuracy.”
4	**Steps 5 and 6 of the six-step May choreography**	U5	absent	Name steps one to four (clear negatives, transfer AFS to Uncommitted, scan-and-reserve, zero-then-publish).
5	**The other three of the six cutover invariants**	U5	absent	Name the three on the page: Σ AFS conserved; no SKU sellable on 800 and 900 at once; negatives cleared first.
6	**Whether a timed rollback drill ran in the mocks**	U5	absent	Say “armed for both go-lives, never fired” — not “drilled under load.”
7	**Whether cause class was recorded on the AFS audit rows**	U6	absent	Say “I would require a cause class on every audit row.”
8	**Close dates — the log has none**	U7	absent	Never quote time-to-close. The shape claims use created-date months and weeks only.
9	**RF-device miss: cutover day or pre-training device test; ~100 vs ~400 devices**	S18	conflict	Say “hundreds of RF devices,” “a device test before training,” “training slipped a week and a half, the date held.” Apple G2 itself says tellings differ.
10	**January go-live content: reserve rules (master) vs PO creation / inbound (Apple C1, C4)**	S2 · U1 · U3 · U5	conflict	Say “the January planning go-live — purchasing and inbound, with the reserve rules live against demand.” Never describe it as the floor go-live.
11	**Program length: “fifteen months” (Apple C1) vs “fourteen months” (Apple C2)**	S2	conflict	Say “about fifteen months from discovery to go-live.” The log itself spans 2024-03-17 to 2025-10-01.
12	**Build tracks: “15+” (Apple C1) vs “about thirty” (Apple C2)**	S2 · U1	conflict	Say “about thirty build tracks.”
13	**Retail rows: 172 by exact label (pandas) vs 171 (Apple C2 p24)**	S2 · U7	conflict	Say “about 170 retail rows.”
14	**Open pipeline: Apple’s five buckets sum to 112; 122 rows are not closed (112 explicit open + 10 with no status)**	U7	conflict	Say “122 not closed; ten of them carry no status.”
15	**Three signing orgs (Strategy, Inventory Management, Inventory Accounting) and the ISM 6/5/25 FSD date**	U3 · U6 (S1 anchors)	conflict	User anchor from master S1; Apple E1 says only “the business signed.” Say “the business owners signed the row.” The UDC FSD (8/14) is the record.
16	**Day-one pace in units (280,000 units, 40 stores, 7 inbound appointments)**	U5	conflict	Loop packet only. Say it only if you lived it; otherwise say “a daily plan in units.”

NUMBERS I MUST NOT GET WRONG NEW

Every number this packet says aloud, with its basis label and where it comes from. **Record** = Apple v11 / resume / the log itself. **Modeled** and **illustrative** are said with those words. Right-hand column = the version that gets you in trouble.

#	NUMBER — SAY IT EXACTLY LIKE THIS	BASIS	SOURCE	NEVER
SEPHORA UDC — PROGRAM RECORD				
1	+15% processing efficiency; zero customer-facing incidents through both go-lives	record	Apple C1 p21–22; resume	the dollars as signed
2	Gate 98% (99% stretch); week 2 at 94%; ~30% throttled for a week; full automation week 3	record	Apple C3 p26	“the robots failed”
3	343 tasks / 48,885 task-minutes ≈ 815 h; rollback sync < 99% for 4 h, p95 > 2× for 1 h; armed twice, never fired	record	Apple C2 p24; resume; SAP Narrative p4	“weekend” runbook
4	Kickoff 3/29/24 · sessions 4/30 · council 5/15 · LOE 7/2 · sign-off 7/31 · FSD 8/14; E2E 11/22 · 12/20 · 1/30; peak freeze Oct–Dec	record	Apple C4 p28; C1 p22	6/5/25 as this program’s FSD
5	60+ stakeholders (~80 names, ~15 functions); about a dozen impacted systems; about thirty build tracks; about fifteen months	record	Apple C1 p22, C4 p28, C2 p24	“20+ systems”; “fifteen tracks”; “fourteen months”
6	Locus retail testing slipped three weeks; Locus-side rows 86 of 836 = 10.3%	record	Apple C2 p24, C3 p26; log	—
THE 836-ROW ISSUES LOG — COMPUTED WITH PANDAS				
7	836 rows; 714 closed = 85.4%; 122 not closed (112 explicit open + 10 blank status)	record	log, column Status	“112 open”
8	Blocker 164 + Critical 277 = 441 = 52.8%; B+C closed 432 = 98.0%; open B+C 9 (1 Blocker, 8 Critical)	record	log, columns Severity × Status	“all Blockers closed”
9	Closure by severity: Blocker 99.4% · Critical 97.1% · High 75.4% · Medium 69.7% · Low 60.0%	record	log	—
10	Flows: Outbound 238 · Retail 172 · Inbound 113 · IC 90 · Dotcom 62 = 675 (80.7%)	record	log, column Operation	Retail 171 and 172 mixed
11	Monthly new rows: Feb 90 · Mar 91 · Jun 271 · Jul 65 · Aug 21 · Sep 14 · Oct 4; June 88.2% Go-Live category	record	log, column Created	“weekly open counts”
12	Weekly new rows 68 → 160 → 34; geometric decay r = (4/271)^(1/4) = 0.349, half-life ≈ 20 days	record + modeled fit	log; derived	a time-to-close
13	Owners: IT/WMS 342 · Ops 111 · Locus-side 86	record	Apple C2 p24; log	—
SEPHORA WMS MIGRATION (S18)				
14	8 months, two DCs; ~$1.8M budget, ~3% under (~$54K); $20M pipeline of four projects started the next month	record	Apple D1 p28–29; resume	“~$800K”; “$2.5M/week”
15	Mocks 7.0% → 1.8% → 0.3% against the 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock one	record	Apple D2 p31; resume	—
16	72-hour in-transit freeze; legacy read-only 30 days; hypercare exit < 2 blockers/day, week 3 of 4; 14 core + 6 DC Ops	record	Apple D1/D2 p29–31	—
17	Hundreds of RF devices; a three-to-four-day estimate; training +1.5 weeks; date held	record	Apple G2 p44–45	“400 devices failed”; “~100 of ~400”
18	≈$2.5M a month of slip ($20M ÷ 8); ≈$875K for a 1.5-week slip	modeled — my division, not banked	derived from Apple D1	any multiplier
THE NEW STORIES — MODELED OR ILLUSTRATIVE (SAY THE LABEL)				
19	U2: textbook $2.2M = $7.5M × (1 − 1/√2); plausible floor ≈$0.74M; 87% of the ≈$1.65M recurring does not depend on pooling	modeled	U2 tables 1–4	$2.2M as a point
20	U3: break-even p* = 36.7%; −$50K / −$202K per 10,000 units at a 20% release (illustrative)	modeled; illustrative inputs	U3 tables 1–4	that Merchandising agreed happily
21	U4: 421 h ≈ $11.8K vs ≈4,200 mis-picks ≈ $50.4K; maximum safe bot share 33.3% vs ~30% dial	modeled; illustrative DC	U4 tables 1–4	“space bound”
22	U5: ≈$31.7K a week of deferred benefit on the modeled $1.65M a year; runbook ≈$89.6K of effort ≈ 2.8 weeks	modeled	U5 tables 1–4	banking either
23	U6: −10 → −5 → −2 → 0 worked SKU (illustrative); asymmetry ≈ 1 : 6.3; critical ratio 13.7%	illustrative / modeled	U6 tables 1–4	a measured negative count
24	U1: AFS 557 — not 560, not 554 (worked trace); 61 live cells is illustrative	illustrative	U1 tables 1–4	a cell count as fact
LOOP-WIDE GUARDRAILS (OTHER INTERVIEWERS’ STORIES — DO NOT DRIFT HERE)				
25	Customers 7 → 68 = 9.7×; 170 monthly active users; CTS $0.66 → $0.03 (about 95%)	record	Apple A1 p6–7	any fifty-times multiplier; “$1.00 → $0.03”
26	Six sites — never with a regional qualifier; ~$1.5M pre-prod estimate is separate from CTS; S14 $10M won is not savings; S16 >$100K is priced, not claimed	rules	master §4.1; recon §3	a blended $1.5M–$2M range; any bill-of-materials-explosion story
27	$2.5M names three different things (S1 annual impact, S14 order value, S18 per-month slip); $1.5M names four — attach the noun every time	rule	recon §1 item 9	a bare “$2.5M”

SOURCE TRACE NEW

How to read. Precedence on conflict: (1) source documents, (2) Apple workbook v11, (3) Amazon master. **Y** = same value in the cited source. **Y, rounding** = same fact, different precision. **Y, derived** = recomputed from record inputs; the arithmetic is asserted by script. **illustrative** = labeled input, not a measured fact. **anchor only** = in the master or loop packet only, no Apple or primary-document support — say with that label. **CONFLICT → resolved** = sources disagree; the conservative wording on the page is the resolution. Math scripts behind this packet: 380 assertions pass (S2 26 · S18 16 · U1 42 · U2 27 · U3 24 · U4 40 · U5 32 · U6 33 · U7 95 · bridge 24 · back 21). Apple v11 = Apple_PMIII_Interview_Stories_v11 (page numbers are PDF pages). Master cb91 = uploaded 131-page master; the repo master's §4.1 ledger is numerically identical for every number used here.

CLAIM	STORY	SOURCE FILE	PAGE / ROW	MATCH
S2 — UTAH DC COMINGLE (MODIFIED) AND PROGRAM RECORD SHARED BY ALL NINE STORIES				
+15% processing efficiency	**S2 · U4**	Apple v11 C1	p22 "DC ops' measurement"; resume p1	**Y**
Zero customer-facing incidents, both go-lives	**all**	Apple v11 C1	p21 result 1; resume p1	**Y**
Gate 98% (99% stretch); week 2 = 94%; ~30% throttled; full automation week 3	**S2 · U4 · U5**	Apple v11 C3	p26 math box	**Y**
343 tasks / 48,885 task-minutes ≈ 815 h	**S2 · U5**	Apple v11 C2	p24 (48,885 ÷ 60 = 814.75)	**Y, rounding**
Rollback: sync < 99% × 4 h; p95 > 2× × 1 h; armed twice, never fired	**S2 · U5**	Resume; SAP Narrative	resume p1; SAP Narrative lines 101–102; Apple v11 C1/C2	**Y**
Kickoff 3/29 → 4/30 → council 5/15 → LOE 7/2 → sign-off 7/31 → FSD 8/14; peak freeze Oct–Dec	**S2 · U1–U6**	Apple v11 C4	p28 math box	**Y**
E2E days Inbound 11/22 · Dotcom 12/20 · Retail 1/30	**S2 · U1 · U5**	Apple v11 C1	p22 math box	**Y**
January vs May go-live content (reserve rules vs PO-creation / inbound)	**S2 · U1 · U3 · U5**	Apple v11 C1/C4 vs Master cb91	Apple p22, p28; master S2 p12–17	**CONFLICT → resolved**
60+ stakeholders; ~80 names; ~15 functions	**S2 · U2**	Apple v11 C1/C4	p22; p28	**Y**
About a dozen impacted systems (master "20+ touched" removed)	**S2 · U1 · U2 · U5**	Apple v11 C1/C4	p22; p26; recon S2.10	**CONFLICT → resolved**
About thirty build tracks (C1 says 15+)	**S2 · U1**	Apple v11 C2 vs C1	p24 vs p21–22; recon S2.11	**CONFLICT → resolved**
About fifteen months (C2 says fourteen; log spans 2024-03-17 → 2025-10-01)	**S2**	Apple v11 C1 vs C2	p21 vs p23–24; log Created min/max	**CONFLICT → resolved**
Locus retail testing slipped three weeks	**S2 · U5**	Apple v11 C2	p24	**Y**
≈$1.6M/yr = 0.88 + 0.22 + 0.45 + 0.10 = $1.65M; ≈$2.2M one-time = $7.5M × 0.293	**S2 · U2 · U4 · U5**	Master cb91	S2 model rows p12–17; recomputed in S2 tables (31,300 h × $28 = $876,400)	**Y, derived**
Illustrative base: 100K units/week; 120 FTE × 2,000 h; $50M × 25% × 60% = $7.5M	**S2 · U2 · U4**	Master cb91	S2 model rows; labeled illustrative	**illustrative**
THE 836-ROW ISSUES LOG — RECOMPUTED WITH PANDAS (NO CLOSE-DATE COLUMN EXISTS)				
836 rows; 714 closed = 85.4%	**S2 · U1 · U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	col Status; Apple v11 C2 p24	**Y**
Blocker 164 + Critical 277 = 441 = 52.8% (52.75%)	**S2 · U1 · U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	col Severity; Apple v11 C2 p24	**Y, rounding**
B+C closed 432 = 98.0%; open 9 (1 Blocker, 8 Critical)	**U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	cols Severity × Status	**Y, derived**
Closure by severity 99.4 / 97.1 / 75.4 / 69.7 / 60.0%	**U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	cols Severity × Status	**Y, derived**
Flows 238 · 172 · 113 · 90 · 62 = 675 (80.7%); Retail is 171 in Apple	**U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	col Operation, exact-label match; Apple v11 C2 p24	**Y, rounding**
122 not closed = 112 explicit open + 10 blank status (Apple's five buckets sum to 112)	**U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas) vs Apple v11	col Status; Apple C2 p24	**CONFLICT → resolved**
Monthly new rows Feb 90 · Mar 91 · Jun 271 · Jul 65 · Aug 21 · Sep 14 · Oct 4 (not "weekly open counts")	**S2 · U5 · U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	col Created; Apple C2 p24 "monthly arc"	**Y**
June: 239 Go-Live category (88.2%); 140 B+C (51.7%); 242 closed (89.3%)	**U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	cols Created × Category / Severity / Status	**Y, derived**
Weekly new rows 68 → 160 → 34	**U5 · U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	col Created, ISO weeks around go-live	**Y, derived**
Owners IT/WMS 342 · Ops 111 · Locus-side 86 (10.3%)	**S2 · U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	col Owner; Apple v11 C2 p24, C3 p26	**Y**
Decay r = (4/271)^¼ = 0.349; half-life ≈ 20 days	**U7**	derived	from the monthly arc; modeled fit	**Y, derived**
42 physical-building rows (dock 23 · space 19 …); 39 closed; 0 open B+C	**U7**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	cols Area / Description; my label grouping, stated on the page	**Y, derived**
Two AFS rows (ID 716: 400 of 1,800 = 22.2%; ID 818: ~10-minute hold-feed latency)	**U6**	UDC issues log (xlsx, 836×19; pandas)	rows ID 716, ID 818	**Y**
S18 — WMS MIGRATION (MODIFIED)				
8 months, two DCs; team 14 core + 6 DC Ops	**S18**	Apple v11 D1	p28–29; resume p1	**Y**
~$1.8M budget, ~3% under (= $54,000)	**S18**	Apple v11 D1	p29	**Y, rounding**
Mocks 7.0% → 1.8% → 0.3% vs 0.5% tolerance published with Finance before mock one	**S18**	Apple v11 D2	p31; resume p1	**Y**
$20M pipeline of four projects, started the next month	**S18**	Apple v11 D1	p29	**Y**
≈$2.5M/month = $20M ÷ 8 (my division); $83,333/day; $875K = 10.5 d × $83,333	**S18**	derived from Apple v11 D1	recon S18.05; not banked	**Y, derived**
72-hour in-transit freeze; legacy read-only 30 days; hypercare exit < 2 blockers/day in week 3 of 4	**S18**	Apple v11 D1/D2	p29; p31	**Y**
RF devices: "hundreds"; three-to-four-day estimate; training +1.5 weeks; date held	**S18**	Apple v11 G2	p44–45	**Y**
Master "~100 of ~400 devices at cutover; paper-pick fallback; ≈$45K; ~19×" (removed from the spoken story)	**S18**	Master cb91 vs Apple v11	master S18 p96; Apple G2 p45 says tellings differ	**CONFLICT → resolved**
(0.5% − 0.3%) × $50M = $100K	**S18**	Master cb91	S18 model row; illustrative base	**illustrative**
U1 — NODE × CHANNEL × BUCKET-TRANSITION MATRIX (NEW)				

CLAIM	STORY	SOURCE FILE	PAGE / ROW	MATCH
Bucket inventory: one owning system per bucket; exactly-one-bucket rule; replay no-op; SAP movement types 101 · 311 · 601 · 701 · 702	**U1**	Master cb91	S1 p7 (discovery/design), p11 system map	**anchor only**
Worked trace: AFS 560 → 557 (one bucket); 554 if two; 560 if zero	**U1**	derived	U1 table 2; illustrative units	**illustrative**
6 node-channel pairs · 14 events · 61 live cells; 4 in-transit cells + 3-case de-aggregation family added	**U1**	illustrative / master	VERIFY pill on page; Recon S4.04	**illustrative**
30,000 incidents/yr ÷ 61 = 491.8 × $30 = $14.8K; 61 cells × 4 h × $110 = $26.8K; break-even ≈ 1.8 cell-classes	**U1**	derived	U1 table 4; $30 and $110/h benchmark inputs	**illustrative**
U2 — PROFILE BOTH BOOKS BEFORE THE DESIGN (NEW)				
Two books (MCS, S/4); discovery 3/29 → 4/30; node sessions across ~15 functions	**U2**	Master cb91 · Apple v11	S1 p7; Apple C4 p28	**Y**
Release f(ρ, σ) = 1 − √((1+ρ)/2) family; 29.3% ceiling; 9.9% floor; $0.74M–$2.20M; 87% = 1.43 ÷ 1.65	**U2**	derived	U2 tables 2–4 (27 script checks)	**Y, derived**
Overlap sensitivity 40/60/80% → $1.46M / $2.20M / $2.93M; ≈260K self-transfer units/yr	**U2**	derived · master S2	U2 table 2; S2 model row	**illustrative**
U3 — MERCH RESERVE, THE PRICED NO (NEW)				
Three signing orgs; zero open “who owns this bucket” rows; 0 units of merch reserve in published AFS	**U3 · U6**	Master cb91	S1 p7; Apple E1 p33 says only “the business signed”	**anchor only**
p* = c/(g+c) = 36.7%; −$50K and −$202K per 10,000 units at a 20% release (illustrative); asymmetry 1 : 6.3	**U3**	derived	U3 tables 1–4 (24 checks)	**Y, derived**
30,000,000 orders × 0.10% = 30,000 oversell incidents (benchmark 0.05–0.25%)	**U3 · U6**	Master cb91	S1 model rows; Recon S1.12	**illustrative**
U4 — WHERE THE NODE’S CONSTRAINT BOUND (NEW)				
94% vs 98%; throttle ~30%; max safe share 33.3%; 6,000 vs 2,000 mis-picks; 28.6σ	**U4**	Apple v11 C3 · derived	p26; U4 tables 1–3	**Y, derived**
4,615 → 4,013 h/wk (240,000 h ÷ 52; ÷ 1.15); +421.4 h = 10.5 people-weeks at 40 h; $11,799 at $28	**U4**	derived	U4 table 2 (40 checks); $28 loaded rate = master S2 modeled input	**Y, derived**
4,200 mis-picks avoided × $12 = $50,400; break-even $2.81; ratio 4.3	**U4**	derived	U4 table 4; $12 is an illustrative input	**illustrative**
$2.2M ÷ $25 = 88,000 units × 0.25 ft³ = 22,000 ft³; ~92 days of float Jul 1 → Oct freeze	**U4**	derived · NACF booklet	unit cube from CAP-C; calendar	**illustrative**
U5 — 343-TASK RUNBOOK (NEW)				
Window May 1 → Jul 1 = 61 days	**U5**	calendar · Apple v11 C1/C2	31 + 30 days	**Y**
Steps 1–4 of the six-step choreography; three invariants (Σ AFS conserved; never sellable on 800 and 900; negatives first)	**U5**	Master cb91	S2 p16 (cutover invariants); steps 5–6 and invariants 4–6 absent	**anchor only**
$1.65M ÷ 52 = $31,731 a week; 814.75 h × $110 = $89.6K = 2.8 weeks	**U5**	derived	U5 tables 2–4 (32 checks)	**Y, derived**
24 events ≈ $714; 0.02⁴ vs 0.02; 680 units conserved (three-SKU trace)	**U5**	derived	U5 trace; illustrative units	**illustrative**
Day-one plan 280,000 units · 40 stores · 7 inbound appointments	**U5**	Loop packet	amazon-l6-scm-loop-packet.html only; not in Apple or master	**anchor only**
U6 — NEGATIVE AFS AND THE CORRECTION SCREEN (NEW)				
Worked SKU: basis 25, 35 committed → −10; −5 → −2 → 0; ≤15-minute feed; <5-minute consumer lag	**U6**	Master cb91	S1 p11 system map; worked SKU illustrative	**illustrative**
Critical ratio 1 ÷ (1 + 6.3) = 13.7%; reconciliation 4 → 1 FTE × $110K = $330K	**U6**	derived · Master cb91	U6 tables; S1 model row	**Y, derived**
U7 — THE ISSUES LOG AS READINESS INSTRUMENT (NEW)				
836 × 0.5 h × $110 = $45,980 ≈ 1.45 weeks of $31,731; z = 1.50 (directional)	**U7**	derived	U7 tables 2–4 (95 checks); basis modeled	**Y, derived**
BRIDGE, ROUTER AND BEHAVIORAL PACKS				
120,000 units/day → 5 doors; +13.6% hours; 49.0% true utilization; dwell 13.3 h → 40 h (3.0×); ≈14 flex heads; p* = 25%	**Bridge**	NACF booklet	CAP-A · CAP-B · CAP-C · CAP-D · CAP-E · INV-D	**Y**
Real AIQB wordings: 16 LPs, router + 36 behavioral questions	**all**	AIQB Reference Guide	128 questions parsed; cited as “AIQB: LP Q#”	**Y**
9.7× (7 → 68); never a fifty-times multiplier; $0.66 → $0.03; six sites; S14 $10M, S16 >$100K, S11 ~$1.5M	**guardrails**	Apple v11 A1 · recon §3	p6–7; recon items 1–5, 84–88	**Y**

62 grouped claims; every arithmetic row above stands for the full set of recomputed steps in the story’s four tables.